The Totality Engine

Ten Days Before Totality

Jacob Verhoeks

2026

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This is a work of fiction. Its characters, conspiracies, companies, motives, and hidden connections are products of the author's imagination. The novel uses real places, public institutions, technologies, foods, buildings, and the total solar eclipse of 12 August 2026 as setting. Nothing in the story alleges undisclosed conduct by any real organization or person.

The organizations Lenticular Systems, Guaita Event Resilience, Institut Llum, Yulan Microdevices, Llevant Import, Llebeig Logística, Tramuntana Modular Services, and Narthex Conseil; the software systems Atlas, Antumbra, Ephemeris, and Shanhai-Coder; the Ingot hardware; and every act attributed to them are wholly fictional.

AI use: artificial-intelligence tools were used in making this book. They assisted in drafting and editing the English text and parts of the end matter, produced the first drafts of the Spanish, Catalan, and Dutch translations, and generated the front-cover artwork. Every creative decision, revision, and final approval is the author's own.

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For those who look up, and those who watch the watchers.

Ten days before the Sun goes out over Catalonia, a warehouse in Badalona receives a photograph of a shipment it never packed.

The same morning, a broadcast engineer finds his colleague's chair empty and an eleven-second film of a room that does not exist.

The label in the frame uses his wife's company name.

The typography is wrong.

Somebody has already decided who will be blamed when the darkness comes.

They are not spies.

They will have to do.

Prologue: Two Goals

Pedralbes, 10 May 2026. Ninety-four days before totality.

At 21:09, every phone in the room vibrated except Lin Qiao's.

Marc Escudé looked at his screen first. He had arranged the three phones along the edge of the workbench despite the signs asking visitors to silence them, each tuned to a different stream because he trusted none of the streams to stay alive for the whole match.

"Rashford," he said.

The shout reached them a second later from the open window, thin after its journey from a bar somewhere beyond the university buildings. Marc slapped the bench. The instruments jumped in their foam cut-outs.

Lin watched the load graph.

The line did not move.

Her own phone was in a locker outside the controlled room, powered down inside a radio-shielding pouch. She was not here for the Clásico. She was here to learn whether an empty case could pass as a legitimate instrument until August, when the case would not be empty.

"Your city has scored," she said. "My equipment remains unimpressed."

"Our city," Marc corrected. "For tonight."

He was smiling too broadly to care whether she accepted the amendment. Behind him, through the glass partition, three black cases stood open beneath the white service lights. Identical aluminium frames occupied each one. Empty cradles, coolant couplings, power conditioners, and enough sensor wire to make emptiness look expensive.

The cases had entered the Institut Llum annex that afternoon under a real work order. Lin's passport was real. Her contract with Yulan Microdevices was real. The accelerator pilot named on her visitor record existed, and every measurement she would submit on Monday would withstand inspection.

Only the purpose of the measurements was false.

She touched the orange device wired to the first cradle. It looked like a toy left among laboratory equipment, small screen, white buttons, a cartoon dolphin etched into the case. The annex allowed no visitor laptops past the lockers. That afternoon the guard had turned the device over, asked what it was and written *serial console, Yulan field kit, radio functions disabled* in the equipment log after reading the vendor's note. Yulan's field engineers carried them for that reason: a sealed box with a screen and no keyboard passed doors a laptop did not. The custom service application removed the joke. Three current values, one coolant return temperature, one line waiting for a response from hardware that was not there.

Ingot would answer that line in August.

If the rehearsal worked.

Marc returned to his chair but did not sit. A muted stream showed the stadium from high above the pitch. The new tiers were bright; the unfinished parts beyond them disappeared into work lights and shadow. The club had returned home before the building was finished. Lin understood the engineering compromise better than the emotion around it.

“Nine minutes,” she said.

“You timed the goal?”

“I timed the load.”

The match had turned the occupied annex into useful cover. A large event nearby gave the network team a reason to record unusual traffic. Marc thought she was conscientious.

What she needed was simpler: whether one sealed case could enter with two legitimate instruments, draw six kilowatts, and remain administratively boring.

“Run two,” she said.

Marc dragged his attention from the match and read the checklist. “Simulated cold start, load profile B, telemetry bridge isolated.”

Lin pressed the centre button on the Flipper. The first cradle began to draw power through its dummy load. Fans rose inside the case with a dry mechanical rush. The graph climbed, held, and settled exactly where it had in Shenzhen.

The second row on her display remained blank.

“Bridge?” Marc asked.

“Waiting.”

“It waited yesterday.”

“Yesterday it answered after four seconds.”

At seven seconds, the return appeared. Marc wrote the number on his form.

Lin did not. Seven seconds was within the approved tolerance and outside hers. A prototype that waited three extra seconds in May could miss its cooling reservation in August. Miss that, and the controller would reduce the load. Ingot would spend the eclipse running like an expensive heater while the model remained too large to move.

She started the test again.

Marc’s three phones vibrated.

This time the shout outside came almost with them. A chair scraped in the next room. Someone yelled *dos* from the corridor, though Lin could not tell whether it was the score or an instruction.

Marc looked at the stream. “Ferran. Eighteen minutes.”

The second test answered in four seconds.

“Your equipment prefers Torres,” he said.

“My equipment prefers repeatability.”

“Nobody prefers repeatability in a Clásico.”

He left to find the technician in the corridor, taking one phone and abandoning two. Lin heard rapid Catalan, a laugh, then the opening commentary turned up in another room. The annex had not emptied for the match. It had become porous to it. Score alerts crossed doors that access cards could not. People who had spent the afternoon disagreeing over cable ownership now stood together around a small screen.

Lin closed the first case.

The tamper seal on the third case was wrong.

She kept her hand on the lid and looked through the glass. Marc's chair was empty. The corridor beyond him was empty. In the next room, the commentator's voice rose and fell above an argument about a foul.

Lin bent closer.

The seal carried the correct number. She had recorded it at the hotel, at the loading bay, and again when the cases entered the annex. The digits matched. The material did not. Yulan used a clear film that fractured into narrow white lines when lifted. This one had been printed to resemble those lines. From standing height it appeared broken and resealed. Close up, the damage was an image.

Someone had copied a used seal and applied the copy intact.

Her phone was in a locker two doors away. She did not call Marc. A person who could copy the seal number could read the test schedule. A person who knew the schedule could know who had been left alone with her.

Lin opened the case.

Nothing seemed disturbed. Empty cradle. Braided hoses. Dummy load. Two coiled data leads held by blue ties. The mass on the shipping record was correct because she had watched it weighed. The pressure marker on the coolant loop remained green.

She connected the Flipper to the maintenance lead.

No response.

The dummy controller should have answered even with the load powered down. She unplugged the lead and checked its end. The connector was clean. She followed the cable into the foam and found it folded beneath the cradle instead of seated in the controller.

An inspection, then. Quiet, careful, and hurried enough to leave one cable loose.

Nothing had been added. Nothing had been taken. Whoever opened the case wanted to know whether Ingot was already inside.

Lin reconnected the cable. The controller answered in three seconds.

She photographed nothing and touched as little as possible. A copied seal was not proof she could use without explaining why it frightened her. Reporting it would bring an inventory inspection, questions to Yulan, and the end of the August slot. Silence preserved the operation. It also preserved the intruder's access.

Lin closed the lid over the copied seal.

She chose August.

Marc returned carrying paper cups and a bottle of water. "You missed the replay."

"Someone opened case three."

His smile vanished. He set the cups down. "Here?"

"The seal was replaced. The maintenance cable was disconnected."

He looked through the glass at the cases. "Could it have happened in transit?"

"Yes."

"But you don't think it did."

"No."

Marc picked up his phone. Lin put two fingers on his wrist before he could unlock it.

"What are you doing?"

“Calling security.”

“And telling them what?”

“That somebody opened visiting equipment inside a controlled annex.”

“The copied seal has the correct number. There is no damage and nothing missing. You will close the building for an empty case.”

“That is what security is for.”

“It is what records are for. Security will ask when we last verified the seal. You will say the loading bay. They will inspect the cameras and the access log. If they find nothing, what will your report say?”

He understood the trap. A report without evidence would become evidence about them. It would mark the August job for scrutiny, perhaps cancellation. Marc did not know why that mattered to her. He believed he was protecting a research booking from an embarrassing delay. That belief was one of the things Lin had come to test.

“We record it in our own handover,” he said.

“Yes. Cable found loose after transport. Reseated. Test passed.”

“That is not what happened.”

“It is what we can prove.”

The match played behind them. Lin could see its changing light reflected in the glass, blue shirts moving across the open cases. Marc looked at the fake damage on the seal, then at her.

“Who are you expecting in August?”

The question was quiet enough to belong only to the room.

Lin unplugged the Flipper. “A heavier dummy load.”

Marc gave a single humourless laugh. He had offered her the chance to answer him. She had declined it.

They completed the remaining tests without mentioning the seal again. Marc wrote the loose cable into the local worksheet but did not upload it. Lin let each cradle run for the full match, long past the point the approved plan required. The response times settled. Cooling held. The empty frames behaved as Ingot would behave if the models were right.

On the screen, Madrid searched for a goal that never came.

At 22:51, the room erupted.

Doors opened along the corridor. Somebody produced a scarf from beneath a lab coat. Marc stood with both hands flat on the bench, watching the celebrations inside the stadium. He did not shout. His face changed instead, the suspicion of the third case briefly displaced by something older.

“Champions,” he said.

The word travelled through the annex in several voices. *Campions.* Lin heard horns outside, more every second. The city had been waiting for permission.

She packed the Flipper into its plain black pouch. The three cases would stay in the annex until Monday morning, when an approved carrier would remove them. Their seals no longer meant anything.

“You should wait,” Marc said. “The metro will be impossible.”

“That is why I am leaving now.”

He studied her. “You knew the result would give you cover?”

“I knew either result would create movement.”

“That may be the least football answer anyone has given tonight.”

“It is the only one I have.”

His smile returned, but incompletely. He walked her to the outer desk. She returned the annex badge, collected her powered-down phone, and signed the equipment log. Her name sat among technicians, cleaners, a cooling contractor, and two researchers who had left before kick-off. Lin read the list twice. On the second pass, the ordinary names looked arranged.

Outside, Pedralbes had changed.

Scarves appeared at windows. Scooters answered one another with their horns. People moved down Carrer de Jordi Girona towards the larger streams forming near Diagonal, some heading for the stadium, others for bars or friends or nowhere in particular. Construction cranes stood above Camp Nou in the distance, red lights fixed over a city that had decided not to stand still.

Lin walked east first.

The grey EBRO waited across the street.

She had seen it at eighteen minutes past seven near the loading entrance, parked in a legal space with nobody visible inside. It had gone when she checked at half-time. Now it stood beneath a plane tree with its lights off and its front wheels angled towards the road.

She kept walking.

The EBRO pulled out after twelve seconds.

Lin did not hurry. Running confirmed fear and separated a person from a crowd. She joined three generations of a family carrying flags, the grandfather moving slowly with a cane while a girl on his shoulders sang one line of an anthem and invented the rest. The EBRO passed them, stopped at the next junction, then rolled forward again.

It was too visible.

A competent surveillance driver could have stayed farther back or let another car take the position. This driver wanted her to notice. Either the person behind the wheel was careless, or the pursuit was a message.

The family turned towards Palau Reial. Lin turned with them.

At the tram stop, the platform was already full. Nobody waited in a line because there was no line capable of containing the mood. A man opened a bottle of cava and lost half of it to the pavement. Two women in white Madrid shirts accepted paper cups from him and endured the surrounding advice with practised contempt.

The EBRO stopped beyond the platform.

Lin could not see the driver through the reflections on the windscreen. The car could not follow a tram, not closely, and every arriving carriage was packed. That made the tram the obvious escape and therefore the wrong one.

She let the first carriage leave without her.

The family with the cane boarded. The girl waved through the glass. Lin waved back.

The EBRO remained.

She crossed Diagonal with a group moving against the light under the temporary authority of celebration. Horns objected. Nobody listened. On the far side she entered a small restaurant where the television showed the trophy presentation and every table faced away from the door.

The owner looked at the black pouch in her hand and the unzipped equipment bag on her shoulder. “Kitchen is closed.”

“I need the toilet.”

“Customers only.”

Lin placed ten euros beside an untouched plate at the end of the bar.

The owner looked at the note, then at her face. “Back left.”

There was no second exit in the toilet. There was one in the corridor before it, a fire door opening into a service lane blocked by recycling bins. Lin pushed through and the alarm did not sound. A cook smoking beside the bins glanced at her, decided her choices were none of his concern, and moved one foot to let her pass.

She walked two blocks south before taking out her phone, removing it from the pouch, and powering it on.

Messages arrived in layers: Yulan logistics, the hotel, three score alerts she had not requested, a photograph from an unknown number.

The photograph showed her hand resting on the third case.

It had been taken through the glass partition at 21:21, three minutes after the second goal. Marc was visible in the corridor beyond her, back turned. The angle placed the photographer inside the annex.

Beneath the image were six words in Mandarin.

You are rehearsing the wrong escape.

Lin powered the phone down and returned it to the pouch.

Behind her, Barcelona celebrated a championship. Ahead, a man in a Barça shirt dragged a plastic chair into the street for his mother. Somebody struck a drum with no rhythm and found one after three attempts.

She did not look back at the annex windows. The photograph had already been taken from inside.

Part One: Afterimage

Barcelona, ten days before totality.

Chapter 1: The False Shipment

At 07:52 on Sunday, ten days before the eclipse, the first photograph said Llevant had shipped equipment to a town where it had no customer.

Mei Zhou enlarged the label until the pixels separated.

ECLIPSE CONTRIBUTION ENCODERS. Five pieces. Three hundred and eight kilograms. Origin: Llevant Import, Badalona. Destination: a temporary municipal store near one of the southern viewing areas.

The pallet in the freight forwarder's photograph was wrapped in cloudy plastic. Five plywood cases showed beneath it. Someone had used Llevant's tax number, telephone number, and old warehouse logo. They had even used the short internal description Mei's father preferred because the full product names did not fit on his paper stock cards.

They had not used Llevant's label.

The typography was wrong. The destination block occupied the wrong corner. Llevant printed handling instructions in Catalan first, then Spanish. This one began in English. The differences would be invisible to anyone who did not spend mornings rejecting deliveries for errors smaller than these.

The freight forwarder had sent four images with a message in careful Spanish.

Please confirm shipper. Receiving authority refuses storage fees. Driver says urgent eclipse programme.

Mei called her father.

"It isn't ours," he said before she finished.

"You looked at the photos?"

"I looked at Saturday's stock cards. We did not pack five of anything. Tell them they have the wrong Zhou."

"There is only one Zhou on the label."

"Then tell them that one is asleep. It is Sunday."

She heard a television behind him and metal spoons in bowls. Her mother said something too far from the phone for Mei to catch.

"Mama says don't call the police," her father translated.

"Mama says that before she knows the question."

"She knows the question. It is always paperwork or police."

"Somebody put our name on equipment for the eclipse."

The television went quiet.

Her father answered in the family's own language. He did that when a sentence belonged to the family before it belonged to the business.

“Handle it before Monday,” he said.

Mei understood what he meant. By Monday the municipal store might call a public office. A public office might call a newspaper. A false pallet would become a Chinese pallet before anyone established who had made it. The warehouses of Badalona Sud would supply the photograph even if the shipment had never passed through them.

“Send me the stock cards,” she said.

“Paper doesn’t travel by telephone.”

“A photograph of paper does.”

“Then it is no longer paper.”

He ended the call.

At 08:21 Mei left Walden 7 with coffee in a steel cup. Arnau’s cup sat washed beside the sink. He had gone at seven for the rehearsal. A note on the counter said lunch Monday, not Sunday, because Marta had changed the time again.

The building’s red corridors held the night’s warmth. Two neighbours were watering plants in the courtyard. One asked whether she was working on a Sunday. Mei said only until the problem understood it was Sunday too.

The roads east were almost kind. The air over Barcelona had the white thickness of a hot day already decided. Radio presenters discussed the eclipse, the traffic it would bring, whether the sea was unusually warm, and which six planets might be visible before dawn. Every subject had become the eclipse if a producer waited long enough.

Arnau called as she joined the C-31.

“If this is about lunch,” she said, “your aunt has already changed the time twice. I am not negotiating with both of you.”

“I need you to look at a label.”

“That is worse than lunch.”

The still arrived while she waited at a light that had no reason to stay red. The first call dropped when a truck of bottled water cut between masts. She pulled into a loading bay, enlarged the image, and called him back.

Five of five, English first, HOME where Llevant never printed it.

“It uses our words,” she said. “Not our label.”

“How can you tell?”

“We write the category in Catalan for local stock and Spanish for export. Home comes from one supplier’s English catalogue, but we never print it. And five of five is not how we split a delivery. Which product number?”

“There isn’t one visible.”

“Then it is not a warehouse label. It is somebody’s idea of one. Where is the box?”

“I don’t know.”

She watched a truck of bottled water turn towards the coast. “Where is Oriol?”

“I don’t know that either.”

“Come home.”

“We have a rehearsal.”

“You have a missing colleague whose private file carries my company name.”

The line ended before she could ask whether he had already told Reixac. That was the question of a woman still hoping the problem would stay private until Monday.

The alarm company called as Mei entered Badalona.

“A collection driver is at unit two,” the operator said. “Reference five-one-seven. The system shows manager approval.”

“Which manager?”

“Mei Zhou.”

“Cancel it.”

“The reference is already active.”

“Then make it inactive.”

“The driver has been authenticated.”

“The driver may be real. The collection isn’t. Keep the shutter closed.”

She arrived seven minutes later. A white van occupied half the service lane. A magnetic placard on its door read **LLEBEIG LOGÍSTICA**, applied slightly crooked. The driver stood beside a pallet jack and held his phone towards the warehouse camera.

He looked relieved when Mei got out of the car.

“Finally.”

“Who opened the shutter?”

“Nobody. Your alarm people said a manager was coming.”

“Good. Stay there.”

She entered through the personnel door, disabled the alarm with her own code, and opened the loading shutter only to knee height.

Metal shuddered above the concrete. A blade of sunlight caught the front wheels of the pallet jack. The driver bent over its handle to look through the gap.

“Problem?” he called.

“Paperwork.”

“I sent it.”

“That is the problem.”

He slid three pages under the shutter in a clear sleeve. Page one named Llevant correctly, including its unit, tax number, and loading contact. Page two listed five Yulan evaluation systems received on 23 June. Page three authorized release and carried Oriol Cendrós’s name beneath **CLIENT TECHNICAL REPRESENTATIVE**.

His signature was a clean blue line, too balanced to have been written on a phone.

“Who gave you this?” Mei asked.

“Dispatch.”

“Who requested the collection?”

“The client.”

“I am the client.”

The driver straightened. “Then you requested it.”

“Do I sound surprised enough?”

He looked back at the van. His irritation looked professional, not threatening. Somebody had sent him across the metropolitan area on a Sunday and put the lie in his hands. Mei preferred him irritated. Frightened people improvised.

“Call the number on the order,” she said. “Put it on speaker.”

“Use your own phone.”

“I know I am not the customer. You are still deciding.”

He called.

A recorded voice announced a logistics service in Catalan and Spanish. The driver entered an extension. Four seconds of music, then a man answered.

“Collection five-one-seven,” the driver said. “Client is refusing release.”

He listened.

“He says your systems manager approved it.”

“Name?”

The driver asked. “Mei Zhou.”

“Ask him to describe me.”

The driver stared beneath the shutter.

“Ask.”

The answer took longer.

“Chinese woman,” he said.

“Ask what colour my car is.”

The call ended.

“Now you have a problem too,” Mei said.

She read the serial list.

Four numbers matched Yulan’s advance manifest. The fifth ended in `8B7`, the number in Llevant’s inventory system.

The physical case ended in `887`.

One curved line separated them. Yulan had sent a blurred scan. Mei corrected the paper receiving sheet but left the database unchanged because the supplier’s evaluation portal already used the wrong number. Fixing one system would break the warranty record in three others. She wrote the discrepancy into the red exceptions ledger instead.

The false collection order had copied the database error.

So had the pallet in the south.

Whoever made both could read Llevant’s digital stock record but had not seen the case. The red ledger could prove it.

A chime sounded from the office behind her.

One note, repeated twice. Not the intrusion alarm. The warehouse system announcing that a door recorded as open had closed.

“Did you come alone?” she asked.

“Yes.”

The driver answered quickly, but quick was not always false. “Five pieces, three hundred and twelve kilos. I don’t need a second man.”

“Your order says three hundred and eight.”

He checked his app. “Mine says three-twelve.”

Two versions of the same false job.

Mei pressed the shutter control. Metal descended the final distance and met the floor. The driver jumped back with his pallet jack.

“Wait in your van,” she called through the closed door. “Send me the order. You will need proof when dispatch denies this job existed.”

She turned towards the aisles.

Unit two had begun as a lighting showroom and expanded backwards whenever the next unit became available. The result was a building understood through work rather than plan: display rooms at the front, pallet racking behind, a narrow passage into unit one, two offices assembled from glass and plasterboard, and loading doors on opposite service lanes. Signs appeared in Catalan, Spanish, English, and Mandarin, depending on who needed to find what. None formed a complete map.

On weekdays the place carried forklift warnings, phones, radios, tape guns, and arguments about quantities. Sunday gave every small sound distance.

Mei took the office stairs two at a time. The door was locked. Through the glass she could see both laptops docked and the red ledger on the shelf.

Another chime sounded below.

The rear door had opened again.

She ran down the stairs, stopped at the corner of the first aisle, and listened. A shoe struck concrete. A metal push bar returned against its stop. Outside, an engine started without hurry.

Mei reached the rear loading bay in time to see a man enter a dark van. Blue shirt, ordinary trousers, nothing in his hands. The van pulled away.

A grey EBRO waited twenty metres farther down the lane.

For one second Mei expected it to follow her. Instead it moved after the van, keeping two vehicles between them at the turn.

Not one team.

She photographed both vehicles. The dark van’s plate was obscured by glare. The EBRO’s was readable and almost certainly irrelevant; a recent car could be hired, borrowed, or carrying plates that belonged to another recent car.

The neighbour in unit four raised his shutter and stepped out in sandals.

“Your delivery man came through here,” he said.

“Not the man at the front?”

“No. This one had a blue shirt. He showed me a badge and said your rear alarm was faulty. I let him through our yard.”

“What badge?”

“Television. Three something.”

Mei showed him no faces and supplied no names. She asked what he remembered first. Height. Hair. The hand holding the badge. Which way the van turned. Human memory before logs could teach it a cleaner story.

Upstairs, the office was still locked.

Mei opened it with her key.

The red ledger was gone.

Nothing else had moved. Cash remained in an unlocked drawer. Supplier contracts, customs notices, staff records, and three years of tax anxiety filled cabinets nobody had touched.

The ledger contained smaller truths: damaged cartons accepted against policy, serials corrected by hand, returns received after their credit note, a pallet stored overnight for a neighbour, five Yulan

boxes received during Sant Joan while firecrackers made telephone calls impossible. None of it was criminal. Much would look irregular to a person paid to remove context.

Her phone received three photographs from the courier and a final message.

Job cancelled. Client error. I was never inside.

Mei saved everything twice, called the police, and fetched the cage key.

Four Yulan boxes matched their receiving weights within the tolerance of the floor scale.

The fifth was eleven kilograms too light.

Joel Huang arrived while she was still on the scale, Sunday standby, keys already in his hand, the cousin who answered warehouse calls so she did not have to.

"I can finish this," he said.

"It is already finished. Photograph the display. Do not move the case."

He photographed it. He looked at the light case the way a person looks at a machine that has disappointed them, not at evidence. Mei filed that without knowing yet what it was.

She called Arnau.

"A man walked out of here with Oriol's badge," he said.

"Arnau, listen to me. They came for the five boxes. I stopped the shutter. While I was at the front they took the red ledger through the rear. The fifth case is eleven kilos light. Blue shirt. Dark van. A grey car followed the van, not me."

Metal no longer moved behind her. The shutter was down. The courier was gone.

"Do not stay there alone."

"Joel is here. So is the case. I have already called the police."

She looked at the empty shelf where the ledger had been.

"Somebody can read our stock system," she said. "They cannot read the book they just stole."

Joel was still looking at the case. She kept the phone at her ear until a siren turned into the industrial estate. It might have been theirs.

Chapter 2: Eleven Seconds

The same Sunday morning.

Oriol's chair was empty, his coffee was cold, and the eclipse had ten days left to become everybody else's problem.

Inside Lenticular's temporary contribution centre near the 3Cat studios, it had been everybody's problem since April.

Every screen arriving from 3Cat carried a version of the same black circle. The newsroom had a countdown clock. The weather desk had a horizon simulator. The children's channel had built a Moon from painted foam and hung it from a track in the ceiling. Somebody in food had commissioned a black rice segment and been told, after two meetings, that making an eclipse from squid ink might encourage unsafe viewing.

Arnau Vidal had spent three months moving video between all of them.

At 08:17 on Sunday morning, he stood beside Oriol's desk in the contribution room and read the last message again.

Need your eyes. Private screen. Eleven seconds.

It had arrived at 02:13. No file, no explanation, no apology for the hour. Oriol sent messages at two in the morning because he trusted the night to contain more time than the day. He normally followed them with three corrections before breakfast.

There had been no corrections.

"He's late," Berta Salvat said.

She entered carrying two coffees and the expression of a person who had already answered the same question on three programmes before most people woke. Her hair was tied up, her studio make-up unfinished around the eyes. One coffee went onto Oriol's desk. She kept the other.

"Thirty-seven minutes," Arnau said.

"You counted?"

"The rehearsal starts in twenty-three."

"That was not my question."

Arnau looked at the cold paper cup beside Oriol's keyboard. "He was here."

Berta touched it with the back of one finger. "Not recently."

On the central wall, twelve feeds showed twelve western horizons. School roofs, municipal squares, observatories, a football ground, a monastery terrace, two fields that looked identical until somebody pointed out that one was outside Tortosa and the other in Mallorca. Each carried a label, clock, ownership code, and contact number. On eclipse day there would be hundreds. Today there were supposed to be twelve because twelve was enough to make the rehearsal fail in interesting ways.

“Maybe he went downstairs,” Berta said.

“His badge is on the desk.”

The plastic card lay beneath a folded sheet of paper. Arnau lifted the paper without touching the badge. It was a printout from Shodan, the search engine Oriol used when he wanted to know which pieces of equipment had introduced themselves to the public internet without understanding the social consequences.

Most of the page was ordinary service information. A web server. A certificate. A product family. A timestamp from shortly before two that morning. Oriol had underlined a hostname twice in blue pen.

`ecl-llum-ped-03`

Across the upper margin, in green pencil and capitals, Oriol had copied somebody else’s claim:

PUBLIC BANNER ONLY. SAME CERT AS 147 / TOUR. SAVED BEFORE CHANGE. - P

The P was Pol. Oriol logged other people’s findings in green and his own in blue, and credited every line he had not checked himself.

At the bottom Oriol had written: **Not on contributor list. Same cert as 147. Ask why.**

“He printed the internet,” Berta said.

“One page of it.”

“Is that better?”

“For the toner.”

The exposed service was not a live camera. It reported only that a gateway was awake, how long it had been running and which software build it believed itself to be. The mistake looked harmless.

Arnau checked the contributor list on the isolated scheduling terminal.

No `llum`. No `ped`. No unit three.

“Could it be one of yours?” Berta asked.

“Lenticular names temporary encoders by event and region. We don’t put the client, site, and unit number in a public hostname unless we want strangers to solve a crossword.”

“So somebody else is careless.”

“Usually the answer.”

He searched the internal onboarding records. No result. Shodan had indexed a sign on a door; it had not told Oriol what was behind it.

It had not found the sign for Oriol either.

Pol worked infrastructure shifts for a food distributor by day. At night, two rented servers and a machine beneath his desk watched public services change. Other people called that hacking. Pol called it listening when machines introduced themselves too loudly.

Arnau called him.

Pol answered with a whispered obscenity and then, more awake, “Oriol?”

“Arnau. I have your printout.”

“Then where is Oriol?”

“Not here. Tell me what you found.”

There was movement on the line, a blind knocking sound and running water. Pol had probably slept beside the machine again.

“A public status page,” he said. “No login, controls or picture. My indexer saw it at 01:46 and I sent Oriol the independent record.”

“You did not enter anything?”

“There was nowhere to enter. It said the gateway was awake. That is all. A sign, not a door.”

Arnau looked at the certificate block. “And 147?”

“Same public identity as a contribution unit active during the Tour. Not the same box. The same family.”

“Is the page still there?”

“Fourteen minutes after Oriol replied, the name disappeared. Somebody noticed it was visible.”

“Can you prove the first version existed?”

“I kept the public response and its timestamp. I did not go past the sign.”

“Send me the archive.”

“I sent it to Oriol.”

“Send it to me.”

Pol stopped moving. When he spoke again, the sleep had gone from his voice.

“Arnau, why do you have his paper?”

Arnau looked at Oriol’s cold coffee. “Because he isn’t here to explain it.”

The archive arrived while they were still on the call. Two independent public observations and one documented change. Nothing in it opened a camera, named a room or explained why somebody had cleaned the page after Oriol saw it.

It preserved the question.

The folded paper held one more thing: a storage path written along the margin.

Arnau recognized Oriol’s private workspace on the rehearsal server. He entered the path. A single video file waited there, eleven seconds long.

“Private screen,” Berta reminded him.

The contribution room was a working broadcast environment. Unknown media did not belong on it. Arnau copied the path, not the file, and took Oriol’s printout to a small review booth across the corridor. The booth had no production controls and an inspection workstation kept for malformed submissions. If the video was broken, it could break something unimportant.

Berta followed.

“Rehearsal,” he said.

“Twenty minutes.”

“You have a countdown clock.”

“The countdown clock is why I need to know whether the man running the rehearsal has vanished.”

Arnau opened the file.

For eleven seconds, nothing happened.

A fixed camera showed a white equipment room. One wall, part of a door, the edge of a wheeled case. No people. No sound except ventilation. The picture darkened slightly at four seconds, recovered, then darkened again. An automatic camera correcting for somebody moving near a light, perhaps. The case stood too far from the lens to read its label.

“Again,” Berta said.

He played it again.

“The clock,” she said.

A small timestamp occupied the lower right corner. It advanced normally, paused, jumped forward, paused again. The file remained eleven seconds long. The clock inside the picture accounted for less.

Arnau advanced frame by frame.

“One point seven seconds missing,” he said.

“Twice?”

“The same amount twice.”

“Can compression do that?”

“Compression can do almost anything if you blame it vaguely enough.”

The file claimed one of Lenticular’s capture tools, but the identifier could be copied. Whoever made it wanted a technician to recognize the format and stop asking questions one step too early.

Berta leaned closer. “Can you enlarge the case?”

“I can make the pixels larger.”

“Do that.”

He froze the clearest frame and expanded it. The label became blocks of grey and white. Berta pointed to a dark line near the bottom.

“Letters?”

“Maybe.”

Arnau changed the contrast. He did not use invented enhancement or ask software to create detail the camera had never captured. The line became barely readable because it had been there all along.

`LLEVANT-HOME / BDN / 5 OF 5`

He sat back.

“You know it,” Berta said.

“Mei’s family company is Llevant Import. Badalona.”

“Do they supply us?”

“No. Household electronics, lighting, small appliances. Whatever a shop expects to sell six months from now.”

“Cameras?”

“Sometimes. Not broadcast equipment.”

Arnau sent Mei the still. She called back after studying it.

“It uses our words,” she said. “Not our label. Come home.”

“We have a rehearsal.”

“You have a missing colleague whose private file carries my company name.”

The booth door opened before Arnau could answer.

A man in a visitor lanyard stood outside. Mid-forties, short-sleeved blue shirt, no jacket despite the air conditioning, an accreditation card turned so its printed side faced his chest. He had the composed impatience of somebody accustomed to being allowed through the next door.

“Arnau Vidal?”

Arnau ended the call without saying goodbye. “Yes.”

“I am looking for Oriol Ferrer.”

“There is no Oriol Ferrer on this team.”

The man corrected himself too slowly. “Cendrós. My mistake. Compliance asked me to collect a test capture he made overnight.”

“Which compliance?”

“Contribution security.”

“That is not a department.”

The man’s gaze moved past him to the paused frame. It rested on the enlarged label, then returned to Arnau.

“The file is unauthorized,” he said. “It contains an image from a restricted technical area. Delete it and give me the source path.”

He did not ask whether Arnau had found the file. He knew.

Berta stepped into the doorway beside Arnau. She was recognizable enough that the man’s manner changed by one degree. Not surprise. Calculation.

“Show us your card,” she said.

“You are due in Studio Four.”

“Then you know who I am. It seems fair that I know who you are.”

The man turned the card.

The name read **SALVADOR RIERA**, contractor, visitor access. No company appeared beneath it. The photograph was correct. That proved only that somebody had printed the right face.

Berta took out her phone.

“I will ask reception who signed you in.”

“There is no need.”

“Good. It will be quick.”

Riera looked again at the screen. “Do not place that capture on the production network.”

“We agree on one thing,” Arnau said.

The man walked away before Berta made the call. He did not hurry. At the corridor turn he passed a floor manager running in the other direction and moved aside with the easy courtesy of a person who belonged there.

Berta lowered the phone. “Reception says his host is Oriol.”

“Oriol’s badge is on the desk.”

“A host can register a visitor in advance.”

“Did he?”

“Reception is checking.”

The rehearsal director called Berta’s name over talkback. Eleven horizons remained steady. The twelfth had turned blue.

“I have to go,” she said.

“Go.”

“Do not be noble while I am gone.”

“I was planning to be useful.”

“That is often how you begin.”

She left at a run.

Arnau closed the video without deleting it. The file belonged to Oriol’s private workspace, and he had no legitimate reason to copy it. He copied it anyway, to his own storage allocation, and knew

as he did it that he would have to say so. He had eleven seconds in his head, a Shodan printout in his hand, and the still he had already sent to Mei.

He returned to Oriol's desk.

The cold coffee remained. The badge did not.

Arnau stopped beside the chair.

He had left the plastic card beside Oriol's keyboard. The desk surface where it had lain showed a clean rectangle in a film of dust.

Riera had not come for the video.

The visitor needed his host's badge to leave through the internal gate without asking reception to correct the record.

Arnau went after him.

The contribution corridor opened into a larger production spine full of people moving equipment towards temporary rehearsal rooms. Arnau caught a glimpse of the blue shirt near the far doors. A lighting cart crossed between them. By the time it passed, Riera had gone.

Arnau reached the doors and badged through.

The next corridor offered three choices: reception, loading, or the stairwell to the parking level. He listened. A door closed below.

He took the stairs.

One floor down, the concrete air smelled of warm tyres and dust. A vehicle started. Arnau reached the parking lane as a dark van turned past the barrier. He saw no plate, only the brake lights and the outline of a driver. The barrier lifted without the driver presenting a ticket.

Oriol's badge reader flashed green inside the booth.

Arnau ran to the pedestrian door. It refused his production badge. He pushed the release. Nothing. By the time the attendant looked up from the far end of the booth, the van had joined the Sunday traffic.

His phone rang forty minutes later, while he was still giving the parking attendant a statement.

Mei.

He answered while walking back towards the stairs. "A man walked out of here with Oriol's badge."

"Arnau, listen to me."

Her voice had lost every trace of lunch.

"I am listening."

"They came for the five boxes. While I was at the front they took the red ledger through the rear. The fifth case is eleven kilos light. Dark van. A grey car followed it."

The parking lane smelled of warm tyres.

"Do not stay there alone."

"Joel is here. I have already called the police."

The badge reader in the booth went dark again. Upstairs, somebody called his name for the delayed rehearsal.

Arnau did not go back. He was already walking towards the street.

Chapter 3: Menú del Dia

Oriol had reserved a table for four.

The waiter told them after they sat down, placing four glasses around the white paper cloth before counting the people again.

"Senyor Cendrós called Saturday evening," he said. "One thirty, Monday. His usual table. Four menus."

Arnau looked at the empty chair.

"Did he say who was coming?" Berta asked.

"The difficult one, the famous one, and the woman cleverer than both."

The waiter assigned them with one pointing finger. Arnau was difficult. Berta was famous. Mei received the only compliment and accepted it without protest.

"And Oriol?" Arnau asked.

"He would be late."

"How late?"

The waiter looked at the empty chair, then at Oriol's untouched glass. "With Oriol, that is not a unit of time."

Arnau had waited for him at that table after failed broadcasts, funerals and the afternoon Reixac closed the archive project and called the decision focus. Oriol always arrived with an explanation that became less credible as it grew and then listened without trying to repair whatever Arnau told him.

The empty chair removed more than a person. It removed the one witness before whom Arnau had not needed to sound certain.

The waiter left four menus.

The restaurant served lunch to people who worked nearby and knew what food cost. Oriol liked it because Mercè refused reservations from almost everyone and made an exception after he repaired her television during a football final.

At 13:34, every table was occupied.

The room gave them safety through witnesses and danger through proximity. Cutlery, chairs, coffee cups, conversations in Catalan and Spanish. Anyone could hear one sentence. Nobody could hear all of them without trying.

Arnau turned Oriol's glass upside down.

Mei turned it back.

"We are not memorializing him," she said.

"I was making space."

"You were deciding what the empty chair means."

She knew what the restaurant meant too. Mei had met Oriol there before she married Arnau and watched him interrogate her about customs software until Mercè threatened to charge rent on the table. He had later made the wedding speech nobody requested and the only one Chen remembered.

"He registered Riera as a visitor five days before he disappeared."

"That means he registered Riera."

"It means the man who stole your ledger was invited into my building by my friend."

"Both statements are true. Only one is useful."

Berta opened the menu. "Can we establish whether Oriol is a traitor after ordering? Mercè will remove us herself if we occupy four seats and ask for water."

They ordered from the blue board. Berta requested coffee before the food.

"You have already had one," Arnau said.

"I have been discussing safe eclipse glasses since six fifteen. Coffee stopped being a beverage at eight."

Berta opened her tablet beneath the table edge.

"Gateway 147 joined the Tour de France contribution pool on the fourth of July," she said. "It carried public pictures from a temporary road position during the Barcelona start. The equipment owner was Guaita Event Resilience."

"Riera," Arnau said.

"Salvador Riera is the name on his visitor card. Guaita is not a Lenticular company. Salvador Reixac owns it privately. He controls both, separately."

"Two Salvadors."

"Catalonia contains more than one."

"Riera could be an alias."

"Or an employee. Or unrelated. This is why police officers did not arrest the continent for us."

Mei enlarged Berta's screenshot. "What did Guaita do for the Tour?"

"Temporary continuity support. Gateways, monitoring, road teams. One contractor among many."

"A distinction I wish more people made before lunch."

Salvador Reixac stood beside the empty chair.

Arnau had seen his employer angry twice in eleven years and could not remember either occasion involving a raised voice. Reixac did disappointment instead. He made the other person feel that a competent version of them had been expected and might still arrive if given another minute.

Today he wore linen trousers and a pale shirt with the sleeves folded once. No jacket, no assistant, nothing that explained why the founder of Lenticular had crossed Sant Joan Despí on foot to appear beside Oriol's table.

"Salvador," Arnau said.

"Arnau. Berta." Reixac turned to Mei. "Senyora Zhou. Llevant has supported half the independent retailers in Badalona longer than my company has existed. I am sorry our name has entered your warehouse in this way."

He pronounced *Llevant* correctly, with none of the careful spacing people used when they wanted credit for knowing the word was Catalan.

Mei did not invite him to sit. "Which of your names entered it?"

Reixac looked at the screenshot without leaning closer. “That is what our review will establish. Guaita supported one part of the Tour operation. Lenticular supported another. Credentials crossed boundaries they should not have crossed. It may be untidy rather than criminal.”

“Between two companies with one owner,” Mei said, “untidy is a decision.”

Reixac did not answer her.

“A man used one to steal Oriol’s badge,” Arnau said.

“A man used a visitor record created by Oriol. We have suspended it and every credential associated with it. The police have the logs.”

“He also took a file.”

“Then give our security team an exact copy.”

“The police have it.”

A pause. Not long enough to be objection, only long enough to make Arnau hear his own refusal.

“Good,” Reixac said. “We will work from their copy.”

Mercè appeared with three gazpachos balanced along one forearm. She stopped when she found a stranger standing at the fourth place.

“He is leaving,” Mei said.

Mercè waited for independent confirmation.

“I am,” Reixac said. “But the coffees are mine. All four.”

“There are three people,” Mercè said.

“Then the fourth can wait.”

He placed a card beside the bill.

“Senyora Zhou, send us the collection order and a photograph of the exceptions record that was taken. We can keep an inventory dispute from becoming a public story about an entire district.”

“I cannot photograph a missing book.”

“The red ledger, yes? Your husband mentioned it in his incident note.”

Arnau had written *paper exceptions record*. Not red.

Reixac turned to Berta. “They are looking for you in make-up. The afternoon producer has called twice.”

Berta checked the tablet she had kept face down. Its screen showed no missed calls.

“Then he can discover a third method,” she said.

Reixac smiled. Until then his patience had looked practised.

“Ten minutes. After that, staying becomes the report.”

He left them with four coffees ordered and none served.

Mei touched the edge of Arnau’s Shodan printout. “Did you tell him the ledger was red?”

“No.”

“Did the police?”

“Not in anything I saw.”

Berta slid the screenshot towards herself. “Guaita’s incident team received the warehouse report through Lenticular’s insurer. There may be a photograph.”

“There may be,” Mei said.

She did not sound reassured.

The gazpacho interrupted them. Mei ate three spoonfuls before continuing.

“The collection order and the southern pallet copied an error from our inventory database,” she said. “The last serial ends in B-seven in the system. The case says eight-seven. The paper ledger explained the difference.”

“Could a supplier have both?” Berta asked.

“Yulan’s portal has the wrong number because its scan created the error. But the order also had our exact unit, loading contact, and weekend format.”

“An employee?”

“Possible. A compromised account is possible. A supplier integration is possible. Possibility is cheap.”

“The fifth box was eleven kilos light,” Arnau said.

Mei rested her spoon in the bowl. “It still is.”

“What should it contain?”

“A catalogue inference appliance. Yulan described all five as identical evaluation systems. Product matching, translation, search. Their small local model saves us days of catalogue work.”

“Can you open it?”

“Physically, yes. Contractually, no. Breaking the prototype seal makes us responsible for the contents.”

“Somebody already opened one.”

“Somebody removed eleven kilos. I do not yet know when.”

“Sant Joan,” Berta said.

Mei looked at her.

“The boxes arrived on the twenty-third of June. The fake order says 23:41.”

“That time is wrong,” Mei said. “We stopped receiving before dinner. The system posted when somebody closed the batch. They arrived while the firecrackers were already going off, around seven.”

“Is that in the ledger?” Arnau asked.

Mei looked at the empty fourth chair. “It was.”

The main courses arrived. Botifarra browned at the edges, beans hot enough to carry garlic into the air, hake under onions cooked past the point of resistance. Arnau’s appetite had disappeared, which did not stop him eating. Food this good did not become evidence because the table was frightened.

Two Lenticular technicians entered, greeted Arnau, recognized Berta, and chose a table by the window. One glanced towards Oriol’s empty chair. News moved through workplaces before management decided what could be said.

“Why this restaurant?” Mei asked.

“Oriol’s usual place,” Arnau said.

“That answers why we chose it. Why did he choose it for us on Saturday?”

The reservation predated the Shodan search early Sunday. Oriol had expected the three of them to need this conversation before he found the ownerless gateway, or before he claimed to find it.

“Maybe the search was theatre,” Arnau said.

“The public page is real,” Berta replied.

“The discovery can be staged even when the thing discovered exists.”

“Now you sound like Júlia.”

“Who is Júlia?” Mei asked.

“Júlia Muntaner. Computer vision, Institut Llum. She helped design the eclipse image study using MareNostrum. Gateway 147 was briefly on her Tour research list. She removed it because its ownership record was incomplete.”

“Call her,” Arnau said.

“I did. She is coming here.”

Arnau looked at the fourth glass. The waiter had placed it for Júlia, not Oriol.

“Oriol did not reserve for himself,” Mei said.

Berta checked the time. “Júlia said one forty-five.”

It was 14:11.

A man in a blue shirt stood across the street, reading a parking sign with great attention. From the side, at distance, he could have been the visitor who called himself Riera. He could have been any man who chose blue in August.

“Do not stare,” Mei said.

“I am not.”

“You stopped chewing. It is the same thing from outside.”

Berta’s tablet vibrated against the table. She read the notification and did not touch it.

“Gateway three checked into the eclipse rehearsal pool at one thirty-nine,” she said. “The alert has only just reached me.”

“Who approved it?” Arnau asked.

“Nobody. It used 147’s Tour credential.”

“Location?”

“Pedralbes. Institut Llum.”

The man in blue crossed the street and passed without looking in.

Júlia’s chair remained empty.

Chapter 4: A Computer in a Chapel

Júlia Muntaner answered on the third call.

"Do not come to the restaurant," Arnau said.

"I wasn't going to."

Her voice reached him over ventilation and a fast sequence of keys.

"You said one forty-five."

"At one thirty-nine gateway three woke up. I went where it was."

"Institut Llum?"

The keys stopped.

"Who told you that?"

"The gateway."

"Gateways don't tell you where they are. People put places into hostnames because they enjoy regret."

"Then we regret the same address."

Júlia exhaled. "Are you with Berta?"

"And Mei."

"Bring the original printout. Not a photograph. Don't email anything."

"Why?"

"Because I would like one fact in this building to arrive without announcing itself first."

She ended the call.

Berta had already stood. Reixac's ten minutes were long gone.

"If I miss the afternoon link, somebody else will tell viewers that eclipse glasses work through binoculars," she said. "Then I will spend tomorrow explaining retinal burns with fruit."

She put Oriol's fourth coffee into a paper cup and carried it away. Mercè watched her do it without approval.

Arnau paid for the lunches despite Reixac's card beside the bill. Mercè pushed the card back towards him.

"Your important friend forgot this."

"He isn't my friend."

"Then you forgot it for him."

Outside, heat closed around them. The man in blue had gone. A delivery rider waited in the strip of shade beneath an awning, helmet balanced on one knee. Two Lenticular technicians smoked by the corner. Neither looked at Arnau.

"Your boss knows about my ledger," Mei said.

"He knows an insurer's version."

“That is not what I said.”

Arnau opened the car and waited for the trapped air to escape. “No.”

They drove west with the air conditioning at its loudest setting. Navigation offered three routes, withdrew two, and added nine minutes without explanation. Near Camp Nou, construction barriers made familiar turns temporary. Lenticular had run contribution circuits there in May. Guaita had handled crowd continuity on the same contract.

He had approved their shared timing plan.

“You are doing it again,” Mei said.

“What?”

“Treating everything you signed as something you caused.”

“I approved their access to our clock service.”

“In May. For a football match.”

“Gateway 147 first appeared during the Tour. Three is using its credential now. These are not separate mistakes.”

“No. But guilt is not a routing protocol. It does not follow every connection.”

The navigation sent them around another blocked turn.

Institut Llum occupied a postwar research building close enough to Torre Girona for visitors to assume they belonged to the same institution. They did not. A brass plaque named the institute. A temporary vinyl sign beneath it promised **ECLIPSE IMAGING 2026: OPEN DATA FOR A SHARED SKY**.

The slogan had survived three committees and meant nothing.

Júlia waited inside the entrance with her arms folded. She was shorter than Arnau expected, dressed in black despite the heat, with dark hair cut level at her jaw. Her age and the timing were enough to be useful and not enough to be evidence.

She looked first at Mei.

“You are Llevant.”

“I am Mei Zhou. Llevant is a company.”

“Sorry. Berta told me about the label.”

“Berta found time to phone you on her way to the studio?”

Júlia looked at Arnau. “You brought the printout?”

Mei did not move.

Arnau took the folded page from his pocket but kept hold of it. “Were you with Oriol on Friday?”

“For eleven minutes. He asked about an old gateway. I told him to reject it.”

“Why didn’t you sit?”

Júlia’s folded arms tightened against her ribs.

“Mercè remembers everybody,” she said.

“She remembers people who make Oriol serious.”

“That list is shorter.”

She turned and walked towards the stairs. Arnau followed. Mei waited long enough to make it clear that following was a choice.

The institute’s eclipse room contained no telescope and no view of the sky. It was a long laboratory with blackout blinds, three equipment bays, and a wall of test images from public cameras.

A mountain ridge. A municipal square. A church tower. A western horizon broken by apartment roofs. Each image had been printed at the same size and marked with time, lens, exposure, and a confidence score.

One bay was awake. A small status display showed gateway three connected to a rehearsal pool and sending no video.

“That is the public status page Oriol found,” Arnau said.

“No. That is the instrument behind it. The public page is a sign hung outside.” Júlia pointed to the display. “It checked in using a Tour credential. It has no camera attached and no reason to be here until the twelfth.”

“Can it reach MareNostrum?” Mei asked.

“Not directly. This room can submit approved work. Nobody walks a mysterious box into a supercomputing centre and plugs it into the national machine.”

“Good,” Mei said. “We already had one mysterious-box collection yesterday.”

Beyond an internal courtyard, through glass and distance, stood the old chapel the city put on posters. For almost twenty years it had held MareNostrum, racks where pews once faced the altar. The supercomputer had outgrown it. MareNostrum 5 filled a hall in the new building beside it, and the chapel now held the centre’s quantum computers, tall sealed cryostats under the vault, wired to the big machine across the yard. Visitors liked the contradiction. Arnau had always thought the machines made the building’s original purpose easier to understand. People still came to ask questions larger than the room.

Júlia held out her hand for the printout.

Arnau gave it to her.

She read the hostname, the certificate note, and Oriol’s handwriting. She stopped at **Same cert as 147**.

“Where is the clip?”

“With police. And on a review workstation at Lenticular.”

“Nowhere else?”

“My private storage.”

“Which Lenticular backs up.”

“It is still my allocation.”

“That sentence has kept lawyers in houses since the invention of tape.”

She moved to the active bay and opened a local inspection view. Arnau watched her hands rather than the screen. She did not search for gateway three. She entered its identifier from memory.

“You rejected 147 from the Tour study,” he said.

“Its ownership field was blank.”

“You remember every rejected gateway?”

“I remember the ones that come back.”

The display filled with timing values. No pictures, no controls, only the gateway’s account of its own clock and the rehearsal service’s account of when packets had arrived. The two disagreed by 1.7 seconds.

Then agreed.

Then disagreed again.

“The missing time in Oriol’s clip,” Arnau said.

“Not missing.” Júlia leaned closer. “Partitioned.”

“Meaning?”

She hesitated for half a second. It was the first delay in anything she had done.

“Camera clocks drift and jump. You compare them against a common event.”

“Such as an eclipse,” Mei said.

“Approximately. The light falls across the country on a known curve.”

“Why would gateway three add the same error twice?”

Júlia moved one window aside. A small table divided eleven seconds into three islands of corrected time.

“It is testing whether a correlator notices the discontinuity,” she said.

“Which correlator?”

“The eclipse study.”

“You said the study corrects clocks.”

“It does.”

“This is correcting the correction.”

Júlia closed the table.

The laboratory door opened behind them.

“Doctor Muntaner. You found our ghost.”

Marc Escudé entered carrying a ring of keys and two bottles of water. He had the easy, settled manner of a technician in his own building. His shirt bore the Institut Llum sunburst. A red-and-blue football cord held his identification card.

Júlia introduced them.

At Llevant’s name, Marc offered Mei one of the bottles. “You have had a difficult weekend. Salvador called.”

Mei did not take it. “Which Salvador?”

Marc laughed. “Reixac. He said Arnau might arrive upset and that the police would need anything we found.”

“I am not upset,” Arnau said.

“Then he was wrong about one thing.”

Marc inspected the status display. His attention moved directly to the connection time, not the repeated offset.

“This unit was meant to stay isolated,” Júlia said.

“It is isolated.”

“It joined the contribution rehearsal pool.”

“Then somebody left a cable mapped from May. We tested three instruments during the football load. Temporary work becomes permanent if nobody is paid to remove it.”

“Who ran the test?” Arnau asked.

Marc took a tablet from the bay and opened the project bookings. He did not ask why Arnau needed to know. Helpful people either trusted you or wanted to choose the facts you saw.

The May entry listed three low-power telemetry emulators. All had checked out after the Clásico. A second booking reserved the same three instrument identities for 12 August, from late morning until the eclipse processing window closed.

Project specialist: **Dr Lin Qiao**.

Local contact: **Marc Escudé**.

“She was conscientious,” Marc said. “Better documentation than most visiting engineers. She even replaced a transport seal that tore.”

“Which instrument?” Mei asked.

Marc scrolled. “The third.”

Mei and Arnau looked at each other.

Five of five. Gateway three. The third instrument. Numbers wanted to become a pattern before facts had earned one.

Júlia photographed the booking with an institute camera, logged the export, and handed the copy to Arnau. Every step was correct. Marc watched her complete them.

“I will isolate the gateway,” he said.

“Don’t,” Júlia replied.

He looked genuinely surprised.

“If it disappears now, whoever woke it learns that we found it. Route it into a closed test pool and let it believe the rehearsal is running.”

“I will need approval.”

“Get it.”

“From Salvador?”

“From the project owner.”

“Guaita is the continuity partner. Salvador owns Guaita.”

For one moment nobody in the room moved.

Then Marc smiled, apologetic on behalf of an organizational chart. “I will word the request carefully.”

He left with both bottles of water.

Júlia waited until the door closed.

“We have perhaps three minutes before Reixac knows exactly what we opened,” she said.

“He already knew we were coming,” Mei replied.

Arnau pointed to the table Júlia had closed. “What is the correlator?”

“An abandoned research method.”

“Name?”

“It didn’t have one.”

She said it too quickly.

Arnau moved to the wall of camera images. The confidence numbers did not follow geography. Two neighbouring Barcelona views sat far apart. A camera in Tarragona was grouped with one in Girona. The clusters made no sense as weather, landscape, or astronomy.

“This study isn’t mapping the eclipse,” he said.

Júlia looked past him towards the chapel and the machine hall beside it.

“No,” she said. “It is mapping the cameras.”

Footsteps returned on the stairs. Two sets.

They belonged to students looking for the roof. Marc had left to request permission to isolate the gateway and had not returned.

In the institute's small meeting room, Ephemeris refused to help in twenty-three seconds.

Arnau had removed the names, addresses and credentials. He gave it only three records that should not have known one another: public gateway metadata, timing from the authorized Tour capture and the false collection order. He asked whether they could share an operator.

I can't assist with correlating network reconnaissance, captured radio traffic, and access or shipment records in a way that could identify or facilitate access to public infrastructure.

Beneath the refusal, Ephemeris told him to preserve the records, notify the operators and use the incident process.

"It is not wrong," Júlia said.

"I have already done all of it."

Mei read over his shoulder. "Then the machine has accurately identified you as unnecessary."

Arnau opened the request details. Its retention warning had become furniture in the year he had used Ephemeris. The new amber label had not.

INFRASTRUCTURE SAFETY REVIEW

"Review by whom?" Mei asked.

"Tenant security."

"Lenticular."

"Eventually Reixac," Arnau said.

Júlia came around the table. "Delete the conversation."

"Deletion removes it from my history, not the audit record."

"People feel safer when the screen is empty."

Arnau left it where it was.

His company phone vibrated with a message from Lenticular Trust Operations.

An automated safeguard has restricted this conversation. If the request relates to active eclipse infrastructure, preserve relevant data and contact Guaita Event Resilience through the priority incident channel.

A blue button waited beneath it: **OPEN INCIDENT**.

Júlia touched the printed booking. "Marc asked the project owner for permission. Your security system has now told that owner which words you used."

The door opened.

Marc stood in the corridor without the water bottles. "Salvador can join us at five. He would prefer that the gateway remain connected until then."

"Which Salvador?" Mei asked again.

Marc did not laugh this time. "Reixac."

They left through the public entrance. Marc held the inner door and wished Mei a better afternoon.

Outside, heat rose through the soles of Arnau's shoes. Across the courtyard, the chapel's cryostats stood behind glass. A cheap gateway, a Badalona shutter, a missing man: Reixac owned the distance between them.

Chapter 5: The Useful Error

"Where now?" Júlia asked.

"Llevant," Mei said.

"Why?"

"Because our machine says yes or no without telling Arnau's employer that he asked."

"Your catalogue model?"

"Among other things, it reads tables. Today we have tables."

Arnau unlocked the car. "Ephemeris is better at code."

"Ephemeris may be better at code," Mei said. "It is certainly better at reporting you."

They drove east in Arnau's car. Júlia left hers at the institute, a car anyone watching would expect her to come back for. Arnau did not ask when his wife had begun planning routes around people who knew their appointments.

The afternoon traffic thickened before Glòries. Heat distorted the roofs ahead. On the radio, Berta explained for the fourth time that Barcelona would not see totality. Callers continued to ask which beach in Barcelona offered the best view of totality.

An earlier blockage had pushed them off Diagonal and down Passeig de Gràcia past La Pedrera. Tourist groups occupied the pavement despite the heat. A guide raised one arm towards the stone facade and described Gaudí's imagination as freedom from rules.

Júlia turned in her seat to look after the building.

"Wrong," she said.

"The beach?" Arnau asked.

"Gaudí. Curved surface, calculated load. Ventilation, light, structure. Fantasy is what people call engineering when they cannot see the constraints."

Traffic stopped. The facade remained visible in the mirror, repeated across buses and car windows until every reflection showed a different crop of the same structure.

Arnau took the clean notebook from the glove compartment and changed the question.

Which records share an operator?

Not: **Where is the facility?**

Júlia listened with her head against the seat.

"You said the correlator was abandoned," Arnau said.

"It was."

"Abandoned things don't normally have live gateways."

"Neither do rejected Tour devices. Yet we have one."

"Who wrote it?"

She watched a tram slide beside them, its windows repeating their car in sections. “A research group.”

“Your group?”

“Drive, Arnau.”

They were stopped at a red light.

He let the question wait.

At Llevant, the police had finished photographing the rear door but left powder along its handle and a bright notice telling staff not to use it. The Sunday courier’s papers lay in clear sleeves on Mei’s desk. Somebody had covered the empty space on the shelf where the red ledger belonged with a sheet of cardboard, as though dust might damage an absence.

Four black Yulan boxes occupied the top of a short rack in the systems room. They were ordinary server appliances with restrained logos and impatient fans. A fifth space stood empty because Mei had moved the light case into the locked cage after weighing it.

Someone knocked on the showroom glass with a metal key.

Pol stood outside in yesterday’s shirt, holding a supermarket freezer bag against his chest. The bag had split at one handle. A power cable trailed through the tear.

Mei admitted him through the front because the rear door still carried police powder. He crossed the showroom without looking at the televisions and put the bag on her desk.

Inside lay a small computer with its storage removed. Dust marked the rectangle where it had sat beneath another machine for years. One fan blade had stopped at an angle behind the grille.

Arnau recognized it from Pol’s flat. “Your indexer.”

Pol placed the missing storage drive beside it in an antistatic sleeve. The tamper strip across the sleeve bore the time and his signature.

“My hosting provider reset the account at twelve fourteen,” he said. “Support says the request came through the enterprise contact on the abuse ticket.”

Pol unfolded a printout. Someone had reported his public scanner for probing eclipse infrastructure. The complaint listed the long Pedralbes hostname, gateway 147 and the minute he sent the archive to Oriol.

The complaint described legal public requests in the language most likely to make a provider stop asking questions.

The provider had briefly issued a support credential. Pol killed his rented instances and exported Oriol’s public responses with the provider notices.

He took a blank evidence envelope from Mei’s desk, slid in a read-only card and wrote three filenames across the seal.

Arnau reached for the drive. Pol covered it with his hand.

“It stays with me.”

Arnau let go.

Mei found a second envelope. Pol refused it. He put the drive back in the freezer bag, then unplugged the indexer’s fan with two fingers although the machine had no power.

Júlia asked whether he could restart elsewhere.

Pol looked through the systems-room window at the four Yulan boxes. “Of course.”

Nobody asked when.

He signed the evidence card over to Mei and photographed only the sealed envelope. At the front door he swapped the broken freezer bag for an empty returns carton and carried the dead indexer out beneath a picture of an air conditioner.

Mei placed his envelope beside the false collection order. The empty rectangle on Pol's machine faced the empty place on her rack.

The regular afternoon carrier arrived while Pol's carton was still visible through the showroom glass. Its driver scanned the first outgoing parcel. His screen turned red. He tried a second, then a third.

Eight Llevant cartons waited on the pavement: fans, radios and two repaired coffee machines promised back before closing. The driver showed Mei the same notice on each scan. **SHIPPER REVIEW. COLLECTION SUSPENDED.** No reason appeared beneath it.

He had collected from her family for nine years. He kept one hand on the trolley while she called dispatch, preventing the parcels from becoming either accepted or refused.

Dispatch asked whether Llevant had attempted an unauthorized equipment movement on Sunday.

Mei looked through the open showroom towards the false order on her desk. Nobody outside the police reports should yet have joined that question to her account.

She gave the incident number. Dispatch placed her on hold. The driver checked the time twice, then removed his hand from the trolley.

"I have three more estates."

Mei signed his failed-collection screen and made a copy before he left. Joel and Chen carried the cartons back inside. The repaired coffee machines returned to the bench where they had begun the morning.

On the shipping portal, Llevant's green account badge had become amber.

"These run Shanhai?" Júlia asked.

"A small local version," Mei said. "Product descriptions, translations, returns, supplier messages. Four boxes because Yulan wanted performance data at our scale. Not because I require four computers to identify a kettle."

"Does it call home?"

"No. That is why I agreed to evaluate it. Our prices and supplier terms stay in this building."

Arnau connected his laptop to an isolated desk port. Mei stopped him before the plug seated.

"Not that computer."

"The files are on it."

"So is Lenticular."

She gave him a clean warehouse laptop and a new storage card. He loaded sanitized gateway timing and shipment fields. No pictures, credentials or instructions.

Mei opened the local model interface. It had none of Ephemeris's polish. A plain page showed the loaded model, four green appliance states and a warning that answers could contain unsupported conclusions.

"At least it insults itself first," Arnau said.

"That warning was mine."

She asked in English and Chinese which records could share an operator, requiring an exact source for every link.

“Why twice?” Júlia asked.

“It follows constraints better in Chinese. It explains network fields better in English. This way it can disappoint us in both languages.”

The fans climbed.

Shanhai produced a table slowly enough that Arnau could watch each row become a claim. It linked the Tour gateway to the eclipse gateway through the reused certificate and their repeated clock correction. It linked both to the false collection through a six-character site field found in the shipment reference and the gateway’s maintenance banner.

Then it named a facility.

Likely shared staging location: Delta Emergency Imaging Centre, Sant Adrià de Besòs. Confidence: 0.91.

Below the answer it cited all three datasets.

Júlia gripped the back of a chair.

“There is no Delta Emergency Imaging Centre,” Mei said.

“There was,” Júlia replied.

Arnau looked at her. “You know it?”

“A temporary name. One floor in a municipal-services building during the pandemic. The project ended.”

“What project?”

“Missing-person image matching after evacuations. Different cameras, bad clocks, no shared index.”

The room’s fans filled the silence she left.

“The abandoned correlator,” Arnau said.

Júlia released the chair. “A predecessor.”

“You said a research group wrote it.”

“A group did.”

“Were you in the group?”

Mei leaned over the model’s citations before Júlia could answer. “This is wrong.”

She pointed to the six-character field. The model had treated `BDN-RET` as a site code shared by the collection order and a maintenance record.

“BDN is our account prefix,” she said. “It follows a return regardless of destination. It says who receives credit, not where the goods go.”

“And the maintenance banner?” Arnau asked.

“Copied from a template attached to our evaluation contract. Somebody reused the whole customer profile. The model found the copied mistake and called it geography.”

Arnau made it recalculate without the field.

Confidence in Delta fell from 0.91 to 0.34. The alternatives remained below half. The model had found the shared lie and mistaken it for a place.

Júlia sat down.

Relief changed her more completely than fear had. Her shoulders lowered. Colour returned beneath her eyes.

Arnau saw it because he had been waiting for the opposite.

“You wanted it to be Delta,” he said.

“I wanted the prototype dead.”

“Your prototype.”

She looked at the four ordinary black boxes, then at Mei.

“I wrote the first correlator,” she said. “Not this system. Not whatever is using the eclipse. The first one.”

“And you let us drive here while you waited to see whether the model named it,” Mei said.

Júlia did not offer the excuse Arnau expected. “Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because if Delta was active, I could tell myself somebody had restarted old code. If the answer was somewhere new, then somebody understood the method.”

“Which answer frightened you more?”

“The one we got.”

Mei took the clean storage card from Arnau’s laptop and placed it beside Júlia. “Then your next withheld fact belongs on that. Not in the car after it becomes convenient.”

Júlia nodded and slid the card into her shirt pocket.

Arnau’s company phone vibrated again on the desk.

This time the message displayed a sender’s name.

Salvador Reixac: You are right to connect the camera clocks to the cloned shipment. Please do not involve external systems until we speak. Guaita can give you a protected room at 07:30 tomorrow, before the traffic-priority rehearsal.

He had not told Reixac about the clocks.

He had told Ephemeris.

Outside the systems-room window, a dark van turned into the service lane and stopped at Llevant’s shutter.

Chapter 6: Every Light Green

At 07:30 on Tuesday, Guaita gave Arnau a protected room with glass walls.

It overlooked the temporary contribution floor near the 3Cat studios. Every person Arnau worked with could see him inside it. None could hear what Salvador Reixac was saying.

“Ephemeris behaved correctly,” Reixac said.

He sat on the other side of the table with Arnau’s restricted prompt open on a company tablet. The false collection order had become *a cloned shipment record*. Gateway three had become *publicly indexed camera metadata*. The authorized Tour capture remained exactly what it was.

“I know,” Arnau said.

“Good. People become emotional when a tool refuses them. They confuse a boundary with an accusation.”

“The refusal is not why we are here.”

“No. The log is.”

Reixac turned the tablet so Arnau could see the complete request. Even the phrases Ephemeris had removed from its visible reply remained in the audit copy.

“You combined data from three custody regimes on an external service.”

“Lenticular licenses the service.”

“External does not mean unknown. It means governed by contract. That is usually safer than a computer in a warehouse governed by friendship.”

Arnau looked through the glass. Berta crossed the contribution floor carrying a box of eclipse glasses. A floor assistant followed with a second box and the expression of someone who had learned that free objects generated more complaints than expensive ones.

“You know we went to Llevant,” Arnau said.

“You told me you were connecting the clocks to the shipment.”

“I told Ephemeris,” Arnau said. “Not you.”

“Then you told Lenticular. I assumed you would consult the people named on it.”

“You knew where the ledger was.”

“I knew its colour.”

Reixac did not deny it. The correction was more effective.

“Guaita received a premises survey from the insurer,” he continued. “One photograph showed the shelf before the incident. Red spine, black corners. You could have asked me yesterday.”

“Would you have shown me the photograph?”

“Yes.”

“Show me now.”

Reixac smiled without warmth. “That would contaminate the police process.”

On the wall display, the morning traffic rehearsal changed from amber to green. Six selected junctions around the eclipse broadcast campus appeared as simple circles. The diagram omitted street names and control details. It was designed for producers who needed to know whether a camera vehicle would arrive, not engineers who wanted to know how.

“Guaita is running the priority test at eight,” Reixac said. “Your team is monitoring interference with the contribution links. I want you at your normal position.”

“You restricted my account.”

“The assistant restricted one conversation. I have restricted nothing.”

“Why put me in a protected room?”

“Because you have found something worth protecting.”

He stood. “Bring me the original Tour capture after the rehearsal. We will compare it with Guaita’s system record. If there is misuse, we find it together. If there is an innocent explanation, we prevent an engineer’s private investigation from becoming a public allegation.”

“And Oriol?”

Reixac gathered the tablet. “The police still classify him as missing voluntarily. His bank card was used in Girona on Sunday afternoon.”

Arnau had not known that.

“Where in Girona?”

“A petrol station. Before you ask, no usable face. He may be avoiding you for a reason that has nothing to do with cameras.”

“Or somebody has his card as well as his badge.”

“That is why certainty is expensive.”

Reixac opened the glass door. Conversation from the contribution floor entered at once: horizon checks, safe-viewing graphics, a debate about whether a presenter could say *planetary alignment* without encouraging nonsense.

“Eight o’clock,” Reixac said. “Do your job, Arnau. It is still yours.”

Arnau returned to his console at 07:47.

His chair had been moved to the end of the desk.

The test recorder remained where he had left it, but the custody dock now showed an amber border around his name. He touched the badge reader. The border turned red. Across the desk, the test director took off one side of his headset.

“Use mine,” he said.

“Why?”

“Your capture permission changed.”

“When?”

The director checked the corner of his screen. “Seven thirty-six.”

While Arnau had been inside the glass room.

“Who approved it?”

“Security review. Temporary.”

“Which security review?”

The director put the headset back on. Two field crews were asking whether the first receiver had passed its lamp test. He answered them before looking at Arnau again.

“I have six junctions, three camera returns and a presenter who wants to stand in the road. Ask me after rehearsal.”

Arnau tried the contribution archive. Read only. The Tour folder opened, but its export control had disappeared. Oriol’s private allocation returned a legal-hold notice. His own engineering notebook remained local because nobody had yet found a way to revoke paper.

Berta crossed behind him with the eclipse glasses. She slowed when she saw the red border.

“Coffee?” she asked.

“No.”

“That was not about coffee.”

Arnau turned the monitor a few degrees. She saw the changed permission and kept walking.

A junior operator arrived with a cable query. He normally leaned across Arnau’s desk and pointed at whatever trace had offended him. This time he stopped outside arm’s reach.

“Reixac said all traffic questions go through the test director.”

“You have a traffic question?”

“Audio return on camera four.”

“Then why send it through traffic?”

The operator looked towards the glass room. Reixac had gone. The empty chair still held the shape of the meeting.

“I’ll ask after,” he said.

“Ask now.”

“It can wait.”

He took the query away.

At 07:55 the director placed a spare recorder dock between them. His own badge opened it. The custody field filled with his name, not Arnau’s.

“You monitor,” he said. “I preserve.”

“And if we disagree about what happened?”

“Then both of us will have been present.”

The answer was kind. Arnau disliked it more for that.

He opened his paper notebook to a blank page. At the top he wrote the rehearsal time, the director’s name and the minute his own access had failed. The director watched him write, then turned back to the route display.

At eight, six circles changed from grey to amber.

The traffic-priority rehearsal had a legitimate purpose. On eclipse day, outside broadcast vehicles, emergency crews and technical repair teams would move through roads expected to carry more cars than August normally left in the city. Six temporary receivers had been installed at selected junctions. An approved vehicle could request a short priority sequence. Everything outside the test corridor was meant to behave normally.

Arnau’s job was not to operate the signals. It was to listen for interference.

He set his small software-defined radio kit beside the contribution monitor and connected it to the approved test recorder. The equipment could tell him that a temporary system had spoken near a broadcast link. It could not turn a red light green. That distinction had felt too obvious to write into the plan until legal made him write it twice.

Berta dropped a pair of cardboard eclipse glasses beside him.

“For when the traffic signal becomes too bright,” she said.

“You are giving these to people?”

“I am explaining them. Giving implies joy. How bad is it?”

“Reixac showed me my prompt and asked for the original capture.”

“That bad.”

“He says Oriol’s card was used in Girona.”

Berta’s face changed, then reset before the camera operator across the room could notice. “Alive?”

“A card is alive.”

“Tell Mei.”

“After the test.”

“Tell your wife the next time your missing friend’s property moves. That is my professional recommendation as a science presenter.”

She went back towards the studio.

Arnau sent Mei the Girona card use, the petrol-station detail and Reixac as source. Her reply arrived before he finished mounting the recorder.

New fact, interested source. Keep both. Do not turn one into proof of the other.

Then a second message.

Thank you for telling me now.

The gratitude hurt more than criticism. It implied a recent version of him would have waited.

At 08:02, Guaita’s white test vehicle requested the first priority sequence.

One circle on the wall turned green. Then the next. The radio trace showed a clean exchange, followed by a brief correction from the receiver. Arnau marked the event against the rehearsal clock. No interference reached the contribution circuits.

The white vehicle appeared on a street camera approved for the rehearsal, crossed an empty junction, and stopped where the route plan told it to stop. A Guaita technician in a yellow vest stepped out and waved at nobody.

“Point one complete,” the test director said.

At point two, a refuse truck occupied the approach and the priority request waited. The test vehicle stopped. The system had not failed. It had declined to make one problem by solving another.

Arnau marked that too.

By point four, the heat had softened the adhesive holding one receiver’s temporary sun shield. A field technician called for tape. The studio camera rehearsing a traffic segment framed him from the waist up while Berta explained, live to an internal recording, why eclipse visitors should use official sites rather than parking beside dry fields.

Behind the technician, a plywood transport crate stood open on the pavement.

Arnau recognized the label before he could read it.

White field. Old Llevant logo. English handling line first.

He froze the rehearsal return and enlarged only what the camera had captured.

`LLEVANT-HOME / BDN / 5 OF 5`

The same false words from Oriol’s clip.

He photographed the monitor with his personal phone. Sending a still from the production system would create a company record. Photographing it created a worse record in a different place. There was no clean evidence left, only evidence with different owners.

He sent it to Mei.

She called before the next test point.

“Where is that crate?”

“Temporary receiver at point four. Guaita field team.”

“Turn the image left.”

“The image doesn’t turn.”

“Your photograph does. There is another label on the inside edge.”

Arnau enlarged the corner. A narrow supplier strip ran beneath the lid. Its print was too small to read, but the last three characters were clear.

`8B7`

“The wrong serial,” he said.

“The database serial,” Mei corrected. “Not the case. Somebody copied our customer profile onto the receiver shipment. The same profile Shanhai mistook for a place.”

“Can you identify the crate?”

“Not from pixels you have made larger. Ask the technician for the delivery note.”

“Guaita’s technician.”

“Then ask like Lenticular pays you.”

The test director called point four complete. On the route display, the white vehicle moved towards the fifth junction.

A dark van entered the camera frame behind it.

The van had waited outside Llevant the previous afternoon. Arnau could not prove it from one blurred plate and a dark shape. It had stayed for seven minutes, photographed all three cars, and left when the neighbour in unit four raised his shutter. Arnau knew the dent above the rear light.

The fifth circle turned green before the white vehicle requested it.

“Hold the test,” Arnau said.

The director looked over. “Guaita is in sequence.”

“A second vehicle entered the corridor.”

“Local traffic.”

The dark van passed the first green light close behind the test vehicle. At the next junction, the white vehicle stopped in its designated bay.

The dark van continued.

The next circle turned green.

Then the next.

Every light ahead of it changed before it arrived.

Arnau watched the radio trace. A request had entered the system, but it did not match the white vehicle’s clean exchange. It carried the same short correction afterwards, a small piece of traffic the recorder treated as maintenance noise.

“There,” he said.

The director leaned towards the display. “I don’t see an error.”

“Because the dashboard says the test vehicle made the request. The test vehicle is stopped.”

He isolated the capture and saved it through the approved recorder, preserving the original clock and test authorization. The file received a checksum and a custody number. He wrote both in his notebook.

The dark van left the final camera without stopping.

All six circles returned to amber.

“Run it again,” the director said.

Arnau selected the captured exchange but did not arm transmission. Reproducing an unknown command on live traffic equipment would convert evidence into an action.

“No,” he said.

“We need to know whether it repeats.”

“We need Guaita’s operator to revoke the priority identity and inspect the receivers. We do not send it again.”

The director touched his earpiece. “Guaita says their vehicle completed the route normally.”

On the camera wall, the white vehicle remained parked at point five.

Arnau called the field technician at point four through the rehearsal talkback.

“The receiver shade needs replacing,” he said. “Record the transport crate as damaged and hold it for inspection.”

“It’s only tape.”

“The label is wrong. Who delivered it?”

The technician bent to the crate and pulled a plastic document sleeve from the inside lid. He read the top line.

“Guaita Event Resilience. Internal equipment pool.”

“And maintenance?”

“Guaita. Same job.”

Camera gateway. Traffic receiver. Tour credential. One contractor had been placed between systems because institutions trusted it to coordinate them.

The same position let it make one system describe another’s lie as normal.

Arnau’s test recorder went blank.

Not the laptop. Not the radio trace. Only the window showing the central archive.

SESSION CLOSED BY SECURITY ADMINISTRATOR.

He checked the local capture. The file remained, its custody number intact. The central copy had disappeared from his view.

His phone rang. Reixac.

Arnau let it ring once before answering.

“Bring me the original capture,” Reixac said.

“You closed my session.”

“The rehearsal detected an unauthorized priority request. Guaita is containing it.”

“Your vehicle rode every light green.”

“Our white vehicle stopped at point five.”

“I didn’t say white.”

Silence lasted less than a second.

“Where are you, Arnau?” Reixac asked.

Through the contribution-centre window, Arnau saw the dark van turn into the staff entrance below.

“Doing my job,” he said, and removed the local recorder from its dock.

Chapter 7: Walden Seven

Mei knew Arnau was being followed because he told her he was not.

Leaving by the north door. Nobody behind me.

The message arrived at 08:41, nine minutes after the dark van entered the staff car park. Arnau never described an absence unless he had looked for it. He also never used the north door. It added four minutes to the walk from the contribution centre and deposited him beside a junction where every arriving car had to slow.

Mei waited in a loading bay across the road with Júlia in the passenger seat.

“He thinks he can detect surveillance,” Júlia said.

“He thinks he can detect a fault.”

“Is there a difference?”

“A fault does not know you are testing it.”

Arnau appeared between two parked production trucks. He did not look towards Mei’s car. He crossed at the pedestrian light, continued past them, and stopped beside a vending machine outside a petrol station.

A man in a blue shirt came through the same gap forty seconds later.

Not Riera. This man was broader, younger, and carried a motorcycle helmet. He stopped to read his phone. The helmet visor reflected the road.

“That one?” Júlia asked.

“Maybe.”

“Useful.”

Arnau bought water from the vending machine. He walked back towards the crossing as if he had forgotten which side of the road employed him.

The man with the helmet stayed where he was.

“Not him,” Júlia said.

“Maybe.”

“You have a difficult marriage.”

“We have a precise one.”

A dark van rolled out of the staff car park and stopped at the junction. The dent above its rear light caught the sun.

Arnau saw it. His head did not turn, but the bottle in his hand stopped swinging.

The light changed. The van drove past him and continued west.

Mei called.

“Do not look at us,” she said.

“I know where you are.”

“Then you already failed. Walk to the bus stop.”

“The van went the other way.”

“It knows where we live.”

That ended the argument.

Oriol’s paper eclipse map was in their flat at Walden 7. He had left it after dinner three weeks earlier, rolled inside a cardboard tube and covered with notes that made sense only when he stood over them. Official viewing sites in blue. Contribution routes in black. Red pencil circles around places that were not on the broadcast plan. Arnau had promised to return it Monday.

If the people in the dark van had Oriol’s badge, his card and Llevant’s ledger, they might already know about the map. If they did not, Arnau and Mei were about to lead them to it.

Leaving it felt worse.

Mei collected Arnau at the bus stop without stopping. He opened the rear door and entered while the car moved at walking speed. A driver behind them sounded his horn. Arnau spilled half the water down his shirt.

“Very discreet,” Júlia said.

“Drive.”

“She is driving.”

Mei took the first turn towards Sant Just, then another, then doubled back around a block of offices. The dark van did not appear. A white scooter stayed behind them for three turns, then left when its rider reached a bakery. A silver hatchback followed through two unnecessary right turns and parked outside a pharmacy.

“Nobody,” Arnau said.

“We are the suspicious vehicle now,” Mei replied.

At a roundabout she circled twice. Júlia closed her eyes.

“If someone is behind us,” she said, “we have told them we are looking. If nobody is behind us, we have told everybody else that we are lost.”

Mei exited towards Walden.

The building rose red above the surrounding roads, too large to read at once. From outside, its blocks seemed to stack according to a rule that had almost become an argument. Inside, the courtyards opened vertically through blue and green, crossed by walkways, stairs, bridges and balconies that made one address into hundreds of possible observations.

Arnau’s mother had taught him the routes when he was a child. Mei had learned them after marriage and learned the neighbours later, which was more useful.

She drove into the car park.

“We should not all go up,” Arnau said.

“Correct.”

“I will get the map.”

“Incorrect.”

“It is my flat.”

“It is also mine, which is why I know you left the spare tube behind the winter blankets instead of with the maps.”

“I moved it.”

“Where?”

Arnau hesitated.

“Behind the winter blankets,” Mei said. “Júlia, wait here. If the dark van enters, call once and hang up. If you see the grey EBRO, call twice.”

“What do I do after calling?”

“Decide whether you still want to be a research group.”

Mei and Arnau entered through different doors.

The lower courtyard smelled of watered plants and hot concrete. A child sent a red ball across the paving with a kick too hard for the space. It struck a wall, returned at an angle, and passed beneath a bench. Two older men continued their conversation without moving their feet. They had seen generations lose balls to the same geometry.

Mei went up the way she had been taught, which was not the way the signs suggested. She watched reflections in apartment windows instead of looking back. A person following her could appear above, below or across the courtyard without having passed her. The building made surveillance abundant and certainty scarce.

Her phone rang once.

The dark van had arrived.

Mei stepped out of the lift two levels below home. Arnau stood on a bridge across the courtyard, pretending to examine his wet shirt. Behind him, a woman carried two shopping bags towards the stairs.

Carme. Seventy-two, retired primary teacher, custodian of every parcel delivered to the wrong floor and every opinion delivered to the correct one.

Mei called her name.

Carme looked down. “You are home early.”

“We forgot something.”

“Arnau forgets. You remember.”

Across the courtyard, Arnau lifted one hand in surrender.

A man entered the level below Mei. Pale shirt, dark trousers, no helmet. He moved slowly and looked at the apartment numbers before choosing a stair. The numbers were repeated on every level. Anyone who belonged knew which sign was least helpful.

“Is he with you?” Carme asked.

“No.”

Carme did not look down. “Then why is he looking for you?”

“Maybe he isn’t.”

“You have become Catalan enough to give useless answers.”

She set one shopping bag beside Arnau and leaned over the railing.

“The lift is broken,” she called to the man.

It was not.

“Which lift?” he asked.

“The one you need.”

Two doors opened. A teenager carrying flattened boxes came out on Mei’s level. A man in running clothes appeared above with a rubbish bag. Nobody blocked the stranger. They occupied the circulation. In Walden, that was enough to make a person explain himself.

“Insurance inspection,” the man said. “Water report.”

“Which apartment?” Carme asked.

He supplied a number from another courtyard.

The teenager pointed back the way the man had come. “Other blue.”

There were several blues. The description was local, accurate and useless to someone who expected a corridor to behave like a street.

The man thanked him and descended.

Mei crossed the bridge while he was below. Arnau took Carme’s shopping and walked with her towards the next core. Their route looked domestic because it was. At her door, Carme unlocked three locks and spoke without turning.

“Someone asked yesterday whether your kitchen leak was repaired.”

“We don’t have a leak,” Arnau said.

“I know. Yours is the only kitchen that has never damaged my ceiling.”

“Who asked?”

“A polite woman with a clipboard. Not from the building. Her shoes were too clean.”

Carme opened her door and pressed a spare key into his palm. “Bring my milk back when you leave. I am going down for bread. If you need the long way, you know the long way.”

She did not ask why.

Mei knew the long way. Nobody had ever written it down. A building like this one was learned, not described. It took longer than walking directly home. It put three occupied kitchens between them and the man below.

Their front door was locked.

Arnau examined the frame. “No damage.”

“Open it.”

Inside, the air conditioning was running.

They had turned it off that morning.

The flat smelled faintly of lemon cleaner. Nothing in the sitting room appeared disturbed. Books remained uneven on the shelf. Mei’s tea cup stood by the sink. Arnau’s shoes formed the same obstruction beside the sofa. Whoever had entered had photographed the disorder before touching it or understood that tidying could be more visible than theft.

Mei went to the bedroom.

The winter blankets remained folded on the wardrobe shelf. The cardboard tube did not.

“Map is gone,” she said.

Arnau checked behind the blankets as if a second search could shame the tube into appearing.

“Anything else?”

“We cannot know. That is the point.”

His dive watch lay on the bedside table.

He reached for it. Mei caught his wrist.

“You wore that this morning.”

Arnau looked at the watch, then at his bare wrist.

“I took it off during the radio test.”

“At work.”

“I put it in my equipment case.”

The intruder had brought it home.

Not theft. Delivery. Proof that somebody could move through his workplace and his bedroom inside the same morning.

Mei's phone rang twice.

The grey EBRO.

She went to the kitchen window without touching the blind. Below, the dark van pulled away from the entrance. The man in the pale shirt had returned to it. He stood for a moment with one hand on the open passenger door, looking up at the building's repeated windows.

The grey EBRO waited beyond the roundabout.

It did not turn towards their entrance. It did not watch their stair.

When the dark van moved, the EBRO moved after it.

"The grey car is following them," Mei said.

Arnau joined her at the wall, staying outside the window's reflection. "Yulan?"

"A guess."

"Police?"

"A worse guess."

Below them, Carme emerged onto a bridge and looked directly towards the kitchen. She touched two fingers to her empty bag, reminding them that her milk was still in their kitchen.

Mei understood the instruction. Ordinary obligations were also routes.

She took passports, medicine, two changes of clothes, the clean warehouse laptop, and the paper copy of the false collection order. Arnau wanted his spare tools. She allowed the small radio kit he had carried out of the contribution centre and made him leave everything else.

He looked once at the watch on the bedside table.

"Leave it," Mei said.

"It was my father's."

"Then whoever put it there knows you will touch it."

He left it.

They put Carme's milk back in her refrigerator, locked her door, pushed the key under it and left the building separately, among neighbours who were going to work, walking dogs, taking children out, bringing bread in. Nobody performed an escape. They continued the building's day around two people who could no longer go home.

Júlia waited in the car park with the engine running.

"How many parties?" she asked.

Mei put the bags in the boot. "Us. The dark van. The grey car."

"That is three."

"No," Mei said. "It is four. We still don't know which party Oriol belongs to."

She took the driver's seat and turned east.

Arnau noticed at the second roundabout. "The police station is west."

"The warehouse is east."

"We just watched two vehicles follow each other away from our home. We are not going to Llevant."

"Five Yulan cases are at Llevant. The paper record that says what arrived is not."

"Which is why police sealed them."

“Police sealed the cage. The weekend shutter still opens with six staff codes and one key my father keeps in a biscuit tin because he dislikes codes.”

Júlia turned in the passenger seat. “Who knows you will go there?”

“Nobody.”

Arnau held up Mei’s phone. Joel’s name waited on the screen beneath a call she had started and not completed.

“Nobody except the person you are about to tell.”

“Joel can move the sealed cases from the systems room into the cage without opening them.”

“Joel was on Sunday standby. The collection order expected him.”

“It expected someone on Sunday standby. That is not the same thing.”

“Today those are the same thing until we know why his name was on their route.”

Mei took the phone from him at the next light. “My father is in that building. So are three people who came in early because our customers have started calling. I am not protecting a clue before I protect them.”

“Then call the police and tell them to protect the building.”

“Police cars outside our warehouse become the photograph’s caption by evening.”

“And your solution is Joel.”

“My solution is a person with hands inside the building.”

The light changed. Mei did not move. A horn sounded behind them, then another. She called.

Joel answered on the first ring.

“Where are you?” she asked.

“Unit two. Your father sent everyone else home. He says the police tape is crooked.”

“Do not straighten it. Put both shutters down and stay at the front desk. Do not move the Yulan cases.”

Arnau looked at her. She had changed the instruction while the call connected.

“You were going to ask me to move them,” Joel said.

“I am asking you not to.”

“A Yulan man already called. He said the same thing.”

Mei pulled into the first legal space and stopped hard enough that Júlia caught the dashboard.

“Which man?”

“Corporate security. Different voice from July. He knew police sealed number five. He said opening it would destroy the manufacturer’s evidence.”

“What number did he call?”

“Mine.”

“Did you tell him where you were?”

Joel did not answer.

“Joel.”

“He knew. He asked whether Chen was still with me.”

Mei looked across the traffic. They had left Walden behind, but the road still offered no route that did not end at somebody she knew.

“Take my father to Pilar’s shop,” she said. “Leave through unit four. Do not use your own car.”

“He will not go.”

“Put me on speaker.”

Her father came onto the line already objecting. Mei did not let him reach the end of the first sentence.

"A man who knows the police seal called Joel. If you stay, you are not guarding the warehouse. You are giving him a reason to visit it. Go to Pilar. Take the document crate."

"And you?"

"I am not coming."

The admission cost more than the instruction. Chen heard it.

"Good," he said. "Then for once we are both doing what the other asks."

The line remained open while Joel lowered the front shutter. Metal rattled through the phone. A door closed. Her father complained that the document crate was too heavy for him and then refused to let Joel carry it.

Arnau watched the mirrors.

"Grey EBRO," he said.

It passed the junction ahead of them, moving east.

Mei saw only the rear before traffic covered it. Same grey body. Same dark mark beside the left lamp. It did not slow near their car. It did not need to. The road led towards Badalona.

"You called Joel and it moved," Arnau said.

"It was already moving."

"You don't believe that."

"Belief is still cheap."

"So is calling family until one of them tells the wrong person where to wait."

Mei looked at him. "Do you want me to say you were right before we know whether my father is out?"

"I want you to stop treating danger to Llevant as private because the public version may be unfair."

"And I want you to stop treating Oriol as the only person who can be missing."

The words silenced the car.

Arnau turned towards the window.

Mei's phone vibrated once. A photograph from Joel showed Chen inside Pilar's shop, holding the document crate and arguing with someone outside the frame. A second photograph showed unit two's shutters down and the police patrol arriving.

Mei called the investigating officer and gave her the corporate-security call, Joel's number and the grey EBRO's direction. No private handling. No softened version. By the time she finished, the officer had already received a report that Llevant staff were interfering with sealed equipment.

The report had been filed four minutes before Mei called Joel.

Somebody had known the choice she would make.

She turned away from Badalona.

"Hotel," she said.

Arnau did not answer.

At the next light, Mei placed her phone between them. "If Oriol calls, you answer. If the warehouse calls, I answer. If neither calls, we decide together."

"That is not together. That is two emergencies sharing a car."

"It is what we have today."

The light changed. This time Mei moved before anyone sounded a horn.

Part Two: The Negative

Every image contains what it excludes.

Chapter 8: Five Boxes

On Wednesday morning, Mei broke a contract with a screwdriver.

The fifth Yulan case stood in Llevant's locked cage beneath two police evidence labels and one supplier seal. The police labels recorded that nobody had opened it after Sunday's theft. The supplier seal said opening it would transfer all damage, data loss and intellectual-property liability to Llevant Import. At seven the investigating officer had released the police labels by phone, on condition that the opening was filmed and the incident number read aloud.

Eleven missing kilograms had already transferred the liability in every way that mattered.

Arnau and Mei had spent Tuesday night in a business hotel near Badalona under their own names. Police knew the address. Carme knew. Nobody else was supposed to, which meant Mei assumed Guaita could learn it by breakfast.

The room contained one chair, two toothbrushes supplied by reception and curtains that never met in the middle. Arnau slept facing the door until three, then facing the window until five. Mei slept for forty minutes and woke angry that fear had made even rest feel like negligence.

At seven they checked out rather than extend. The receptionist asked whether the room had been satisfactory.

"It remained a room," Mei said.

They were crossing the lobby when Arnau's phone rang.

The hospital caller used Oriol's full name and asked whether Arnau could identify him in person. A man of approximately forty-five had been brought from a service road near Sant Adrià without a wallet. Heat exhaustion, bruising, no clear account of where he had spent the night.

"Is he conscious?" Arnau asked.

"Sometimes. He gives different names. Yours is on the missing-person contact."

Arnau was already walking towards the car.

"Ask about his hand," Mei said.

"What?"

"His left hand. Ask whether the last finger closes properly."

Arnau stared at her.

"He broke it before our wedding. He complained through the whole dinner because the splint stopped him cutting bread."

Arnau relayed the question. The caller checked with someone away from the phone.

"All fingers mobile," she said. "There is a scar on the right forearm."

Oriol had scars. Arnau could not place them. He knew the gain error in Oriol's favourite field monitor, the code to the cupboard where he hid decent coffee and the exact delay after which impatience became a joke. He did not know his friend's arms.

“We are ten minutes away,” he said.

They were twenty-two minutes away in morning traffic. Arnau made it eighteen and spent every red light inventing reasons an old fracture might no longer limit a finger.

The man in the observation bay was younger than Oriol and older than the nurse had guessed. His face was swollen. One shoe was missing. He turned towards Arnau with the exhausted hope of someone who had been told a person was coming.

Arnau knew before reaching the bed.

“I’m sorry,” he said.

The man asked in Spanish whether Arnau had brought his brother.

Nobody knew the brother’s name.

Mei found the duty officer and made sure the man’s photograph entered the regional missing-person check before they left. Arnau waited in the corridor with the plastic bag containing the man’s remaining shoe because a nurse had handed it to him and nobody had taken it back.

“Oriol would have made that man’s brother a producer by now,” he said.

“Oriol would have promised a live connection before finding a camera.”

“Then asked me to make it true.”

The joke arrived intact. Neither of them laughed.

At the lift, the nurse caught them and retrieved the shoe.

“We should open the Yulan case,” Mei said.

Arnau pressed the ground-floor button. “You did not have to come here.”

“Yes, I did. Otherwise you would have identified him from wanting to.”

The lift doors closed on the observation ward.

Now the locked cage at Llevant felt more private than the place where they had slept. That did not make it safe.

Mei set two phones to record. One belonged to Llevant and had never run company email. The other belonged to her father, who had covered its camera lens with tape and objected when she removed it.

“That is for privacy,” he said.

“Today privacy needs a video.”

“Then today is badly designed.”

He stood outside the cage with Joel Huang and a paper bag from the bar on Guifré. Tomato had soaked through one corner. Joel held a tray of coffees and looked as if he had not slept, which made him resemble everyone else in the warehouse.

Arnau checked the recording angles. Júlia wrote the time, seal number and floor scale reading on a clean sheet of paper.

“State why we are opening it,” Arnau said.

Mei looked into the Llevant phone.

“Yulan evaluation case five was recorded at sixty-two kilograms on receipt and weighs fifty-one this morning. A false collection order attempted to remove it on Sunday. The paper exceptions ledger documenting its arrival has been stolen. We are opening the case to identify missing contents and preserve evidence.”

“Police incident number,” Arnau said.

She read it.

“Supplier contract?” Júlia asked.

“Already broken,” Mei replied.

She cut the seal.

Her phone rang before the blade reached the second corner. The caller was Pilar Forn, who ran the independent appliance shop that had bought from Llevant since Mei was seventeen. Pilar did not ask about the case. She asked whether the picture circulating among suppliers was real.

“Which picture?”

Pilar sent it.

The false pallet stood beneath a municipal-store sign. Llevant’s old logo filled the nearest case. Someone had cropped out the police tape and added a caption in Spanish: **CHINESE ECLIPSE EQUIPMENT HELD IN SOUTHERN DEPOT.** No article, no byline, only a picture ready to acquire either.

“I have a council order for thirty emergency radios,” Pilar said. “They want origin documents before collection. They have never asked me for origin documents on radios. If I send yours, am I sending something that will become another question?”

The honest answer would cost Llevant before any investigation cleared it.

“The pallet is false,” Mei said. “Our company did not ship it. I will send you the police incident number and the original radio declarations within ten minutes. If the council refuses them, give me the buyer’s name.”

“And if I need another supplier today?”

Mei looked at the sealed case, the two recording phones and her father waiting outside the cage.

“Then use one. Do not lose the order to protect my feelings.”

Pilar was silent. “Your father would tell me to wait.”

“My father is not responsible for your payroll.”

Chen heard. His face supplied no objection, which was worse than an argument.

“Ten minutes,” Pilar said, and ended the call.

Mei restarted the spoken evidence record. Breaking the seal now had a price beyond the supplier contract. If the case contained what the photograph implied, she would have to prove Llevant had been used without making every customer wait for a court to say so. If it contained nothing, the emptiness would look arranged.

The case lid resisted for three centimetres, then released with a sigh as its gasket separated. Inside, black foam surrounded a metal appliance identical to the four running in the systems room. Same restrained Yulan logo. Same handles. Same vent pattern. The front status window showed no light.

Mei photographed it before anyone touched it.

“Looks right,” Joel said.

“That is what looks are for,” Júlia replied.

Arnau lifted one side. The appliance moved too easily.

They removed it together and set it on the cage table. Mei checked the case beneath it. No loose parts. No hidden document. The foam held a rectangular impression along one edge where something warm had pressed against it long enough to leave the surface smoother and darker.

“Heat,” she said.

Arnau touched the mark. “Maybe.”

“Foam doesn’t polish itself.”

“Compression can do it.”

“The other cases have the same compression.”

Her father opened the paper bag. “You should compare before breakfast becomes lunch.”

He distributed pa amb tomàquet wrapped in paper, wedges of truita, and napkins too thin for either. Nobody argued. Food in the warehouse was scheduled by whoever remembered that concentration did not replace blood sugar.

Mei ate standing beside the open case while Arnau removed the appliance cover.

The inside had been built to pass a shallow inspection. Fans occupied the front. A standard controller board sat behind the status window. Cables ended in plugs fixed to an empty frame. Steel plates filled the bottom, cut into neat rectangles and bolted through rubber mounts so they would not move when the case was tilted.

“A dummy,” Júlia said.

“A good one,” Arnau replied.

“It is eleven kilograms bad.”

“Good enough for a manifest and a person who doesn’t lift servers.”

Mei looked at Joel. He carried cases more often than anyone at Llevant.

“Did you notice?”

“Sunday? I wasn’t here.”

“Before Sunday.”

Joel drank coffee. “They were all heavy.”

“That is not an answer.”

“Then ask a smaller question.”

Mei’s father gave him a look that had corrected smaller relatives for thirty years.

Joel put down the cup. “Five was heavier when it arrived. I think. We moved them once for the electrician and once when the evaluation team wanted better airflow. After that, the four live ones stayed on the rack. Five stayed in the case.”

“Who asked for better airflow?”

“Yulan support.”

“By email?”

“A man came.”

The cage seemed to become quieter although the systems-room fans continued beyond the wall.

“Name,” Mei said.

“I don’t remember. Corporate security. He showed me a Yulan card.”

“Support or security?”

“Both. He said prototypes were being stolen from European evaluation sites. He wanted to know whether any box ran hot or was moved without a ticket.”

“What did you tell him?”

Joel looked at the open dummy. “That number five was hot after Sant Joan.”

Mei set her food down.

“How hot?”

“Hotter than the others. The case handles were warm. I thought they had tested it before delivery.”

“When did you tell him?”

“July. Maybe the second week.”

“You reported our stock to a stranger.”

“To the manufacturer.”

“A badge is not a manufacturer.”

“You let five closed computers into the warehouse because a contract said Yulan.”

The reply landed because it was accurate.

“And when you thought the contract was wrong,” Mei said, “you told another badge. You did not tell me.”

“You were negotiating the evaluation renewal. Every complaint became my mistake before it became Yulan’s.”

“So you protected your position.”

“I protected the account that pays three of us through winter. You can call that my position because yours has an office.”

Joel had never said it so plainly. Mei managed the warehouse as family when she needed trust and as a company when she needed obedience. He moved between both descriptions without receiving the protection of either.

Mei’s father folded the top of the paper bag closed. “Argue after you know what was stolen. Before that, you are choosing which ignorance to defend.”

Júlia crouched beside the open appliance. “The controller is real.”

Arnau followed the cable from the front board. It ended in a small storage module mounted beneath the empty frame.

“It had to answer inventory checks,” he said. “Power it without the fans?”

“Read only,” Júlia said.

“Everything is read only until software discovers ambition.”

They moved the controller to the systems room and connected it through an isolated bench supply. No network. No radio. Arnau used a standard service lead. The controller started and presented itself as Yulan evaluation appliance five.

It believed the steel plates were still attached to something useful.

Mei exported the local service history from all five units. Four histories showed catalogue-model updates, inventory tests and ordinary failures: a fan warning, a bad language pack, a disk filled by product photographs nobody had resized.

The fifth contained none of those.

Its first entry appeared at 20:18 on 23 June, shortly after arrival. A hardware profile had registered once, completed a short thermal check and disappeared from the controller on 16 July. The replacement profile began eleven minutes later.

The dummy had entered Llevant three weeks after the real machine.

“Can the log be forged?” Mei asked.

“Yes,” Arnau said.

“Can the heat mark be forged?”

“Yes.”

“Can Joel’s memory be forged?”

Joel raised one hand. “Often.”

“All three together?” she asked.

Júlia answered. “Possible. Expensive.”

The original hardware profile used no product name. It listed power boundaries, cooling expectations and a class of workload. Arnau read the upper power figure twice.

“Six kilowatts,” he said.

Mei looked through the wall towards the four black appliances. “The others use less than one together.”

“Six needs direct cooling. Fast storage. Conventional compute beside it. Whatever was here could not do its real work in this warehouse.”

“Then why bring it here?”

“Because warehouses receive boxes,” her father said.

Shanhai grouped the fifth controller’s unusual entries against the other four. Mei made it cite exact fields and forbid conclusions not present in the logs. It still offered six explanations. Five were variations of failed prototype testing.

The sixth identified a dormant appointment record.

Not a connection. Not an access key. A date, a project abbreviation and an instrument identity waiting for a larger system.

`12-AUG / LLUM-PED / INST-03`

Arnau took out the photograph Júlia had made of the Institut Llum booking.

Three instruments. Dr Lin Qiao. Marc Escudé. The third seal replaced after the May rehearsal.

“It was here,” he said. “Now it is booked there.”

“No,” Mei replied. “Something that claims its identity is booked there. We have learned what claims cost.”

Júlia expanded one final field from the first thermal check. The value was not a serial or location. It was a compiler target, short enough to survive in a status table.

`INGOT-M1`

“Ingot,” Joel said.

“A product name?” Mei asked.

Arnau searched the four ordinary systems. No result. He searched the public Yulan documentation stored with the evaluation contract. No result.

“An internal name,” he said.

Mei looked at the steel plates in the open dummy, then at the police labels on the case. Llevant’s paperwork said the company still possessed five Yulan systems. The floor scale said one had become lighter. The controller said the missing part expected to enter a research annex beside one of Europe’s best-known computers on the day millions of cameras would watch the Sun.

On paper, Llevant remained its custodian.

“The false shipment in the south,” she said. “If somebody opens those cases, what will they find?”

Her phone rang before anyone answered.

The freight forwarder from Sunday had called three times since Tuesday. The first call came while Mei was inside Walden collecting passports. The other two arrived while police recorded

the break-in and nobody trusted an unfamiliar number.

She returned the call on speaker.

“The municipal store opened the pallet,” the man said. “There are five empty cases. Your labels are inside and outside now. Police want the shipper.”

“We did not ship it.”

“Then somebody has spent a great deal of money making sure that sentence sounds convenient.”

After the call, nobody spoke.

Mei looked at Joel.

He had known which case ran hot. He had told a stranger. He was family, useful and ashamed. Mei could not yet tell which part was the lie.

“Find me every time number five moved,” she said. “Forklift, camera, lunch receipt, neighbour, favour. Not the inventory system. People.”

Joel picked up his coffee. “How far back?”

“Sant Joan.”

Outside, someone tested a string of small firecrackers for the coming festa and earned three shouted complaints from neighbouring units. The sound entered the warehouse sharp and unfinished.

Mei did not look at Joel. She watched the five service histories until the model stopped offering explanations she had not asked for.

Chapter 9: Sant Joan

On Wednesday evening, Lin watched a photograph of Llevant's opened dummy case appear on a private Yulan channel that should not have known the seal was broken.

The photograph was a frame from Llevant's continuous evidence recording, made from outside the cage through the systems-room window. Mei stood with her back to the glass. Joel was visible beyond her, holding a coffee. Mei had attached the recording to a warranty notice sent through Yulan's evaluation contact. It should have remained inside that claim. On Lin's channel it carried no source, only a question from her sponsor:

Can local custody still be trusted?

Lin did not answer. The question contained its preferred conclusion and one fact that mattered more: the supplier process had carried Llevant's evidence into the recovery operation before anyone acknowledged that the operation existed.

She sat in a small hotel room near Sants with the curtains closed against heat and view. The air conditioner produced noise without cold. Removing the private phone's battery would not withdraw the photograph from the people already using it.

She enlarged Joel's face.

The last time she had seen him, he was standing beside the same five cases while Badalona prepared to burn the shortest night.

The five cases reached Badalona at 18:57 on the night of Sant Joan.

The driver wanted them unloaded before the next firecracker frightened his dog by telephone. Joel Huang wanted them unloaded before his uncle closed the warehouse. Lin Qiao wanted one of the cases to disappear among the other four before anyone understood that they were not identical.

Only the driver complained aloud.

"Six o'clock delivery," he said, holding out the manifest.

"It is almost seven," Joel replied.

"I have been almost here since six."

An explosion struck somewhere beyond the industrial estate. The roller door shook. The driver looked accusingly at the street, as if Badalona had delayed him on purpose.

"Sign first," he said.

"Unload first."

"Sign that I arrived."

"You arrived with a closed truck. I can sign for a closed truck."

Lin stood beside the loading bay in a Yulan polo shirt. The carrier wanted a signature. Llevant wanted five cases on concrete. Neither yet had what it needed.

The first firecrackers had begun before sunset. Sharp single reports crossed the longer tearing

noise of strings set off between units. Smoke travelled along the service lane and entered every open shutter. Families carried folding tables from warehouses. Someone had placed two trays of coca beside a stack of lighting catalogues and covered them with plastic against the ash.

She checked the five Yulan seals while Joel lowered the truck's tail lift. The numbers matched her encrypted handover sheet. The fifth case carried the physical serial ending in `887`. The advance manifest said `8B7`, an error introduced when someone read a blurred scan.

"This one is wrong," Joel said.

He had found it before she mentioned it.

"The case is correct," Lin said. "The manifest is wrong."

"The portal has B-seven."

"Then the portal is also wrong."

Joel called towards the office. His uncle answered without leaving his desk.

"Red book," the older man said.

Joel took a ledger from a shelf and wrote both numbers, the time, the driver, and the correction in a narrow hand. He asked Lin to initial the margin.

Yulan's instructions said discrepancies should be resolved digitally. Lin signed the paper.

"You keep two inventories?" she asked.

"We keep one inventory and several computers."

"Which one wins?"

"The box."

He struck the fifth case with his palm.

Something inside it recorded the impact.

Ingot occupied the same frame as the four catalogue appliances and weighed eleven kilograms more. The customs description was legal because Yulan had withheld what would make it meaningful to Llevant.

Yulan's risk note called the estate a high-volume trade environment with *low attribution clarity*. It called the family's multilingual records *operationally advantageous*.

Lin had read the phrases twice. They meant the company expected outsiders to believe a strategic component might vanish among Chinese-run warehouses. They also meant Yulan believed the same stereotype.

Lin had objected. Her sponsor answered that Llevant was a legitimate evaluator.

Joel drove the first four cases into unit two. Each passed over the floor scale. Fifty-one kilograms, within tolerance. The driver read numbers into his phone and winced whenever the street exploded.

The fifth case registered sixty-two.

"Not identical," Joel said.

"Different ballast for the evaluation profile."

"Useful ballast?"

"To the engineers."

"Engineers find uses for weight after adding it."

Lin looked at him. He smiled.

He was younger than the briefing photograph and more observant than the local contact description. The file called him a Sunday driver and warehouse assistant. It did not say he read

manifests before signing them or noticed eleven kilograms without needing the scale.

Another explosion erased the driver's next sentence. A child in hearing protectors ran from unit four carrying a paper dragon with one wing bent. Her father followed, shouting that the loading lane was not a plaça. She ignored him and offered Joel a strip of red paper.

"For the beast," she said.

"Wrong month," Joel replied.

"It needs repairs now."

He accepted the paper and tucked it into his pocket.

The driver finally obtained his signature. His application recorded the delivery at 23:41 because the batch would remain open until the truck returned to its depot. Lin asked him to correct it.

"System time," he said.

"It is seven fifteen."

"Then write seven fifteen in your red book."

He left before either of them could stop him.

Llevant's owner emerged from the office after the truck had gone. He introduced himself as Chen Zhou, checked Lin's Yulan identification and declined her offer to explain the evaluation programme again.

"My daughter understands the computers," he said. "She is not here."

"I can return tomorrow."

"Tomorrow is a holiday."

"The installation takes twenty minutes."

"Then it will take twenty minutes on Thursday."

He cut the coca into smaller pieces because more neighbours had arrived than the trays anticipated. Someone opened cava. A forklift reversed through the first notes of music from a portable speaker.

Lin needed twenty minutes to test the fifth case and write its August appointment into the service record.

"The contract requires receiving validation," she said.

Chen read the relevant page. "It permits validation. It does not require tonight."

Joel looked at the five cases. "I can stay."

"You have plans," his uncle said.

"Plans begin after dark."

The sun still pressed white against the loading lane.

Chen considered Lin, his nephew and the open shutter. "Twenty minutes. Then you both leave before people become creative with petrol."

They moved the cases into the systems room. The four ordinary appliances passed their inventory tests. Joel labelled their leads in Catalan and Spanish.

Case five remained closed.

Lin attached her service lead. Ingot woke inside its sealed frame.

Its fans rose stronger than the others. Heat reached the handles. Lin ended the test before the warehouse power monitor could complain again.

"Ballast," Joel said.

"Among other things."

“What does it do?”

“Moves model data.”

“The others do that.”

“This one moves more.”

The appointment appeared in the service record. Lin disconnected the lead.

Outside, twilight had begun. Firecrackers filled every pause. The careful distance between separate explosions collapsed into continuous noise. Smoke softened the warehouse lights and ash settled on the black cases before Joel closed their lids.

He touched case five again.

“Still hot.”

“It will cool. Do not move it without a service ticket. Do not open any case. If somebody from Yulan asks about temperature, direct them to project support.”

“You are from Yulan.”

“Tonight.”

The word escaped before she could improve it.

Joel studied her, then wrote the thermal observation into the red ledger. Paper accepted suspicion without asking for a category.

Lin completed her visit report in the office. The form required a local staff contact. She entered Chen Zhou, then stopped. Chen had approved the delivery. Joel had handled it, found the serial error, stayed late and observed the heat.

Good documentation named the person who knew what happened.

She added **Joel Huang** beneath Chen’s name and marked him *competent local contact*.

It was a courtesy. It would make sure he received credit if Yulan expanded the evaluation contract.

At 21:06 Lin left through the front shutter carrying a piece of coca wrapped in a napkin. Joel had insisted. The streets beyond the estate belonged to smoke, families, music and explosions that arrived from every direction. Bonfires waited for darkness. Balconies held tables. Open windows released arguments about where children were allowed to go.

A grey EBRO stood at the end of the service lane.

Lin recognized it from the May rehearsal. This time the driver made no effort to follow. The car remained beneath a streetlight while she passed, its windscreen reflecting firecrackers above the roofs.

She sent one message to her sponsor.

Five received. Local record corrected. Evaluation contact added.

The answer came before she reached the corner.

Good. Recovery must know who observes the hardware.

Lin stopped walking.

She considered reopening the report and removing his name.

The system had already accepted it. She did not go back.

In the hotel room, the photograph returned her to its unanswered question.

She had entered Joel as a competent contact. Yulan security would have inherited the name when the evaluation moved from engineering to recovery. What she had called credit was also a route.

Lin sent no reply to her sponsor. She wrote the photograph's arrival time on hotel paper, copied its file checksum by hand and removed the device battery.

Someone knocked at the door.

Not housekeeping. She had refused service when she arrived and hung the card outside to prove it.

The knock came again, two measured taps. A man's voice said her surname with the correct tone and no title.

Lin put the paper inside her shoe, took the black pouch and left through the room's connecting door. It opened into an unoccupied twin the receptionist had given her after the first air conditioner failed. She crossed that room and entered the corridor six doors farther down.

At the lift, a man in a pale shirt waited facing the floor numbers. He did not turn when Lin approached. She took the stairs.

She reached the service exit as a delivery rider held it open with one shoulder. Outside, evening traffic moved past Sants in hot layers. Three floors above, the man knocked on a room containing an open connecting door and an air conditioner still making noise.

Interlude: The Missing Licence

The machine Yulan had ordered never arrived.

For six months it existed as a rectangle on a factory plan, a sequence of payments in a finance system, and a delivery date nobody was permitted to call a promise. Engineers designed products around its future presence. Facilities crews prepared power and water. A yellow boundary appeared on the floor where its sealed modules would stand.

In December 2019, the rectangle remained empty.

Lin Qiao learned the export licence would not be granted during a compiler meeting about something else.

The department head entered, unplugged the presentation cable, and said, “Room four. Bring nothing.”

Nobody asked whether to save their work. They saved it.

Room four had no windows and too many chairs. Yulan’s founder, Cao Min, stood at the whiteboard beside a printed factory roadmap. She was fifty-three and disliked being called Chairwoman because it allowed men to spend the first minute of a meeting performing respect instead of answering questions.

Hsu Yu-chen sat near the end of the table with a visitor badge clipped to her jacket. She had arrived from Hsinchu to review the package model for Yulan’s first leading-edge accelerator. Her return flight left the following morning. Until ten minutes ago, Lin had expected her to come back in February.

Cao waited for the door to close.

“The licence is not coming,” she said.

Nobody spoke.

Public reports had prepared them without convincing them. Washington was pressing European governments to stop one class of manufacturing equipment from reaching China. The supplier required national approval. Meetings became calls, calls became postponements, and postponements became language about continuing dialogue.

Engineers had treated the delay as politics. Politics was weather until it entered the clean room.

Cao took a black marker and drew a line through three years of the roadmap.

The sound was small. It removed two accelerators, a training system and the product on which half the room expected to build a career.

“We can redesign around the equipment we can obtain,” the silicon director said.

“How long?” Cao asked.

“For the first device? Eighteen months if the process team can recover density.”

“At what performance?”

He gave a range.

Cao wrote its middle on the board. Then she wrote the expected result from their abandoned plan beside it.

The difference was large enough to end the discussion.

“We cannot make the same machine worse and call it independence,” Cao said. “What valuable computation have we chosen only because everyone else chose it?”

The training architect answered first. “Dense matrix multiplication.”

“That is not an answer. That is our current religion.”

“It is what models require.”

“Models require many things. Which one are we pretending is the whole problem?”

Lin watched Hsu turn her visitor badge face down.

The accelerator on Yulan’s roadmap resembled every accelerator competing for the same market. Smaller transistors. More arithmetic units. Expensive high-speed memory close to them. Enough power that every efficiency slide required a footnote. Yulan had planned to arrive late and charge less.

Without the new process, they would arrive later.

“Training remains arithmetic,” Lin said.

Everyone looked at her. Compiler engineers attended architecture meetings to explain why software would not rescue a bad design. They were not expected to propose the next one.

“Yes,” Cao said. “What does not?”

“Inference, sometimes.”

The training architect shifted in his chair. “Inference is also matrix multiplication.”

“Sometimes,” Lin repeated.

She went to the board because explaining from a chair made an idea sound like an objection. Cao gave her the marker.

Lin drew a box for a model, then divided it into many smaller boxes.

“Pruned networks already leave most of their weights idle. The conditional models in the research papers go further. A router selects a few expert blocks for each input. The rest wait.”

“Wait in memory,” the silicon director said. “Memory we cannot place close enough to the compute.”

“Yes.”

“Then you have described our disadvantage.”

“I have described movement. Not arithmetic.”

She drew arrows between the boxes. Too many at first, then fewer.

“If the active experts can be predicted, reused and moved before they are needed, the valuable part of the machine may not be the smallest multiplier. It may be the system that keeps ordinary multipliers fed.”

“Predicted by what?” Cao asked.

“The router history. Input locality. Compiler scheduling. I don’t know yet.”

Cao nodded at the last sentence. Certainty offered too early was a sales function.

Hsu stood and came to the board.

“Not if memory sits on the other side of one narrow package edge,” she said.

Her Chinese was exact and carried the rhythm of somebody who usually did this work in another language. She took the marker from Lin and drew several packages rather than one large chip.

"You are replacing process density with package area," the silicon director said.

"Partly."

"Area costs money."

"So does equipment that does not arrive."

One person laughed, then stopped when nobody joined him.

Hsu did not draw a manufacturing recipe. She drew boundaries. Mature logic here. Commodity memory there. Short movement where possible. Slower storage behind it. A fabric that treated the package as a system rather than a container.

Lin added the software boundary. Dense layers remained on conventional accelerators. Attention remained there too. The sparse experts moved through the new memory system. A miss would be slow. A hit could make old fabrication useful in a way nobody benchmarked because the benchmark assumed a different machine.

By the time they stopped, the whiteboard held an argument, not a product.

Cao read it from left to right.

"Can it train?"

"No," Lin said.

"Can it serve many users?"

"Not without losing the reuse pattern. Low batch first."

"Can it beat the accelerator we planned?"

"At general computation, no."

The training architect folded his arms. "Then what have we won?"

Hsu capped the marker. "The right to build something."

Silence returned, different from the silence after the missing licence. That one had contained subtraction. This one contained cost.

Cao circled the package and the compiler together.

"How large a model?"

"Today's?" Lin asked.

"The one people will say cannot run outside a data centre."

"We don't know what that model looks like."

"Then design for the property, not the name. Sparse. Mostly idle. Too much memory for one expensive accelerator."

She looked at Hsu. "How long are you staying?"

"My flight is tomorrow."

"Move it."

Hsu did not answer immediately. "My employer approved a package review. Not a new architecture."

"Call them."

"You should call them. It will teach both companies who believes this is joint work."

Cao smiled. "Good. Lin, make the call with me."

The meeting divided into work before anyone declared it finished. Process options. Memory supply. Simulation. Model traces. Finance. Three people argued over whether the yellow rectangle on the factory floor should be removed. Cao told them to leave it for one week.

Lin remained at the board with Hsu.

"You knew the licence was gone," Lin said.

"I knew my management expected it to be gone. They told me to finish the review and bring our interface notes home."

"Will they let you stay?"

"Perhaps for two days. Perhaps they will recall me tonight."

Lin looked at the circled architecture. "Then we photograph the board."

"No."

"The room has no recording system."

"Your room has a company. Companies remember ownership better than collaboration."

Hsu opened her notebook. On one page she wrote the date, the names of everyone in the room, and a short checksum of the package floorplan file they had just saved. She signed beneath it and handed the pen to Lin.

"This proves nothing technical," Lin said.

"Not today."

Lin signed.

"Tonight it goes into the university deposit," Hsu said. "They stamp the date. I do not."

The department head returned with two security staff. They carried no weapons and made no accusation. Their instruction came from legal: visiting personnel could not remain in an unapproved strategic design meeting. Hsu's badge had already been disabled.

Cao began to object. Hsu closed the notebook.

"Make the call first," she said. "Then object."

She put on her coat and left between the security staff, still a colleague, already an external party.

Lin watched through the glass panel in the door as Hsu waited for an escort lift that did not require her badge. The yellow rectangle remained visible on the factory floor beyond her, empty and brightly marked.

Cao came back to the whiteboard.

"Erase the old roadmap," she said.

Lin cleaned away the accelerators Yulan could no longer build. When she reached the new drawing, she stopped.

"That too," Cao said. "Then reconstruct it somewhere the cameras do not own."

Lin erased Hsu's package, her own arrows, and the circle that joined them.

The missing machine left only the yellow rectangle on the factory floor.

Chapter 10: Northbound

Oriol hid the route to Figueres inside a document that said nothing should go there.

Mei found it on Friday morning when the false collection order began to separate in the heat.

Police had photographed the three pages, logged the original and released the sleeve back to Llevant under an evidence receipt. One corner of the second page lifted from the third. Mei slid a fingernail beneath it and felt two sheets where the order claimed one.

“Glue,” she said.

Arnau looked up from the clean warehouse laptop. “On paper?”

“Your industry has forgotten it exists.”

She warmed the sleeve beneath a desk lamp and worked the pages apart with a thin plastic rule. The hidden sheet was narrower and printed on heavier stock. A return docket from the Tour de France Grand Départ, dated 6 July. Guaita Event Resilience had sent two temporary contribution gateways from Barcelona to a post-event depot in Figueres.

The route code named stage three.

“The Tour went through Figueres?” Mei asked.

“No,” Arnau said.

“Certainty or memory?”

He opened Ephemeris on the cleanest company view available, entered no private data, and asked for the published 2026 stage routes. The assistant returned the Barcelona team time trial, Tarragona to Barcelona, then Granollers towards Les Angles through the Pyrenean corridor.

Figueres appeared nowhere.

Ephemeris supplied official links, driving estimates and the night-opening hours for the Dalí Theatre-Museum. It did not refuse, report him or improve the mystery. Tools behaved better when people asked them questions without hidden bodies.

“The docket is false,” Júlia said.

“The collection order is false,” Mei replied. “The docket was hidden inside it by somebody who knew I would inspect the paper.”

“Oriol.”

“Possibly.”

Arnau pointed to a short mark beside the return address. Blue ink, the same colour as Oriol’s notes on the Shodan printout. It looked like a badly drawn eye or a circle divided by a line.

Júlia moved closer. “That is the dome.”

“It is six millimetres of ink,” Mei said.

“He draws it on every Figueres schedule. He thinks Dalí gives technicians permission to make clocks look artistic.”

“Does he also glue schedules into forged shipping orders?”

“Not normally.”

Thursday had produced no other route. The police would not share the Girona card location because Arnau was neither family nor investigator. Guaita had suspended his building access pending an internal interview he had not attended. The dark van did not return to Llevant, which meant only that it had learned not to stop in front of the window.

Arnau and Mei changed hotels once, openly and without aliases. False names would only create another record that could be used against them. Each kept one bag packed. Home had become the place where their unused things waited with the watch.

At ten, Arnau attended his suspension interview from the hotel’s single chair. Mei sat on the bed outside the laptop camera’s view and listened to Lenticular reduce eleven years of work to four questions.

Had he copied restricted media from Oriol’s workspace? Yes.

Had he submitted camera metadata and traffic-capture summaries to an external AI system? No. Ephemeris was Lenticular’s licensed enterprise service.

Had he transferred company material to Llevant Import? He had transferred a still that displayed Llevant’s identity to Llevant’s operations director.

Would he return all retained material and cease independent contact with eclipse partners? No.

The human-resources representative remained a voice behind a company title card. Reixac appeared on camera from an office with no visible window.

“This is not disciplinary theatre,” Reixac said. “The event is five days away. We need one version of the incident.”

“You already have one,” Arnau replied. “That is the problem.”

“I am offering you a protected investigation inside Guaita. Full access, counsel, an evidence room and no further personal exposure.”

“Will Mei have access?”

“Llevant is an interested external party. Its evidence can be represented.”

“By whom?”

“That is what counsel means.”

Mei watched Arnau understand the offer completely. He could return to the system he knew, see the records Reixac selected and tell himself that restricted access was still access. Llevant would enter as a statement summarized by someone whose salary came from the company using its name.

“No,” Arnau said.

The title card spoke. His company credentials would be suspended immediately. His 3Cat access would be reviewed by the broadcaster, not Lenticular. He was not to contact project staff through company systems.

One by one, sessions ended on the laptop behind the call. Contribution dashboard. Engineering archive. Team chat. The remote support window he had kept open for three months turned grey and asked him to authenticate.

A message from a junior engineer arrived on his personal phone before the last session closed.

I have been told not to answer technical questions from you. I am sorry.

Arnau read it twice and typed three different replies. He sent none. Any answer would ask the engineer to choose between a colleague and an employer while the eclipse platform was live.

Reixac remained after the representative left.

"You believe refusal keeps your hands clean," he said.

"No. I believe your room decides which dirt is visible."

"When the public feeds fail on Wednesday, people will not ask whether your principles had good provenance. They will ask who kept the pictures alive."

"And you intend the answer to be Guaita."

"I intend there to be an answer."

The call ended. Arnau's name disappeared from the contribution roster while he watched.

He closed the laptop without saying what the loss meant. Mei knew anyway. Arnau had built systems he complained about daily and trusted with the deeper confidence reserved for things one had repaired personally. Reixac had not only removed his access. He had made continued concern look like trespass.

At noon they decided to go north.

Berta remained at 3Cat. She had live programmes, eclipse briefings and the useful protection of being expected on camera at known times. She booked three night entries to the museum under her own name, then complained that this made her an accomplice to tourism.

"Call when you arrive," she said. "Call sooner if a grey car and a dark van begin arguing over you."

"How would cars argue?" Arnau asked.

"You will explain the mechanism afterwards."

Mei drove. Arnau sat beside her with his small radio kit beneath his feet. Júlia took the back seat and the false docket. They carried one overnight bag each, although nobody had agreed where they would sleep.

Barcelona released them slowly. The motorway north shimmered beneath the heat. Dashboard temperature rose each time traffic stopped and fell only after they moved long enough for the car to forget the city.

A black Guaita van joined behind them near the first service area.

It was not the damaged dark van. This one carried the company name in small grey letters and a roof case used by field teams. Legal, visible and easier to explain.

Arnau's phone rang through the car system.

Reixac.

Mei answered without taking her eyes from the road. "He is driving."

"I know," Reixac said. "I am calling both of you."

"Then you know where we are."

"A company vehicle passed Arnau's account token at the motorway gate. It is an ordinary security notice, not surveillance."

They were in Mei's car. Arnau's account token was inside his work phone.

"What do you want?" Arnau asked.

"For you to return the Room Zero material you took from Lenticular systems."

They had not yet found Room Zero. Reixac had named it before them.

Júlia leaned forward between the seats.

“What is Room Zero?” she asked loudly enough for the microphone.

Reixac paused. “A continuity category. The room that remains when public rooms fail.”

“A room absent from the plan,” Arnau said.

“All systems have exceptions. Fragmentation makes them invisible and therefore unaccountable. You of all people should understand why observability matters.”

“Observation by whom?” he asked.

“That is governance, not engineering. Come back and help design it. Your access can be restored today.”

Mei ended the call.

“I was still speaking,” Arnau said.

“That is why I ended it.”

“He named Room Zero.”

“And offered you your job. Which fact frightened you more?”

Arnau did not answer.

“Do we know the driver?” Júlia asked.

“We know the employer,” Arnau said.

“Your employer.”

“I am suspended from the building, not dismissed.”

“A generous distinction.”

Mei watched the van through the mirror. It remained two vehicles behind when she moved right. When she passed a slow camper, it passed the camper. Nothing it did proved pursuit. Everything together made coincidence work too hard.

“We should leave the motorway,” Arnau said.

“And do what?”

“See whether it follows.”

“It knows where the docket points. Testing the van only tells it that we know it knows.”

“Then we drive to Figueres with Guaita behind us.”

“Yes. At least the road signs will reduce disagreement.”

At the next service area Mei turned in without signalling early. The Guaita van continued north.

“Not following,” Júlia said.

“Or better at it,” Arnau replied.

They parked in the narrow shade beside the fuel shop. Heat reached them through the windscreen before Mei turned off the engine. Families crossed the tarmac carrying cold drinks and children whose faces had reached the red edge of patience. Every table beneath the awning was occupied.

The grey EBRO stood beside the exit.

Mei had not seen it behind them.

The driver’s seat was empty. A man in sunglasses sat on the passenger side, his face angled towards the motorway rather than their car. He could have been waiting for someone inside. He could have been watching the northbound traffic for the Guaita van.

“Two calls,” Júlia said quietly.

“That was yesterday’s system,” Mei replied.

Arnau reached for the radio case.

“Leave it.”

“I can check whether they are transmitting.”

“And if they are?”

He left the case beneath his feet.

They entered the shop separately and bought nothing useful: water, peaches hard enough to travel, a charging cable because Arnau had left his at home, and three bags of ice that became two bags and a leak before they reached the car.

The passenger remained in the EBRO.

Mei pulled back onto the motorway.

The grey car waited until two vehicles passed, then followed.

Ten kilometres later, the Guaita van appeared ahead of them.

It had reduced speed in the right lane. Mei’s car approached while the EBRO held position behind. For half a minute they travelled between the two vehicles, a private arrangement moving at a hundred kilometres an hour among holiday traffic.

“Do not speed,” Júlia said.

“I am not.”

“Do not slow down.”

“Choose a fear.”

The Guaita van indicated right and entered a rest pull-off. Mei passed it.

The EBRO did not.

It followed Guaita off the motorway and disappeared from the mirror.

Arnau turned in his seat. “They are watching each other.”

“We established that at Walden,” Mei said.

“They let us continue.”

“That is new.”

The absence of both vehicles lasted twenty-three minutes. It felt less safe than either tail. Mei checked every joining road and every vehicle that stayed behind for more than one exit. A delivery truck. A French family. Two motorcycles riding too close together. No van. No EBRO.

Júlia studied the docket.

“This depot name is wrong,” she said.

“It is fictional,” Arnau replied.

“No. It is designed. Look at the line breaks.”

The address occupied three centred lines. A normal logistics system would align them left. The longest line sat in the middle, the shorter lines above and below.

“A triangle,” Mei said.

“A viewpoint. Oriol wants us to stand somewhere.”

“Inside the museum?”

“Or he wants me to think that.”

“Why you?” Arnau asked.

Júlia folded the docket along its original crease. “Because he knew where the first Atlas tests happened and asked me about perspective.”

Arnau looked at her in the mirror. “When?”

“Last Friday. Our eleven-minute meeting.”

“You said he asked about an old gateway.”

“He did. Then he asked whether a false room could be detected from one camera.”

“And you told him Figueres.”

“I told him perspective. He supplied Figueres himself.”

The road opened towards the plain. Figueres waited in heat beneath a sky scrubbed almost white. They would arrive hours before the museum’s night doors opened at half past nine.

Mei checked the mirror again.

A beige car had joined behind them. The driver was a woman wearing dark glasses. She stayed far enough back to be competent or uninvolved.

“Another one?” Arnau asked.

“Maybe.”

“How many parties now?”

“Ask me when one of them helps.”

Ahead, a motorway sign offered Figueres as a destination. The false docket had done the same with more imagination.

Chapter 11: Dalí by Night

At 21:24, the museum had six minutes left before opening and the woman from the beige car was already inside.

Arnau saw her through the glass entrance, speaking to an attendant beneath the red facade. Dark glasses now rested on her head. She carried no bag and wore shoes that looked chosen for stone floors rather than a drive from Barcelona.

“Maybe she has a ticket,” he said.

“A radical theory,” Mei replied.

The evening heat had not left Figueres. It rose from the paving around the Teatre-Museu and held the waiting visitors together in a loose line. Families, couples, a guided group negotiating four languages, two children asking whether night began when the museum opened or when the sky became dark.

Above them, the glass dome caught the last light.

Júlia looked at the false Tour docket again. Three centred address lines, arranged like a viewing mark.

“Oriol expected me to come here,” she said.

“Because you are from Figueres?” Arnau asked.

“Because he knew I would hate the clue.”

“Why?”

“Surrealism is not the absence of rules. People use it to excuse anything they cannot be bothered to understand. Dalí constructed the view. He did not throw objects into a room and hope tourists supplied meaning.”

The doors opened at half past nine.

Their tickets were under Berta’s name. The attendant checked them without interest in the conspiracy required to purchase museum admission. Arnau felt briefly offended by the ordinary transaction, then relieved.

A man waited beyond the entrance beside the Cadillac courtyard. He wore a museum technical-services badge and held a folded lighting plan. Grey hair, narrow face, black shirt despite the temperature.

“Arnau Vidal?” he asked.

“Who told you?”

“Oriol. Six days ago. He said a difficult engineer might arrive instead of him. I expected taller.”

“Miquel Sastre?”

“Quel. Only the tax office calls me Miquel.”

They moved away from the arriving visitors. The courtyard opened above them, night gathering around the edges while gold figures watched from the walls. Quel did not lower his voice. The building already contained enough strange conversations to protect one more.

“Oriol asked about a video,” Arnau said.

“He asked about false depth. Then he sent eleven seconds of a room and told me not to answer by telephone.”

“Did you answer?”

“I told him to come and stand in the correct place. He enjoyed being mysterious when a direct train would have worked.”

“He disappeared instead.”

Quel’s irritation left. “I know.”

“Do you have the clip?”

“No. Museum devices do not receive unknown files from television producers at two in the morning. I watched it on his screen during a video call.”

“What did you see?”

“A boring room designed by somebody who thought boring meant trustworthy. I told him that. He said the boring was the important part.”

Quel led them through the museum with the impatience of a technician crossing his workplace. Visitors stopped. He went around them. Paintings, stone, velvet, glass and staged surprise passed in fragments. Arnau resisted the urge to turn every reflection into surveillance.

Júlia stopped beneath the dome.

She unfolded the false docket and held its three centred address lines against the curve above them. The longest line matched nothing. She moved left, then right, then climbed three steps until an attendant asked her to keep the paper away from the railing.

“The dome is the mark Oriol drew,” Arnau said.

“Which is why it may be bait.”

“For whom?”

“For anyone who thinks recognizing a symbol is the same as understanding it.”

She tried another position. Visitors flowed around her and began looking upward because she did. Within a minute six strangers were photographing the part of the dome her paper seemed to identify. None asked whether she had found anything.

The woman from the beige car joined them.

She raised her phone towards the dome. Its dark screen reflected Júlia, Arnau and the docket more clearly than the glass above. She took one picture and lowered it.

Arnau stepped towards her.

A family entered between them. When they passed, the woman was examining a framed work on the opposite wall with both hands visible.

“She photographed us,” Arnau said.

“She photographed the dome,” Mei replied.

“We were in the screen.”

“Then every visitor with reflective glass has photographed us. Do not let one correct suspicion make all the others free.”

Quel took the docket from Júlia and folded it once along its existing crease. “Oriol drew the dome on schedules because it amused him. He also drew ants on invoices he disliked. If you follow every mark, the museum will close before the useful one.”

The first reading had failed. The address did not select a work, room or direction from the courtyard. It selected only a viewer eager to be selected.

The woman from the beige car remained two rooms behind.

She did not look at them. She looked at the work, moved when the route moved, and never consulted a guide. At one doorway she vanished. At the next, Arnau saw her reflection before he saw her.

“Do you know that woman?” he asked Quel.

“I know people who work here. She does not.”

“Should we tell security?”

“That a visitor is visiting? No. You should stop behaving like thieves.”

The Mae West Room made Quel slow down.

From below, its objects remained objects: a sofa shaped as lips, framed images, features distributed across a room. From the elevated viewing point, they became a face. The installation did not change. Position organized it.

“Here,” he said.

Júlia had already climbed to the viewpoint.

She looked once, descended and took Arnau’s phone from his hand.

“The clip.”

“Police have the file.”

“You have the still.”

He opened the frame he had sent Mei. The white equipment room, edge of a wheeled case, unreadable surfaces except for the false Llevant words they had enlarged.

Júlia held the phone at arm’s length, then lowered it until the screen aligned with the room beyond. She was not comparing the image to Mae West. She was using the viewing platform to force Arnau to see that a picture could contain a room only from one place.

“The left wall,” she said.

“What about it?”

“It has no thickness.”

“It is a video.”

“The camera vibrates with the ventilation. Watch the door edge against the case.”

Arnau played the eleven seconds from the private copy on his personal storage, the copy he had already admitted to Reixac’s investigators. The frame moved by less than a pixel, the ordinary tremor of a fixed camera mounted near machinery.

The case shifted against the door.

The wall did not.

“Printed surface,” Quel said. “Or a screen.”

“A flat placed behind the case,” Júlia replied. “The camera stands at the one position where the perspective completes the room.”

“You saw that last Friday?” Arnau asked.

She did not answer.

Mei took the phone. “If the room is false, what is real?”

“The case. The near floor. The ventilation sound. Maybe the door edge. Everything else is an image.”

“And the clock?”

“Real enough to carry the fault.”

Arnau watched Júlia. “You asked Oriol whether a false room could be detected from one camera.”

“He asked me.”

“Because you had already told him how to build one.”

“Because I once designed calibration rooms. If every camera sees the same targets from a known position, you can measure clock and lens error without taking the system into the field.”

“Atlas rooms.”

“The prototype did not have that name.”

“But it had rooms.”

The woman from the beige car stepped onto the viewing platform.

For one second she occupied the position above them and looked down through the optical frame. Her gaze did not stop on the face assembled by the room. It stopped on Arnau’s phone.

Then she moved.

Too quickly for a visitor who had waited to reach the correct view.

Arnau followed.

She crossed into the next room without running. He lost sight of her behind a guided group, found her near a stair, then lost her again when a museum attendant asked him not to move against the visitor route.

“I need to speak to that woman.”

“Then speak without pushing people.”

By the time Arnau reached the courtyard, she had disappeared.

He checked the entrance. Nobody had left through it. A technical door stood closed beside a red cord. He reached for the handle.

Quel caught his arm.

“No.”

“She went through here.”

“Then I call our security. You do not turn a museum into your private chase.”

“She followed us from the motorway.”

“That does not give you a key.”

Quel called the control desk. Staff checked the public route and exits. They found no woman matching Arnau’s description. They did not surrender camera footage to a visitor who said his friend was missing. Their competence was an obstacle and a reassurance.

At 22:46, Quel took them to an interior terrace where visitors were offered cava. An audiovisual projection had been cancelled because equipment disliked the heat. The sky above the courtyard was clear. Arnau did not drink.

Mei set the false docket beside the phone.

“The address is not an address,” she said. “It tells us where to stand. The video tells us the room is a picture. What does the picture hide?”

Júlia replayed the clip without looking at the false wall.

Eleven seconds. Ventilation. A case. The edge of real floor. The timestamp losing 1.7 seconds twice.

“Sound,” she said.

Quel leaned closer. “The fan changes at the fourth second.”

“Not the fan. Behind it.”

Arnau raised the volume. Beneath the ventilation came a small repeating impact, almost absorbed by the compression. Three beats, a pause, then three again.

“Rail joint?” he asked.

“Too regular,” Quel said.

Mei listened. “Loading door.”

“How can you know?”

“A loose chain striking a guide when the shutter moves. Three strikes on the way up. Three on the way down.”

“That gives us every warehouse in Catalonia,” Arnau said.

“No. The video excludes the warehouse. Whoever built the false wall wanted us to see a clean equipment room and not ask why a loading shutter was operating behind it.”

Júlia froze the frame at the first clock jump. In the curved metal handle of the case, a narrow reflection interrupted the white wall. Not a landmark. A band of orange light, then darkness, then orange again.

“Vehicle beacon,” Arnau said.

“Or a warning lamp above a shutter,” Mei replied.

“The light crosses twice in eleven seconds.”

“Because the camera clock shows three islands, not one continuous event,” Júlia said. “Oriol assembled them.”

“To say what?”

“That the room moves.”

Quel looked at her. “A truck body.”

The false equipment room was inside a vehicle or removable staging container. The loading shutter sound came from wherever it had parked. Oriol’s clip did not show where he was. It showed that the place carrying him could become a different room for any camera that found it.

The museum announced that forty-five minutes remained before closing. Visitors began making choices about what they had not yet seen.

Júlia looked across the terrace.

The woman from the beige car stood on the opposite gallery.

This time she held one finger to her lips. With the other hand she placed a white card on the stone ledge.

Then the lights between them dimmed for the scheduled lighting check.

When they rose, she was gone.

The card remained.

Quel retrieved it because he worked there and Arnau did not. One side was blank. The other carried a Girona restaurant reservation for four people at one thirty the following afternoon.

The name on the booking was **Salvador Reixac**.

Chapter 12: Negative Space

The most useful part of Oriol's false room was the equipment it did not contain.

Mei found the absence at eight on Saturday morning in a hotel breakfast room in Figueres. The coffee came from a machine that made six drinks from the same brown ingredient. Arnau had selected *intens* and received louder water. Júlia had eaten nothing.

They occupied a table beside the window with the eleven-second clip paused between them. Other guests planned beaches, museums and routes north in low voices. Nobody appeared to be following them. Mei had stopped treating that as good news.

"A mobile technical room needs levelling," she said.

Arnau looked at the screen. "It could be self-levelling."

"Then it needs controls. A road unit needs tiedowns, protected corners, cable entries, emergency markings, something that admits it moves. This room shows none of them."

"Because the wall is false."

"The real floor is not. Neither is the case. Whoever staged it removed every object that describes transport."

Júlia drank water. "Negative space."

"Paperwork calls it scope. If a photograph excludes the thing a consignee needs to accept a delivery, the photograph was made for someone else."

Mei enlarged the narrow real floor beneath the wheeled case. Two parallel dark marks ran towards the false wall.

"Forklift tines," she said. "Not wheels. The whole room is a removable body lifted from below. It was carried into a larger building."

The orange reflection in the case handle could be a warning lamp above that building's shutter. The loose chain supplied the repeating impact. Oriol had made his movable room inside a warehouse, then hidden the warehouse behind a picture.

"That still gives us many buildings," Arnau said.

"It gives us a type of supplier."

Mei called Joel.

He answered over forklift noise. Saturday had no respect for their investigation.

"Find companies that rent removable broadcast rooms," she said. "Not trucks. Bodies that can be loaded, powered and cooled inside a depot. Girona or Figueres."

"How quickly?"

"Before this coffee becomes honest."

"Then never."

He asked three neighbouring wholesalers, a trade-show installer and a driver who transported

refrigerated pharmacy displays. Human queries travelled without keywords, audit logs or a model deciding that mobile rooms might be dangerous. They also travelled with gossip attached.

Nine minutes later Joel sent two names.

One rented festival toilets.

The other, Tramuntana Modular Services, supplied temporary control cabins, editing rooms and cooled equipment bodies. Its public address lay in a small industrial area south of Girona. Its website contained photographs, insurance certificates and a list of event clients. Guaita's name did not appear.

Mei compared the false Tour docket with a sample delivery form on the site.

Both used the same six-box damage diagram at the bottom.

"Template," she said.

"Copied?" Arnau asked.

"Or supplied with a rental. The fake Figueres return tells us where to look. Its form tells us who moved the room."

They checked out without returning to their rooms together. Mei left through the front, Arnau through the car park, Júlia after settling a bill already paid online. The precautions delayed them and deceived nobody they could identify.

The beige car was gone.

The drive south to Girona took less than an hour. Heat arrived early, flattening the fields beyond the motorway and turning every patch of shade into occupied territory. The Guaita van did not appear. Neither did the EBRO.

Tramuntana Modular Services occupied a fenced yard behind a tyre warehouse. Rows of white cabins stood on metal feet. Some had windows. Others carried ventilation units and blank panels where client branding could be applied. From the public road they resembled temporary classrooms, site offices and broadcast rooms because the same rectangle could become any of them after delivery.

"Do not enter," Arnau said.

Mei parked at reception.

"That is entering."

"It is a business. Businesses have doors for questions."

A bell announced them inside. The man at the desk wore reading glasses repaired with black tape and had a plate of sliced peach beside the keyboard. He continued eating while Mei explained that a false return docket named Llevant as shipper and used his company's damage form.

She did not mention Atlas, Ingot or a missing television producer. She showed him the paper.

He wiped his fingers before touching it.

"Old version," he said. "We changed this diagram in March."

"Who still has the old form?"

"Every customer who ever downloaded it."

"Who rented two technical bodies for the Tour?"

"That is customer information."

Mei gave him Llevant's police incident number.

"Then police can ask."

“They will. Before they do, a municipal store in the south has five empty cases with our name on them. If your form put them there, your company will be in the same question.”

He read the docket again. His peach waited.

“We supplied three bodies to Guaita,” he said. “Two returned. One extended for an eclipse contract.”

“Where is it?”

“Not here.”

The answer arrived too smoothly.

Mei looked through the reception window. Beyond the first row of white cabins, an orange warning lamp stood above a high shutter. A loose chain hung beside its guide.

Three strikes sounded from the warehouse.

A pause.

Three more.

The man removed his glasses. “You should leave.”

“Did Oriol Cendrós come here on Sunday?”

He looked towards the yard.

That was answer enough.

“He rented the remaining body under a 3Cat production reference,” Mei said. “He came alone.”

“I did not say that.”

“No. You looked at the place he parked.”

Arnau followed her gaze. A dusty blue hatchback stood behind two cabins, partly hidden by a stack of barriers.

Oriol’s car.

The man stood. “I am calling the police.”

“Please do. Tell them a missing man’s car is in your yard.”

He held the phone without dialling.

Júlia moved to the window. “Which body did he use?”

The closest cabin carried fresh white paint across one side. Its floor height and ventilation grille matched the real edges in the clip. A strip of adhesive remained where a false wall had been removed.

“He arrived before four on Sunday morning,” the man said. “The booking had been made the evening before, and he brought his own equipment case. He asked us to power the cabin before dawn. He left at ten.”

“In his car?”

“He came back after lunch. Paid for fuel at the station because our account card failed. Two men were waiting.”

“Guaita?”

“They had an incident order. They said the cabin carried unauthorized broadcast material.”

“Did he go with them?”

“He argued. Then one showed him something on a phone. He stopped arguing.”

“Weapon?”

“I saw a screen. Nothing else. They took him in a dark van. One drove his car back inside. They said police would collect it.”

“You did not call police?”

“They knew his production reference, his booking and his name. They had badges.”

Mei thought of Joel and the Yulan security card. A badge opened one door. The story around it opened the next six.

“Show us the cabin,” Arnau said.

“No.”

“Our friend was taken from it.”

“Then police will inspect it. You will not.”

Again, competence blocked them correctly.

The man finally dialled. He gave the address, Oriol’s registration and the incident number from Mei’s paper. While he spoke, Mei watched the white cabin through the glass.

Oriol had built the eleven seconds himself. He had used his valid production reference, his knowledge of Arnau’s habits, Júlia’s calibration method and Llevant’s stolen identity. He had disappeared voluntarily long enough to make Arnau follow.

Then Guaita had found him.

“Why not tell us directly?” Arnau asked.

“Because Reixac owns your messages, your office and the systems Oriol knew,” Júlia said. “If you did not know his plan, you could not give it away.”

“He made us instruments.”

Arnau walked towards Oriol’s car.

Mei caught his arm before he crossed the reception threshold. “Do not touch it.”

“I am looking through the window.”

“You are going to open the door because it is his.”

“If his phone is inside, or another note, or anything that tells us where they took him, waiting for an evidence team gives Guaita the afternoon.”

“And touching it gives Guaita our fingerprints in the car of a man who signed a false order against my company.”

“He left us the route.”

“He sent a collector to my shutter.”

“Guaita sent the second team.”

“Oriol sent the first.”

Arnau stopped. Behind the windscreen, a paper coffee cup leaned in the centre holder. Oriol’s red reading glasses rested open on the passenger seat. He owned four pairs and lost all of them in rooms he later remembered. Arnau had spent a week looking for a man and found the habit first.

“Those glasses are not evidence,” Mei said more quietly.

“Everything is evidence to you until it belongs to someone I love.”

“Everything belongs to someone you love today. That is the problem.”

The man at the desk looked away. Júlia moved to the far side of reception and watched the access road, giving them the smallest privacy the room permitted.

Arnau put both hands against his thighs. “If we stop, what happens to him?”

“Police search. We give them the car, this witness and the mobile room.”

“The same police who let an authorized incident crew collect him?”

“A depot worker let them.”

“Because the badges were good. Every badge is good. Every record arrives finished. You know that better than I do.”

“Yes. Which is why we cannot keep making private records and expecting the public ones to become honest around us.”

Arnau turned from the car. “You want to stop because Llevant is exposed.”

“My father has answered questions twice about a machine he never saw. Pilar is losing an order. Our home is open. Oriol chose our name because he knew I would reject his serial loudly enough for you to hear.”

“You think I do not see that?”

“I think you see Oriol at the end of every line.”

“He is at the end of this one. His car is ten metres away.”

“And Ingot?”

“A machine.”

“You did not call it that when you asked Llevant to wait three days before we opened the case.”

Arnau looked past her at the taped glasses of the depot manager, the untouched peach, the mobile body with fresh paint.

“If we walk away,” he said, “I will come back without you.”

Mei believed him.

“Then I come too,” she said.

“That is not agreement.”

“No. It is me refusing to let your flaw become my alibi.”

He looked at her then.

“We give the police the car,” Mei said. “We do not touch it. We keep following the room until we find Oriol or until the next step asks us to trade somebody else for him. At that point, I choose too.”

“And Llevant?”

“Not collateral.”

“Ingot?”

“Not a person.”

“You made me say that.”

“You needed to hear yourself say it.”

Mei looked at Oriol’s abandoned car. “He wanted us to keep going. That does not mean we should.”

Her phone showed 11:47.

“We leave before they arrive,” Mei said.

“The police?” Arnau asked.

“Everyone.”

She placed Reixac’s reservation card on the desk long enough for the taped-glasses man to see the name, then took it back.

“And go where?” Arnau asked.

“Lunch.”

The reception barrier did not rise.

The man pressed the control beneath his desk. The motor answered, but the arm remained horizontal across the only vehicle exit. A fault light blinked amber.

"Heat," he said. "It sticks."

Mei looked through the window. A black Guaita van had turned into the access road. It stopped beyond the barrier without blocking the public street. Two people inside. Neither got out.

"That is who took him," Arnau said.

The man at the desk went pale. "You cannot know that."

"Did their incident vehicle look like that?"

He did not answer.

The man in taped glasses stayed on the phone. The police operator kept asking whether the missing person was currently present, and he kept saying no while watching the van.

Mei tested the personnel door. It opened onto the yard, not the road. Rows of modular bodies stood between reception and a signed emergency gate at the far end. The gate admitted people but not their car.

"Take your documents," the man said. "I will tell them you left before they arrived."

"Why help us now?" Júlia asked.

"I am helping my business remain a witness instead of becoming another room."

They left the car beside reception and crossed the yard on foot. No running. A person who ran between industrial cabins invited every window to invent a reason.

The Guaita van's doors opened behind them.

Arnau turned. Mei caught the strap of his equipment case and pulled him onwards.

"We have Oriol's car and a witness," he said.

"We have a statement the witness has not signed and a car we cannot touch."

"If they move either?"

"Then the police arrive at the movement."

The first cabin row ended at a locked mesh gate. The emergency release sat beneath a green cover. Mei lifted it. An alarm began inside the reception building, local and loud.

The two Guaita workers entered the yard. One called Arnau's name.

He stopped for half a step. Reixac had removed that name from his systems the morning before. Guaita still knew exactly where to use it.

Júlia pushed the release. The gate opened towards the public pavement. They passed through, let it close and joined pedestrians walking towards a supermarket beyond the industrial road.

The Guaita workers did not force the emergency gate. One photographed them through the mesh. The other spoke to the man from reception while the alarm continued.

At the next corner, Mei called the investigating officer herself. She gave the yard address, the van, the stuck barrier and the emergency exit they had used. She asked him to treat their own car, left beside reception, as part of the scene. Leaving before police arrived no longer resembled innocence. She put the untidy version into the record before Guaita supplied a clean one.

They continued on foot towards the lunch where Reixac expected them.

Behind the high shutter, the chain struck three times.

Something large was being moved before the police could ask to see it.

Chapter 13: Appetite

Hélène Vasseur ordered the xuletó before Salvador Reixac offered to sell her a country.

“For two,” the waiter said.

“I am aware.”

Vasseur closed the menu. She was a broad-shouldered woman of forty-seven who wore white linen without ever appearing to spill anything. Appetite was part of her method. She chose the largest cut, the longest contract and the chair that allowed everyone else to see her choose.

Leïla Haddad sat to her left and watched the entrance in the reflection of a wine cabinet.

At 13:34, Mei Zhou entered with Arnau Vidal and Júlia Muntaner.

They had followed the card Leïla left in Figueres. A taxi from the supermarket rank had brought them, and their own car would stay in the yard as part of the police scene until Chen could collect it with a signed release. On the ride in, the Onyar and its coloured facades had appeared between buildings and vanished before Arnau could finish naming the route. Heat still marked all three collars. Júlia chose a position with both exits in view. The restaurant host stopped them beside the reservation desk. Saturday lunch had been full for weeks. Reixac’s table had four seats, all occupied.

Reixac noticed them without turning his head.

His sister Clara did turn. She placed her napkin beside her plate and rose.

“Senyora Zhou,” she said. “We should speak.”

Mei looked at the table, then at Leïla. Recognition passed without welcome. Leïla had removed the dark glasses. The absence of disguise was its own warning.

“You left the card,” Mei said.

“Did she?” Reixac asked.

Leïla smiled. “I lose paper.”

Vasseur looked between them. “Your local investigation has arrived. How convenient.”

Her Catalan was formal and lightly accented. Reixac called her a French resilience consultant. Leïla knew Narthex as the company that had asked Atlas where Karim Bensaïd went before his family could.

Karim had entered three Marseille cameras and failed to leave any of them. No body, arrest or border crossing followed. Six weeks later, his name appeared in a private demonstration traced to Guaita.

Leïla had spent eighteen months reaching this lunch. Beneath her napkin, in the same sleeve, waited a decoy of Reixac’s demonstration card, loaded with the Narthex sample from Marseille and prepared before dawn.

Sami Bellal would collect the original from a public locker that night and carry it to a lawyer. He believed it concerned a commercial dispute.

“Say that nothing I carry will identify another person,” he had told her that morning.

“The pouch will contain records about companies and contracts.”

The answer was literally true. It had spent the trust beneath it.

Clara guided Mei towards a small side table. “Five minutes. Your husband can hear everything if you prefer.”

“I prefer.”

Arnau and Júlia remained standing. The host disliked the disruption but disliked Reixac’s importance more. Two chairs appeared, then a third. Food made room for power with professional speed.

At the main table, Vasseur ate the first course in two bites. She listened to the wine’s provenance with the attention she denied the provenance of data.

“The eclipse run,” she said to Reixac. “What does it change?”

“Coverage becomes ownership,” Reixac replied. “Atlas presently knows that two cameras probably share a gateway. Guaita already holds the maintenance accounts, address records and asset sheets for every partner it keeps running. After calibration, Atlas knows which of those records belongs to which picture: which maintenance account reaches the recorder and which physical room serves both.”

“Knows?”

“Assigns confidence.”

“Your proposal uses the word *knows* fourteen times. *Confidence* appears twice.”

Reixac folded bread through oil. “Sales language.”

“I am buying the sales language. My clients will buy certainty.”

Leïla kept her phone face down beside her water glass. Its microphone did not need to hear every word. It needed Reixac’s voice describing Atlas and Vasseur’s voice accepting post-eclipse access.

“Exclusive?” Vasseur asked.

“For metropolitan deployment outside Spain, twelve months.”

“Marseille first.”

“Your choice.”

“And the hardware?”

“European custody.”

“That was not my question.”

Reixac drank water. “The inference architecture will be available under a separate licence once provenance is resolved. Atlas does not depend on ownership of one prototype.”

At the side table, Clara opened a thin folder.

“Llevant is named on two incident records,” she told Mei. “A false shipment in the south and a receiver crate used during an unauthorized traffic event. By Monday, one of those will be public.”

“They are both false.”

“I believe you. Belief is not the service I am offering.”

She placed three pages in front of Mei. Cooperation agreement. Corrective statement. Non-disparagement undertaking.

“Guaita will certify that a subcontractor reused Llevant’s customer template in error. We will cover legal costs associated with the municipal shipment. Your company will provide the five Yulan cases for independent inspection and make no public allegation concerning the eclipse programme.”

“The fifth case is empty.”

“Then inspection will establish that.”

“It will establish that Llevant received a strategic machine and lost it.”

Clara did not deny the word *strategic*. “Without this agreement, a reporter will write that before anyone writes *received without informed consent*. Your parents’ company will become the photograph used for every warehouse in Badalona Sud.”

Clara added one page to the folder. It was a copy of the council request Pilar Forn had received that morning, annotated by Guaita’s insurer. Thirty emergency radios remained on hold pending supply-chain review.

“Your customer forwarded this to the municipal buyer,” Clara said. “The buyer asked the eclipse coordination office whether Llevant appeared in any active incident. Guaita is required to answer.”

Mei read Pilar’s message at the bottom of the page. **Declarations supplied. Awaiting clarification. Staff allocation expires at sixteen hundred.**

“Two temporary workers lose the shift at four,” Clara said.

“You contacted my customer.”

“Your customer contacted an authority. The authority contacted the event office. This is what records do when people use them correctly.”

“And the clarification?”

Clara placed a prepared statement beside the agreement. It said Llevant was not the subject of Guaita’s equipment inquiry. Signed, dated, ready to send.

“It leaves this table when the cooperation letter does,” she said.

Pilar’s order, two workers’ pay and thirty radios intended for people already travelling into heat now lay beneath Mei’s hand.

Arnau leaned closer. “Do not sign.”

Mei held up one finger without looking at him. She read every page again, her thumb fixed on Pilar’s deadline while the corner of the cooperation letter lifted in the air conditioning. From Leïla’s side of the table, refusal looked no cleaner than consent. Guaita had made sure of that.

Clara waited with her pen uncapped.

“What happens to the stolen ledger?” Mei asked.

“If recovered, it returns through counsel.”

“And Oriol Cendrós?”

“Not part of this agreement.”

“Then your agreement is too small.”

“It is exactly the size I can enforce.”

The xuletó arrived at the main table on a hot plate, cut thick and dark at the edges. The waiter served Vasseur first. She asked for salt and did not look at the meat until the waiter withdrew.

Reixac opened a leather folio. Inside lay a slim black storage card in a numbered sleeve.

“Sample index,” he said. “One district. Historical feeds. No live access.”

Vasseur ate before taking it. “Which district?”

“Marseille test data.”

Leïla kept her face still.

“Source?” Vasseur asked.

“Your office supplied it.”

“My office supplies many things.”

Karim’s district lay within the likely sample. If his trace existed on that card, Leïla could prove Narthex had possessed an Atlas fragment before he vanished. If she allowed Vasseur to take it, the evidence would enter private custody and cease to exist whenever convenient.

Clara slid a pen towards Mei.

At the same moment, Leïla knocked her own water glass over.

Water crossed towards Reixac’s folio. He lifted the leather clear. Vasseur moved the hot plate and a waiter arrived with cloths.

Leïla stood, touched the numbered sleeve and exchanged it for the card beneath her napkin. If Reixac checked now, she would not reach the corridor. If Vasseur acted on the decoy, she would act on a Marseille sample with the three neighbourhoods that pointed at Karim’s district cut out of it, and Sami would carry the warning.

For one second white linen and hands covered the table. When they cleared, the original card rested inside Leïla’s sleeve.

Reixac set the folio down again.

He looked at her hands. Leïla had already placed both palms on the table where everyone could see them.

“Clumsy,” she said.

“Unexpected,” Reixac replied.

Vasseur cut into the xuletó. The centre was red, the outer fat charred. “Nothing at this table is unexpected. Some things are merely not priced in advance.”

She looked at Leïla, not the wet cloth.

At the side table, Mei finished reading.

“If I sign, when does Llevant’s name leave the incident report?”

“Today,” Clara said.

“If I do not?”

“I cannot control what independent investigators conclude.”

“You control the correction they will receive.”

“Yes.”

Mei picked up the pen.

Arnau said nothing this time.

She wrote the police incident number across the signature line, placed the pen down and closed the folder.

“Put that number on your offer,” she said. “Send it to the investigating officer with the sentence saying Guaita copied our customer template. Then we can discuss cooperation.”

Clara’s expression did not change. “That is not how settlement works.”

“Then it is not settlement. It is rental. You rent my silence until your report is published.”

She stood.

Leaving in the middle of lunch made every nearby table notice. Clara had chosen the public room because discomfort normally kept people seated. Mei accepted the cost.

Mei's phone lit before she reached the entrance. She stopped beneath the framed menu and read without opening the message fully. Leïla saw Pilar Forn's name, then the preview beneath it.

Council reassigned the order. Releasing Núria and Hamza now.

Mei pressed the side button. The screen went black. She did not return to Clara's table.

Júlia followed. Arnau remained long enough to look at Reixac.

"Oriol's car is at a Guaita staging supplier," he said.

Reixac cut a piece of meat. "Then you should tell the police."

"We did."

"Good."

He ate.

Leïla waited until the three reached the entrance. Then she excused herself and followed them to the corridor outside the dining room.

Mei turned before Leïla spoke.

"Who are you?"

"Leïla Haddad. I investigate Narthex."

"You invited us to watch lunch."

"I invited you so Reixac would open the folio while Clara distracted herself."

"Then we were instruments again."

"Yes."

Leïla held up the original sample card.

"But now I can show you where Atlas is."

Chapter 14: Room Zero

Atlas occupied less space than its consequences.

Arnau found the room at 18:12 beneath an event-storage office outside Girona. From the road, the building looked too warm and too empty. One loading shutter, three parked vans, mirrored windows on the upper floor. No sign named Guaita.

They had reached it through a label on Reixac's sample card, Oriol's certificate trail and a driver who remembered unloading a cooled Tramuntana body on Monday.

Mei drove. Leïla had given her the keys to the beige car.

"Four probabilities," Júlia said from the back seat.

"And the heat," Mei replied.

Although the office windows were dark, hot air shimmered above a low exhaust grille beside the rear wall. The building was rejecting the work it pretended not to do.

Leïla watched the entrance. "Reixac will know the sample was changed as soon as Vasseur tests it."

"How long?" Arnau asked.

"Long enough ended at lunch."

"Then why are we sitting here?"

"Because you still think finding a door means we can open it."

The building belonged to a commercial landlord. A printed sheet inside the gate listed tenants. The event-storage office occupied the ground floor. Two units were vacant. Room Zero appeared nowhere.

A catering van arrived. The gate opened from inside. Its driver reversed towards the shutter while a woman in work clothes guided him with one hand.

Leïla left the car.

"What is she doing?" Arnau asked.

Mei opened her own door. "Not explaining."

They followed at a distance. Leïla spoke to the woman beside the shutter. Whatever story Leïla supplied took ten seconds. The woman pointed upstairs, irritated, then returned to the catering driver.

"What did you say?" Júlia asked when they reached her.

"That Madame Vasseur left a contract package in the review room."

"And she believed you?"

"She believed the name and disliked being responsible for the package."

Leïla had not chosen the Girona lunch only to hear the sale. The buyer folio listed an eighteen-hundred demonstration at a site identified only as `GIR-0`, with catering for six and a one-day

visitor code. Vasseur cancelled the demonstration after discovering the substituted sample. Reixac cancelled the guests. Nobody had cancelled the food.

"You knew the van would arrive," Arnau said.

"I knew someone had ordered it. A plan is not the same as knowing which door they will use."

The temporary visitor code from Reixac's folio opened the stairs and nothing else.

The receptionist wrote Leïla's name on a paper visitor sheet and asked the other three to wait below. Leïla wrote Vasseur's company, not a false employer, then pointed to the six-person catering order.

"They are technical advisers," she said.

"The booking names two visitors."

"Then two of us go up and two remain with the food."

Mei chose to stay before Arnau could volunteer her. Júlia went with Leïla because she could identify Atlas. Arnau remained beside the catering boxes, watching the stair door close on the investigation he believed belonged to him.

Two minutes later, the receptionist's phone rang. While she answered, Mei picked up two of the four sealed water crates and walked them towards the delivery lift.

The receptionist covered the receiver. "The demonstration was cancelled. Madame Vasseur has no package here."

"Then our colleagues can come down and we will leave," Arnau said.

The receptionist tried the stair release. Its light changed from green to red. Whoever had answered the call had revoked the visitor code while Leïla and Júlia were upstairs.

"They cannot use the stair," Mei said.

"They can call reception."

Arnau called Júlia. The call did not ring. A recorded voice said the number could not be reached. The offices above were designed to prevent private recording during demonstrations. The same shielding that protected a buyer's meeting now kept the visitors from learning that their exit had closed.

The receptionist spoke into the telephone again. "Yes, two went upstairs. Two are with me. No, I did not admit four."

She listened, then looked at Arnau.

"Guaita security is coming. You wait here."

Mei continued towards the lift.

"Senyora, leave the water."

"The catering order is still here."

"The guests are not."

"Two are upstairs."

The catering driver entered carrying a heated box and asked who would sign for six meals. The receptionist turned to tell him the booking was cancelled. Mei pressed the delivery-lift call button.

Arnau took the other two water crates and followed her.

The lift doors closed while the receptionist called for them to stop. The control offered only delivery and loading levels. Mei selected delivery. A buzzer sounded twice, not an alarm yet, only a request that someone downstairs close the doors they had already closed.

They entered through the delivery level and met Leïla and Júlia beside the dark offices.

“That was not your plan,” Arnau said.

“No,” Leïla replied. “It was Mei’s.”

“You copied the visitor code from the folio too?” Arnau asked.

“I read it.”

“The code was revoked,” Mei said. “Guaita security is coming.”

Leïla checked the stair door. The ground-floor release showed red.

“Then they know we are inside.”

“They know four people entered,” Arnau replied. “They do not know which room we found.”

The lift returned downstairs without them. Its descending motor removed the route they had used and began a clock none of the displays showed.

Upstairs, the air conditioning lowered the temperature without removing the smell of hot electronics. Office doors stood open on empty desks. Saturday shift notices named a Guaita operations team that had left at five. A red light above the final door showed the room beyond remained occupied.

Arnau listened.

Fans. Many, close together.

The door carried no handle on the corridor side. Beside it, a fire plan showed a larger room than the wall allowed.

“Negative space again,” Mei said.

Arnau measured the visible corridor in floor tiles. Eight metres from stairwell to outer wall. The fire plan showed eleven. Air returned through a grille on the wrong side of the partition, drawing towards a space the office layout denied.

Júlia traced the plan without touching it. “There should be a service corridor behind this office.”

They returned to the stair and went down one level. The missing corridor began behind a door marked cooling access. It was unlocked because the catering staff had propped it for the delivery.

Coincidence did not make the entry safe. It made it temporary.

The corridor led beneath the office to a white modular body installed inside the larger building. Tramuntana markings remained on its steel feet. The caterer used the same corridor because the cancelled buyer room had no kitchen access. A false clean-room wall leaned against one side, the printed perspective visible now that nobody stood in the intended place.

Oriol’s room.

The orange shutter beacon reflected in the same curved case handle.

The modular door stood open.

Inside, three racks held storage, network monitors and compact servers. One status screen joined gateways to operators, maintenance accounts, recorders and probable rooms.

The room was loud enough to make whispering pointless. Cold air entered beneath the racks and left warm above them. Cable labels referred to event partners by number, not name. A maintenance board listed cooling checks, storage rotation and the cancelled buyer demonstration. Concealment had not eliminated housekeeping.

Júlia photographed the board before touching any console. It tied ordinary labour to the secret room: somebody changed filters, someone tested alarms, somebody ordered the six lunches now cooling downstairs.

At the centre, a map filled itself with connections.

“Room Zero,” Arnau said.

“A field copy,” Júlia replied. “The eclipse run will complete it elsewhere.”

She approached the earliest storage shelf. Dates began in 2021. Project labels changed over time, but one identifier persisted beneath them.

`JM-CORR`.

Júlia stopped.

Arnau saw her initials before she could close the view.

“Your prototype,” he said.

“Yes.”

“You knew in the chapel.”

“I knew the clock partitioning was mine. I did not know how far they had taken it.”

“You said it was abandoned.”

“I abandoned it. Guaita kept funding the disaster-recovery work. Reixac asked for better cross-camera recall. I gave him it.”

“And the failures?”

“Buried in an appendix nobody was required to ship.”

Her voice stayed level. The confession hurt more because she had rehearsed it.

“Why?” Mei asked.

“Because the prototype found two missing people. It falsely joined seventeen others. Funding cared about the two. I believed another year would reduce the seventeen.”

“Did it?”

“It learned to hide them behind confidence scores.”

Arnau opened the prototype manifest. He recognized his timing-cleanup package before he reached the signature. Atlas had retained its rejection rules and removed the human operator.

His release approval sat at the bottom of the manifest.

`A.VIDAL / ENGINEERING REVIEW / ACCEPTED`

Arnau photographed the line. In the image, Júlia’s identifier remained visible above his.

She watched him save it. “I imported the standard package.”

“You imported my name with it.”

The remote-maintenance light changed once, amber to green, then back again.

Leïla had moved to the active rack. “Moral history later. Which copy can leave?”

“None,” Arnau said.

“One must.”

“For Karim?”

“For every client in Vasseur’s contract.”

The signed index and query engine sat on a removable module used for buyer demonstrations. It could prove Atlas existed and show what Narthex had queried.

Two removable modules occupied the service shelf.

Same black casing, same capacity label, different handwritten suffixes: `A` and `B`. Both status lights showed ready. Leïla reached for A.

“Wait,” Júlia said.

“Which one?”

Júlia opened the service view. The system called one module **active query cache** and the other **demonstration replica**, but the display listed logical positions, not the letters written on the hardware. A remote operator could swap their roles without moving either case.

"If you take the query cache?" Mei asked.

"We may remove current searches, including names, without the provenance needed to interpret them," Júlia said. "The service will rebuild it from the room."

"And Guaita says we stole personal data."

"Correctly."

Leïla kept her hand on A. "Karim may be in that cache."

"So may everyone Vasseur searched this week."

"You do not know which module contains the replica."

"Not yet."

The remote-maintenance banner changed from amber to red. Somebody outside the building had acknowledged it. An estimated connection time appeared: three minutes, then recalculated to two.

Arnau checked the rack cabling. Both modules entered the same backplane. No useful difference.

Mei looked at the maintenance board Júlia had photographed. Storage rotation had been recorded in marker because the labels on the service screen changed after updates. Friday's line read: **DEMO TO B / CACHE TO A / BUYER TEST 18:00.** Beneath it, a technician had initialled the change and noted six meals.

"B," Mei said.

Leïla did not release A.

"The board could be wrong."

"Yes. It is also the record kept by the person who had to replace the correct module and feed the people testing it."

Júlia compared the handwritten time with the last service transition. They matched within one minute.

"B is the demonstration replica," she said.

Leïla moved her hand.

Leïla released the module using the rack's normal service control. No code, no forced lock. The system warned that the field replica would become read-only.

"If you take it, live operations continue," Júlia said. "Queries stop updating but the collection path remains."

"If I leave it?"

"Vasseur receives the demonstration and Guaita retains the same path."

"Then this is evidence, not sabotage."

"It is both to whoever owns the service."

Leïla confirmed removal. The rack released its latch with the small domestic sound of a cupboard opening.

"That alert goes to Guaita," Arnau said.

"So did lunch."

She removed the module.

The room's status screen changed. One connection turned amber, then many. A banner announced remote maintenance.

"Minutes," Júlia said.

Arnau copied the earliest prototype manifest and its failure appendix. He left the raw camera relationships where they were.

Mei photographed the physical rack labels, the false wall and the Tramuntana feet. Paper identity, room and machine in one frame.

Footsteps entered the corridor.

Leïla closed the rack. "Catering?"

"Too quiet," Mei said.

The modular room offered one door. The false wall beside it offered no escape. Arnau looked at the cooling grille. Too small. The floor had been levelled over a service gap, inaccessible without tools.

The footsteps stopped outside.

"Madame Haddad," a man said. "You have something that belongs to our client."

Not Guaita. French accent.

Vasseur had tested the incomplete sample.

Leïla put the storage module beneath her shirt at the small of her back. "When the door opens, do not fight."

"Excellent plan," Arnau said.

Mei pointed to the orange beacon control beside the shutter interface. "Fire evacuation."

"We cannot create a fire alarm in an occupied building," Júlia said.

"We don't. We open the loading shutter."

Arnau used the interior safety control. The high shutter began to rise. Its loose chain struck three times. Daylight cut beneath it, revealing the catering van and two workers unloading metal boxes.

The man outside opened the modular-room door.

Mei walked directly towards him carrying her phone as if he had interrupted an inspection. He stepped aside from the confidence of paperwork before recognizing he should not.

They crossed the loading floor among catering staff who wanted no part of another tenant's argument. Nobody ran until they reached the car.

Leïla kept her hand at her back until the locks closed. Through the open shutter the white room stayed visible. The man from the door was already on the phone.

Mei turned the key.

The engine clicked once and did not start.

"Again," Arnau said.

She tried. The starter answered this time, slow in the heat. Mei released the key before it caught. A black saloon stopped across the open gate.

Salvador Reixac stepped out alone.

He left the driver's door open and the engine running. No security team arranged itself behind him. No raised voice asked the catering crew to move. He walked through the gate carrying his jacket over one arm and stopped far enough from their car that leaving would require Mei to choose whether to drive at him.

“Do not get out,” Leïla said.

Reixac looked through the windscreen at Arnau. “You should.”

“Why?”

“Because four people entered one of my operating sites under a buyer credential. If all four leave in a locked car after a storage alarm, the next conversation belongs to police. If one employee speaks to his employer, it may still belong to us.”

“You suspended me yesterday morning.”

“I removed your access. I did not remove eleven years.”

Mei turned the key again. The engine caught. She kept her foot on the brake.

Arnau opened his door.

Mei caught the back of his shirt. “He can speak through glass.”

“He is blocking the gate.”

“Then we call police and describe the obstruction first.”

Reixac heard through the open door. “Please do. The building alarm has already called them. Tell them about the removable storage module while you wait.”

Leïla’s hand stayed at her back.

Arnau stepped out and left the door open between himself and Mei. Reixac’s gaze moved once across the car: Júlia and Leïla in the back, Leïla’s hand behind her on something he could not see.

“Give me the demonstration copy,” Reixac said.

“Ask your buyer. Her man is inside.”

“Hélène’s impatience does not change ownership.”

“Neither does a Guaita label.”

“You approved the timing package inside that room. Júlia approved the correlation work. Leïla entered under Narthex’s name. Mei opened a restricted shutter. Four people can spend the evening explaining why each was entitled to the part they liked. Or you can return one removable cache.”

“Replica,” Arnau said.

For the first time, Reixac looked towards the open shutter.

The correction was small. It told him they had read the maintenance board.

“Then returning it costs you less,” he said.

“It costs you more.”

Reixac came no closer. The sun reached the left side of his face and showed sweat at his temple. His calm had always been easier in rooms he controlled.

“You think this is the first time you have stood beside an unauthorized copy and called possession an ethical position,” he said.

Arnau knew which failure he meant.

Eleven years earlier, Arnau kept an unapproved backup on air through a storm. Oriol signed the log; Arnau wrote the report. Reixac changed *operator breach* to *continuity action* and stopped the client dismissing either of them.

“You told the board the picture mattered more than the contract,” he said.

“I told the board the contract existed to keep the picture alive.”

“Oriol would have lost his job.”

“Oriol used your certainty and let you write the report. I protected the company from punishing the only engineer willing to put his name beneath a decision.”

"You protected me."

"I invested in you. There is a difference, Arnau. One you were old enough to understand."

Mei left the car.

She closed her door, making the sound deliberate. "He understood that you kept people when they were useful. He mistook it for loyalty. That is not a young man's error. Companies encourage it."

Reixac turned to her. "And family companies do not?"

"Constantly. That is why the person who owns the company should say the price out loud."

"Very well. Return the replica. I correct the cloned-shipment record before it reaches the Monday briefings. Llevant becomes a cooperating witness."

"And Oriol?" Arnau asked.

Reixac did not look away from Mei. "Oriol becomes a missing employee who made an unauthorized production copy. Which is what he is."

"Is he alive?"

"His production identity validated a southern contribution route at sixteen forty-two today."

Arnau moved before deciding to. Two steps closed half the distance.

"His identity or his hand?"

"That is precisely the ambiguity Atlas removes."

Mei reached him and put one hand against his chest. Not to calm him. To mark where he had stopped.

Reixac continued. "People, accounts, cameras, vehicles, rooms. Your friend disappeared between them. Return the copy and finish the index with us. We can locate the person behind his identity before Wednesday."

"Using Ingot," Júlia said from the car.

"Using the allocation already approved."

"And after you find him?" Arnau asked.

"We know who moved him."

"That is not what I asked."

Reixac's patience altered by one degree. "After we find him, police do their job. After we establish who moved the equipment, the insurer does its job. After we complete the eclipse programme, your colleagues keep theirs."

"Show me Oriol's validation," Arnau said.

"Return the module."

"A timestamp is not proof he touched anything today."

"Then help build the proof."

Arnau looked back at Leïla. She did not tell him what the replica might contain about Karim. Mei's hand remained against his chest. He could feel each breath he was taking and none of hers.

"If we give it back," he said to Mei, "he can finish Atlas."

"If we keep it, he can still have Oriol."

"That is not an answer."

"No. It is the choice he brought."

A police siren sounded beyond the industrial road, distant enough to belong to another call until it turned closer.

Reixac held out his hand.

Arnau saw Reixac's signature on the old incident report.

Arnau removed his Lenticular badge from his belt.

Reixac's hand stayed open.

Arnau placed the badge in it.

"That is not the object I asked for."

"It is the one you own."

He returned to the car.

Reixac closed his fingers around the badge. "If you leave with Guaita data, I file the theft under all four names. If you publish it, the first public question is why Mei Zhou's company received the missing hardware."

Mei opened the driver's door. "That was already your first question."

The police car turned into the access road.

Reixac moved his saloon before its blue lights reached the gate. He did not hurry. He had given Arnau a choice in front of witnesses and received the wrong object.

Mei drove out past him.

In the mirror, Reixac stood beneath the open shutter with Arnau's badge in one hand and the false room behind him.

Chapter 15: Water That Would Not Cool

At 23:18, the Mediterranean was too warm to hide anything.

Leïla stood waist-deep off Barceloneta with the Atlas module sealed beneath her shirt and watched strangers remain in water they would normally have left. The beach was crowded under the city glow. Children threw a lit ball. Two men argued over a paddleboard. Couples occupied the dark between lifeguard posts. Nobody wanted to return to apartments that had stored the day's heat.

Her dead drop required three metres of empty shoreline and thirty seconds without an observer.

Barcelona offered neither.

She returned to the sand. The water left no coolness on her skin.

At midnight in another summer, the sea might have hidden a shiver. Tonight it held the day's heat and returned it against her ribs. The city had spent weeks measuring the water as anomaly, record and warning. On the beach it became personal: nowhere cold enough to make the body feel briefly absent.

Leïla had chosen water because a handoff left no doorway camera and because a waterproof sleeve could change hands below the surface. She had planned from maps and winter photographs. The August beach refused the empty metres on which the plan depended.

Arnau, Mei and Júlia waited at a terrace across the promenade, visible without appearing together. Arnau had ordered coffee and not touched it. Mei watched the people who watched Leïla. Júlia watched the module's absence beneath Leïla's wet shirt as if calculating its failure rate.

Leïla entered the public toilet block and locked herself in a cubicle. She removed the waterproof sleeve, checked the seal and opened a secure message on a phone that had never contacted the others.

No reply from Sami.

Sami was meant to carry the original sample card from a public locker to the lawyer in Perpignan. He knew nothing about Atlas.

Leïla had hidden the locker reference inside the false sample as a canary. She expected Narthex to query it, not visit it.

Her phone displayed a photograph.

Sami stood beside a white van, one arm held behind him by a man in a short-sleeved shirt. His face showed confusion rather than injury. The staffed lockers were visible behind them.

Text beneath the image read:

Your incomplete map still finds people. Bring the original.

Leïla closed her eyes.

She had designed a trap for a buyer and placed an innocent man at its end.

She left the toilet through the beach-side door and walked north before returning to the others. Four hundred metres was close enough to make rescue feel like a decision rather than a fantasy.

The staffed lockers stood beyond a row of closed kiosks. From the promenade she could see the white van in Sami's photograph. Its rear doors were shut. One man waited beside it, looking towards the beach. Another stood near the locker entrance with a phone against his ear.

Between Leïla and them moved hundreds of people who had no part in the choice. A family dragging an inflatable boat. Runners. Delivery riders. Children still wet from the sea. If she approached, Vasseur's men could leave, take Sami, or turn the crowd into pressure. If she called out, she announced the original card was near.

She saw a young man in an archive polo shirt exit the locker entrance.

For one second she thought Sami had been released.

The man beside the van took his arm.

Wrong courier.

The young man protested and showed his identification. The grip released at once. Vasseur's people were searching by role, not face. Leïla's false record had not only identified one locker. It had made every archive worker approaching it a candidate.

The van pulled away before she reached the crossing. She photographed its plate and watched it enter traffic she could not stop.

She returned towards the others.

Mei was waiting outside the toilet block.

"Who?" Mei asked.

Leïla did not ask how she knew. "A courier. Mine."

"Taken?"

"Yes."

"Because of the card you switched."

"Because of a marker I put inside it."

They crossed the promenade together. A bicycle passed between them and the terrace. Two tourists stepped into the cycle lane without looking and received a bell, a shout and a lesson that changed nobody.

Leïla showed the photograph beneath the table.

Arnau studied the locker frontage. "Where?"

"Four hundred metres north."

He stood.

"Sit," Leïla said.

"They have him now."

"The van will be gone. If we run towards it, we give them the module and four more people."

"Then call police."

"I did from the crossing. Anonymous report, registration, photograph."

"Anonymous helps you," Mei said. "Not Sami."

Leïla accepted the sentence.

"If I give my name, Narthex connects him to Karim."

“They already connected him to you. The question is whether anyone else can see the connection before they erase it.”

“Public systems fail people too.”

“Yes. Use more than one. Police, his employer, his sister, the lawyer. Do not ask a single record to save him.”

Júlia looked towards the sea. “Can we verify the module without connecting it?”

“Its outer signature, yes,” Arnau said. “Contents, no.”

“Then Vasseur does not know whether Leïla still has the original.”

Leïla’s phone received another message.

Midnight. Water. Come alone.

Vasseur expected the obvious transfer: a waterproof object passed in shallow water. Every metre held a witness, a phone or a child refusing to move.

“They want the beach,” Leïla said.

“Give them the duplicate,” Arnau replied.

“They already have it.”

“Give them the sample from Room Zero with the operational files removed.”

“That tells them we opened it.”

“They saw us leave.”

Mei shook her head. “No more technical tricks with people at the other end. We call the police under Sami’s name. We call his employer. We make him visible before Vasseur can decide invisibility is useful.”

Leïla called the archive director and gave her own name.

The director began with anger. Sami was a courier, not an investigator, and had been sent towards a locker after hours because Leïla described the package as urgent court material. Leïla did not defend the description. She gave the van plate, photograph time, the two visible men and the route she had watched it take.

Then she called Sami’s sister.

That call was worse. Leïla told her the favour Sami believed he was returning and the risk she had concealed from him. His sister said nothing for so long that Leïla checked whether the line remained open.

“Find him,” the woman said.

“Police are looking.”

“I did not ask who was looking.”

Then she called the police again and gave Sami’s name.

The beach continued around them. A group entered the sea carrying bottles. A woman washed sand from a sleeping child’s feet. Farther out, anchored boats showed small white lights that did not move.

At 23:47 police found the van abandoned near the port. Sami was not inside.

Vasseur’s message changed.

You have made this public. The offer is withdrawn.

Leïla placed the sealed module on the table.

“I need to tell you all of it,” she said.

She told them about Karim, the earlier Atlas fragment, the bait and Sami.

When she finished, Arnau looked at the module. “You still want Atlas intact.”

“Yes.”

“Even now?”

Leïla watched the crowded water refuse every secret entrusted to it.

“Now I know what that want costs,” she said.

Mei reached for the module.

Leïla put her hand over it.

The movement was small. Arnau stood anyway. Around them, the terrace continued serving drinks to people in wet clothes. A waiter changed an ashtray at the next table and chose not to notice four adults disputing a black object beneath a napkin.

“It stays with me,” Leïla said.

“Your last private plan put Sami beside a van,” Mei replied.

“And your answer is to take the only proof connected to Karim.”

“My answer is that none of us owns it alone.”

“You mean you do.”

Mei withdrew her hand. “No. I mean we call the investigating officer and declare what we removed.”

“Guaita will have it back before breakfast.”

“Perhaps. But you do not get to protect another person by keeping the risk secret from them.”

Leïla looked towards Arnau. “You copied files in Room Zero.”

“The prototype manifest and failure appendix. Not the people index.”

“A distinction you chose without asking me.”

“Yes.”

His answer stopped Mei. Arnau did not defend the choice as obvious. He put it on the table beside Leïla’s.

Júlia opened the metal cash box from the boot of Leïla’s car. “Module inside. Our four signatures across the seal. Nobody connects it, moves it or copies it alone. We give police its existence and outer identifier, not access, until counsel can challenge Guaita’s claim.”

“You designed the system,” Leïla said. “Why should your signature protect it?”

“It should not. That is why there are four.”

The waiter returned with the bill. Arnau paid because the arrival of an ordinary transaction gave everyone a moment in which not to answer.

Leïla removed her hand first.

They placed the module inside the cash box. Mei wrote the time on a paper receipt. Júlia sealed the latch with tape from Arnau’s radio kit. Each signed across a different edge. Leïla pressed so hard her pen cut the tape.

Mei called the officer. She described the module as material removed under a cancelled buyer-tour authorization from a Guaita staging room. She gave the location and the names of all four people present. She did not disclose where they would sleep.

The officer told them not to access it and asked them to bring it to a station.

“We cannot do that tonight,” Mei said.

“Then you are retaining potential evidence.”

“Record that we understand.”

The call ended without agreement.

When they left the terrace, Leïla carried the box. Júlia walked beside her. Arnau followed several metres back with Leïla, close enough to see her and too far away to pretend the alliance had been repaired.

At 01:16, Leïla put the sealed cash box beside her bed in the room by the lift and discovered that everybody had chosen a room around it.

Júlia took the room across the corridor. Leïla's door faced both stair doors. Arnau checked the window latch twice and placed a chair beneath the handle after Mei told him the latch was designed to open.

"That will stop housekeeping," she said.

"At one in the morning?"

"You believe threats respect departments."

He left the chair.

The air conditioning pushed warm air for thirty seconds before becoming merely less warm. Mei removed the wet tape residue from her fingers. Four signatures ran across the cash-box seal. Hers crossed the latch. Arnau's disappeared beneath it.

Arnau lay back without removing his shoes. "Clara offered to clear Llevant."

"She offered to rename the harm."

"You almost signed."

"I read the signature line."

"That is not an answer."

"Then yes. I imagined my father opening the warehouse on Monday without cameras outside. I imagined Pilar collecting her radios. I imagined every employee being allowed to say where they worked without first explaining a Chinese computer."

"And Oriol?"

"He was why I did not sign."

Arnau turned his head.

"Do not look pleased," Mei said. "I resent him for making that the price."

"He may not know about Clara."

"He knew enough to print our label."

Arnau's phone lay face down beside him. He turned it over and called Oriol again. The call reached a full mailbox without ringing.

"If Guaita has the phone, each call tells them we are still looking," Mei said.

"They know."

"That does not make repetition free."

He called once more.

This time the line rang.

Both of them sat up.

One ring. Two. Three.

At six, somebody answered.

No voice. Air moved across a microphone. A hard knock repeated three times, paused, then repeated. Behind it, a fan or engine held one low note.

“Oriol?” Arnau said.

The line ended.

He called back. Full mailbox.

Mei was already recording the exact time on hotel paper. “The chain from the mobile room.”

“Or somebody replaying it.”

“Yes.”

“He could be there.”

“Yes.”

Arnau reached for his radio case.

“What are you doing?” she asked.

“Checking whether the low tone matches the clip.”

“With what recording?”

He had not recorded the call. The service kept no accessible audio, only time and duration. He had heard a possible clue and answered as a friend, not an engineer.

“I missed it,” he said.

“No. You heard him. Those are different things.”

“If it was him.”

“Those are also different things.”

He put the radio case down.

The cash box was two doors down, beside Leïla’s bed. Mei found she was still listening for that door, and moved the chair closer to their own.

“Whose danger comes first if the phone rings again?” Arnau asked.

“The person on the phone.”

“And if the box alarm sounds at the same time?”

“The person.”

“If the warehouse calls?”

Mei lay down without answering. The air conditioner changed pitch. A lift door opened in the corridor and closed again.

Arnau waited.

“Ask me when both calls are real,” she said. “I will not choose which person to abandon for your rehearsal.”

He switched off the lamp. Neither of them slept.

Chapter 16: Firebreak

Every face said *not him*.

On Monday morning, Leïla waited outside Sami's archive with his sister and watched the first couriers arrive.

One unlocked a bicycle. Two loaded sealed pouches into a van. A third smoked beside the service door before his supervisor made him put the cigarette out.

Sami's employer supplied the details of his last completed delivery: a brown archive pouch signed into chambers near Plaça d'Urquinaona at 16:42 on Saturday. His transit card showed no journey after the lockers. At 02:10 on Monday, his phone had sent Leïla the locker reference she planted on the sample card. She called back. The phone was already off. Police placed its final connection inside a sector serving the port, three hotels and more apartments than anyone could search before morning.

His sister carried a toothbrush in a clear freezer bag.

"They did not want it," she said.

She had brought it to the police station because families on television brought things a missing person had touched. The desk officer took a recent photograph, the van registration and Leïla's second statement. He left the toothbrush in its bag.

At noon, after another courier who was not Sami entered the archive, his sister asked Leïla to explain Karim. Leïla did, without using the words source, asset or collateral. The simpler words were worse.

At dusk police found an abandoned phone sleeve beside a port service road. It held no print, fibre or mark proving Sami had ever touched it.

His sister sent Leïla a question mark after midnight. Leïla answered with the same mark. By Tuesday, silence had acquired a routine.

Deng Rui found Lin before the others finished lunch.

He stood at the end of a vineyard row where shade stopped, dressed in a pale shirt and dark trousers, no jacket, no visible weapon. The grey EBRO waited on the gravel track behind him with all four wheels clear of the grass.

"You chose a defensible place," he said in Chinese.

"I chose a cellar."

"The owner chose the defence."

Marta Queralt, Arnau's maternal aunt, owned the vineyard beyond the routes most eclipse visitors would use the following day. The family lunch she had rearranged twice had finally hap-

pened a day late and with three unexpected guests. Rows ran across dry ground towards low hills. Irrigation tanks, tractor paths and cleared margins divided the property into practical shapes. A sign at the entrance said **NO PARKING ON GRASS** in three languages and a fourth made from an image of flames.

Lin had arrived an hour earlier after three days of changing hotels, phones and plans. She had not known the vineyard existed. She had written to the project contact on the May test booking, the only Institut Llum address she trusted, and Júlia had called her back from a borrowed phone with one question: the serial number of the orange device in May's equipment log. Lin read it from the back of the Flipper. Júlia gave her a petrol station on the main road, not an address. Marta collected her there and drove twice around the roundabout before turning towards the hills. She found Arnau, Mei, Júlia and Leïla at a long table beneath an awning, eating botifarra with white beans because Marta refused to discuss secret hardware with hungry people.

Mei placed the fifth controller log beside her plate and asked, "Did you put this machine in my warehouse?"

Lin answered yes.

That bought her a chair and nothing else.

Before Deng appeared, Lin called Hsu from the end of the same vineyard row. She needed an independent witness willing to say the Ingot service record descended from their 2019 work.

"You want me to certify a Chinese machine," Hsu said.

"I want you to certify your part."

"Those are different requests. Your sponsor will use the first sentence and lose the second."

"Then write the sentence yourself."

Hsu was silent long enough for insects to fill the call.

"Reixac describes cross-Strait ownership as a jurisdiction problem," Lin said.

"It is an authorship problem. No government wrote our package fabric. Do not turn me into a flag because your company removed my name."

"I am asking for your checksum."

"You are asking me to wait while you prove the machine on terms chosen by two men who want to own it."

"One day."

"That is what companies call time when it belongs to somebody else."

Hsu agreed to verify Lin's performance record, not to delay publication.

Now Deng waited between the vines while the others remained at the table, visible through leaves and heat.

"Your recovery team copied the seal in May," Lin said.

"No. We photographed you after someone else copied it."

"Marc."

"You already know."

"I suspected."

"Suspicion is what engineers call knowledge before a report can survive."

Lin looked at the EBRO. "Joel Huang reported to you."

"He reported to product security. That is what we called ourselves. He believed he was preventing theft."

“You used the contact name I submitted.”

“Yes.”

The courtesy had travelled seven years of architecture and six weeks of logistics to reach this row.

“Where is Ingot?” Deng asked.

“Guaita moved it from Llevant on 16 July. The rendezvous remains Pedralbes tomorrow at eleven.”

“We know the appointment. We do not know custody.”

“Then your observation failed.”

“So did your secrecy.”

They spoke without anger. Anger implied time for preference.

Deng’s orders were simple: allow the independent run if Ingot appeared, recover the module before Guaita could remove it, prevent a public confrontation involving Yulan. Lin’s orders had been different. Her sponsor inside Yulan wanted the MareNostrum comparison completed and the eclipse workload processed.

Until Room Zero, Lin had pretended the second aim served the first.

“Atlas is the workload,” she said.

Deng’s face changed by less than surprise required. “Part of it.”

“You knew.”

“I knew your sponsor purchased a large sparse inference trial from Lenticular. I did not know the data described people.”

“It describes access to people.”

“A distinction for lawyers.”

“And engineers who want to sleep.”

Deng looked past her towards the table. “The French investigator has the field index. Narthex has her courier. Guaita has the hardware or expects to receive it. Tomorrow everyone will prefer the run to fail except the people who need its answer.”

“My sponsor needs the answer.”

“Your sponsor needs proof Ingot can serve a model at that scale. Atlas is a benchmark with a buyer attached.”

Lin had chosen MareNostrum because independent comparison would make it difficult for Yulan to bury Ingot or erase Hsu’s contribution again. Her sponsor approved the plan because an eclipse dataset gave the demonstration a deadline and Guaita gave it commercial value.

She had not recruited a neutral witness. She had supplied a better customer.

“I will stop the run,” Lin said.

“Then Guaita keeps the module and claims it failed. Yulan denies it existed. Your Taiwanese colleague remains absent from the design.”

“Hsu has the checksum.”

“A checksum proves she remembers something. A witnessed run proves the thing.”

Marta called from the awning. “If you two are deciding the world, bring the water jug back when you finish.”

Deng had been standing beside it. He picked it up.

“She is not frightened of you,” Lin said.

“She thinks I am another person wasting lunchtime.”

“She may be right.”

They returned to the table together. Deng set down the water and did not sit. Arnau recognized him from the EBRO and moved one hand towards the radio case at his feet.

“That cannot help you,” Deng said in English.

“It rarely does.”

Mei looked at Lin. “Your people?”

“One version of them.”

Marta set botifarra at the empty place and pointed to the chair. Deng sat.

Lin told them what her sponsor wanted. No euphemism about research. Yulan needed Ingot proven on a model too large for ordinary evaluation systems. Guaita needed Antumbra completed. Each had called the other a test partner and treated the dangerous result as somebody else’s application.

Júlia listened without touching her food.

“My harness can separate the model run from the people index,” she said. “Every conclusion must point to source observations. Speculative identities remain in a quarantined table.”

“Can you stop Atlas completing?” Mei asked.

“We can let it compute relationships and refuse to publish the person layer.”

Leïla looked towards her. “The person layer contains Karim.”

“And thousands of people who are not Karim.”

“I know.”

It was the first time Leïla had answered without fighting the sentence.

Her phone lit beside her plate. Sami’s sister had sent the scheduled question mark. Leïla turned the screen so the others could see it and answered with the same mark. No news could still be shared; it did not have to remain private.

Arnau redrew Oriol’s paper map from memory on a blank sheet. The original was gone, but he remembered contribution routes better than geography. Southern feeds, Pedralbes research path, Badalona warehouse, temporary traffic corridor.

“If we cancel the booking,” he said, “Reixac uses another machine or waits. Oriol remains taken. Ingot remains his.”

“If we run,” Mei said, “we enter the room he chose at the time he chose.”

“Yes.”

Marta poured water. “Then stop describing choices as clean or dirty. Decide which mess leaves you able to repair something.”

An engine sounded near the vineyard entrance.

A small rental car passed the no-parking sign and stopped with its right wheels in the cured grass. Two tourists stepped out carrying eclipse viewers and a printed map. They had come a day early to scout a western horizon.

Marta was already standing.

“Move the car,” she called.

The driver waved, misunderstanding the urgency as hospitality.

Smoke appeared beneath the rear of the vehicle.

Not flame at first. A thin grey line where hot metal met dry stems. Wind pushed it under the car and into the margin.

Marta ran towards the tractor shed. Arnau and Mei took the water jugs. Deng reached the rental first and pulled the passenger away as the driver tried to start the engine. Moving it now would drag fire through the grass.

“Leave it!” Marta shouted.

She returned on a compact tractor carrying an irrigation tank. The pump started before she stopped. Water struck the margin. Lin used a shovel to throw bare earth across the narrow front while Júlia called emergency services and gave the exact track entrance.

The fire crossed five metres, then eight. A cleared strip between rows slowed it. Marta soaked the far edge. Neighbours arrived with beaters and another tank. The tourists stood beside the gravel, shocked by the speed of a consequence they had not intended.

Firefighters reached them after the visible flame had fallen. They checked the vehicle, the roots and the ground beyond the wet edge. Nobody called Marta a hero. They asked why the car had passed the sign.

The answer was ordinary. The official viewpoint on the tourists’ map looked crowded. They wanted somewhere quieter.

By mid-afternoon, a black shape marked the vineyard margin. The car remained for recovery. Its exhaust had not guaranteed a fire. Heat, cured grass, wind and one decision had cooperated.

Marta looked at Arnau’s drawn eclipse routes. “Tomorrow those fields in the south will hold thousands of people who believe arriving makes a place safe.”

Lin took the orange Flipper from her bag and placed it beside Júlia’s harness plan.

“This is Ingot’s maintenance console,” she said. “It controls the service state, nothing else. Tomorrow it stays with me.”

Arnau looked at it. “And the traffic receivers?”

“Your capture can be wrapped in a service application, once, if we verify it away from live equipment.”

“One corridor.”

“One request. You will not see what it stops elsewhere.”

The cost belonged in the plan before necessity disguised it.

Deng finished the food Marta had served him. “If Ingot appears, I recover it.”

“If Guaita appears?” Mei asked.

“I recover it from them.”

“And from us?”

Deng looked at Lin. “From whoever still has it.”

“Then you are not part of the operation,” Mei said.

“I was never part of it.”

“You are eating at the table where we are planning it.”

Deng put down his fork. “Because you prefer threats seated and named. That does not make our objectives shared.”

Leïla touched the metal cash box. The four signatures across its seal remained unbroken. “If the run opens this module, Atlas becomes complete.”

“The infrastructure audit becomes complete,” Júlia said. “The people index stays quarantined.”

“Until someone changes a permission.”

“Then you stand beside me and watch the permission.”

“You concealed the original prototype for years.”

“And you concealed the risk from Sami on Saturday. We have established that none of us deserves solitary custody.”

Lin looked at the sealed box. “I can benchmark Ingot without Atlas. We use a public sparse model and synthetic traces.”

“That proves the machine,” Arnau said. “It does not expose Reixac’s export path or find Oriol’s validator.”

“Then say which aim has priority,” Mei said. “The module, the audit or Oriol.”

Marta returned the emptied water jug to the table. Soot marked one forearm. “A plan with three first priorities is three plans sharing a car.”

They wrote the order on the back of a vineyard invoice.

One: a live sign of Oriol ends the computation.

Two: verified infrastructure evidence may leave the annex. No person index leaves.

Three: Ingot enters safe state even if the benchmark remains incomplete.

Four: nobody uses fire, crowds or emergency vehicles to recover hardware.

Leïla added a fifth condition in her own hand: **Karim’s record is not exempt from the person-index rule.** She stared at the sentence before signing beneath it.

Deng read the list and declined the pen.

“My order remains recovery,” he said.

“Then when you follow us tomorrow,” Mei replied, “we know what the car means.”

Marta rinsed soot from the water jug and set it upside down. Mei folded the signed invoice into her bag. On the road beyond the vines, another car slowed at the no-parking sign, read it and continued.

Part Three: Totality

Twelve August. The shadow comes from the west.

Chapter 17: Southbound

At 04:52, six planets became a traffic problem.

Arnau stood between vineyard rows while Berta's voice came from a radio on Marta's terrace. Saturn was obvious, high in the south. Mars took a moment to find in the east. Mercury and Jupiter had not yet risen. Uranus and Neptune required optical help and enough honesty not to claim someone had seen them.

"Alignment does not mean influence," Berta said on air. "It means several planets appear along the same broad path in our sky. Nothing unusual is pulling on your car, your body or the electrical grid."

A caller immediately asked whether the alignment would affect electric cars.

During the next break, Berta sent Arnau an audio file from the July contribution rehearsal. She had been reviewing Oriol's old production notes because police had finally asked which of his irregularities were actually unusual.

The recording began with Arnau complaining that a mobile clock had crossed its tolerance twice. Oriol replied that the fault remained consistent enough to plan around. They argued for forty seconds while Berta tried to record an eclipse introduction in the same room.

Then Arnau's voice left the channel.

Oriol spoke more quietly. "If Guaita asks for clean rehearsal numbers, keep the failed takes. Salvador likes a green dashboard more than a true one."

"Are you making an allegation?" Berta asked in the recording.

"I am making you annoying in advance. You are excellent at it."

He laughed, and the clip ended.

Arnau played the laugh again. Oriol had recognized the danger early enough to warn Berta and still converted the warning into a joke nobody had to act upon. It was his usual form of generosity: give someone a useful burden and make refusing it feel humourless.

Arnau sent the recording to the investigating officer. He did not turn the laugh into a message intended only for him.

Júlia turned down the radio. "We should let the planets answer."

"They have poor media training," Arnau said.

Nobody had slept more than two hours. The farmhouse retained heat from the day before. Windows open to the dark admitted insects, dry air and every vehicle on the distant road. By four, engines were already moving south.

On the terrace wall, Marta had pinned three maps. The first showed the official totality band. The second showed fire access and water points. The third was a road atlas old enough to ignore every navigation service now directing people towards the same junctions.

Arnau trusted the old map least and kept looking at it most.

Marta prepared bread with tomato, anchovies and bottles of water. No wine. No discussion of whether they were hungry. The blackened patch at the vineyard edge smelled wet and burnt.

Leïla's phone rang at 05:11.

She listened without speaking, then sat on the low wall.

"Sami is alive," she said. "Police found him near a freight entrance after three. His wrists are bruised. They took his phone and the archive pouch."

"Did he see faces?" Arnau asked.

Mei looked at him.

"He is alive," Arnau corrected.

Leïla nodded. "He gave my name. Narthex knows I am public now."

The Room Zero module lay sealed in the cash box on Marta's table.

At 05:30 Mei called the officer and put him on speaker. Lin propped her phone against the water jug to record the table. They broke the four signatures one at a time, each person reading their own name aloud as the tape tore. Júlia connected the module to an offline laptop through a write blocker she normally used for camera cards and copied only what the officer agreed to name: the query log, its schema and the journal pages the log referenced. She hashed all three, read the hash into the call and wrote it on the receipt. She did not open the index.

The log was short. Narthex had queried the replica eleven times during its demonstration week. Query seven asked for the movement history of a Marseille identity cluster across three camera dates.

Leïla knew the dates without looking at her notes.

"The cluster has no name here," Júlia said. "The replica carries the relationship graph, not the people layer. Only the full index resolves a cluster to a person."

"Then the full index will have him," Leïla said.

They resealed the module with fresh tape and four fresh signatures while the officer recorded the numbers. Leïla kept custody. The module would travel south with her, away from the annex, Guaita and the machine. The hashed copy of the log went into Júlia's bag for Pedralbes.

Module B also held a slice of Guaita's operations journal, copied with the log. Its last entry, two days before Room Zero, confirmed the Tramuntana mobile room for the southern broadcast operation at a high-ground site in the Ribera d'Ebre. Oriol's production identity appeared as validator.

The entry might be a trap, but it had costs too specific to be invented casually: a generator booking, a water delivery, two crew meals, an assigned spectrum slot and a request for levelling blocks. False locations tended to become believable by copying names. Real operations accumulated boring needs.

Mei circled the meal supplier. Marta knew the family who ran it. They had delivered four portions the previous evening and been told the fifth crew member would arrive inside the mobile room.

"That is not proof of Oriol," Júlia said.

"No," Mei replied. "It is proof the room is expected to contain a person nobody sees enter."

"He is south," Leïla said.

"Or his badge is," Arnau replied.

“We follow both.”

Marta unfolded road maps beside Arnau’s reconstructed contribution plan. Official viewing sites were already reporting full car parks. Police messages requested visitors use designated routes. Navigation applications redirected late arrivals along the same alternatives until alternatives became queues.

“We split at eight,” Mei said. “Leïla and Marta south. I go to Llevant. Arnau, Júlia and Lin take Pedralbes.”

“You cannot stay alone in the warehouse,” Arnau said.

“I will have thirty people by opening time. Llevant is the least solitary place in this plan.”

“Guaita has your paperwork.”

“Which is why somebody must be there when inspectors arrive.”

Mei placed her prepared statement beside the maps. It named the false southern pallet, the copied customer profile and the missing eleven kilograms. It did not name Ingot, Yulan’s private channel, Atlas or any person under investigation. Pilar’s council order remained suspended. Two other retailers had asked whether Llevant could still guarantee origin.

“I send this to the police, our customers and Berta before we leave,” she said.

Arnau read it. “If Berta has it, Reixac assumes it can become public. He moves the module before the annex window.”

“If I wait, Guaita’s incident report becomes the first public version.”

Everyone at the table found another object to examine. Júlia checked the module seal. Leïla watched the vineyard entrance. Marta continued packing water because the argument did not alter heat.

“Police and customers now,” Arnau said. “Berta at ten.”

Mei looked at the statement, then at the time. “At ten, Berta receives it whether you are inside or outside.”

At 06:12 she sent the statement to the police and every customer who had asked. She scheduled Berta’s copy for ten and did not give Arnau the cancellation code.

At 06:19 Guaita’s insurer moved Llevant’s independent inspection from noon to the first available opening.

At 06:23 Clara Reixac called Mei.

Mei carried the phone into Marta’s kitchen. Arnau followed after three seconds, long enough to pretend he had not.

“The inspection can return to noon,” Clara said. “It can also remain independent. Sign the cooperation letter before eight and give the inspector access to the dummy, the four evaluation systems and their service histories. Guaita withdraws its observer.”

“You already know the service histories.”

“My brother’s company knows records supplied through an insurer. I am offering a boundary around that knowledge.”

“And the southern pallet?”

“Contractor error pending investigation. Llevant is not named as origin in the morning brief.”

“Oriol Cendrós?”

Clara paused. “Not part of my instruction.”

Arnau reached for the phone.

Mei moved it away.

"Your brother used his production identity last night," she said. "Put his safe release into the letter."

"I cannot promise custody of a person Guaita does not hold."

"Then you cannot sell his absence separately from the equipment you moved under his name."

"I am not selling anything. I am giving you a chance to prevent a preventable association."

"Before eight."

"Before the inspection begins. After that, findings acquire their own duties."

The letter arrived while Clara remained on the call. Four pages. Mei read the signature section first. Cooperation required Llevant to provide the Yulan logs, submit the five cases for incident custody and make no public statement about Guaita until a joint review finished. Guaita would correct the southern shipment as a contractor error without admitting which contractor made it.

Pilar's council order could move by lunch. Chen's name would stay out of the first brief. Thirty employees would arrive at a warehouse inspected without a Guaita vest beside the cage.

"Say no," Arnau said.

Clara heard him. "Arnau is not an officer of Llevant."

"I know," Mei replied.

"Then decide as one."

Mei ended the call without answering and continued reading.

Arnau stood across the kitchen table. "It gives them the logs before the model run."

"Police already have the logs."

"It gives Guaita the dummy."

"Police already sealed it."

"It silences you."

"It keeps my father out of the morning story."

"Until Reixac needs the name."

"Perhaps. Noon is still six hours in which customers collect orders and staff are not photographed behind an incident cordon."

"You are considering it."

"Yes."

Arnau opened his mouth and closed it again. He had spent ten days deciding which risks belonged to her. He put both hands flat on the table and waited.

Mei opened the signature page.

She wrote the police incident number across the blank line reserved for her name, photographed all four pages and sent them to the investigating officer.

Then she replied to Clara.

Llevant will cooperate through the public investigation already in progress. No private custody. No silence.

The insurer confirmed the early inspection two minutes later. Guaita's observer would attend.

Mei handed Arnau the phone. "You may say no now."

"No."

"Good. You sound like yourself again."

Lin checked the three instrument records. “The annex window opens at eleven. If we miss it, Marc can cancel the allocation.”

“Marc may cancel it when you arrive,” Júlia said.

“Then he admits he knows what is in the third case.”

“You do not have the third case.”

“He does.”

Reixac had stolen Ingot to own the run, not prevent it. Lin would arrive with two instruments and force him to supply the third.

“And if Reixac keeps Ingot south?” Leïla asked.

“Then Lin completes a legitimate two-instrument trial and we release what Room Zero already proves,” Júlia said.

“If Guaita closes the annex?”

“We leave.”

Arnau disliked how quickly she answered.

“If we see Oriol on a feed while the model is running?”

“We do not trade him for another minute of computation.”

They wrote each failure condition beside the route it changed.

At 06:37, Mercury showed for a minute, low in the east, before the sky brightened enough to erase it. Nobody on the terrace could honestly say they had seen Jupiter, so nobody did. Traffic reports replaced astronomy on the radio. A collision near Tarragona. Queues at fuel stations. Camper vans stopped on shoulders for photographs of a dawn that would occur again tomorrow.

Marta loaded water, fire blankets and two beaters into her utility vehicle.

“We are looking for Oriol,” Leïla said.

“We are driving into dry country with people parking everywhere,” Marta replied. “We can do two things.”

Deng had left before dawn. The EBRO’s tyres marked the gravel and nothing else. He had not said whether he would follow Lin or the hardware.

At 07:58 the three vehicles departed.

Before Mei entered her car, Arnau caught her beside the vineyard gate.

“If the model produces another name, I call you before I decide anything,” he said.

“That is a small promise.”

“I am trying to make one I can keep.”

“Then listen when I tell you paper is evidence too. Do not wait for software to translate me into a format you respect.”

He wanted to say he had never done that. The previous ten days supplied too many counterexamples.

“I will listen,” he said.

Mei touched his sunburnt cheek once. “And do not turn staying beside the machine into bravery. Sometimes staying is only what the machine requires.”

“You are going alone to the warehouse.”

“I am going to my family. That is the difference.”

Mei held his gaze for another second, then turned east towards Badalona.

Marta and Leïla took the first southern road.

Arnau drove towards Barcelona with Júlia beside him and Lin in the back, the orange Flipper inside a plain pouch between her feet.

For twenty minutes, their routes behaved like routes.

Then eclipse traffic entered every timetable.

An accident diverted vehicles from the motorway. A police closure sent them through a town where delivery vans blocked opposite kerbs. Navigation added twelve minutes, removed seven, then added nineteen. The air conditioning struggled against three bodies and direct sun.

Berta's voice followed them from the radio, now explaining that Barcelona would experience a deep partial eclipse, not totality. A producer had added a sound effect to the programme's countdown. Each minute ended with a low synthetic pulse.

"Turn it off," Lin said after the sixth.

Arnau did.

At 10:31 they reached the western edge of Barcelona. The appointment began in twenty-nine minutes. Pedralbes lay beyond traffic moving at the speed of a walking crowd.

Mei called from Llevant.

"Inspector arrived early," she said. "So did Guaita."

Marta called from the south before Arnau could answer.

"Official site is full. The mobile room passed us on a closed lane."

Arnau looked at the stopped road ahead. Both calls were still open.

He put the car in gear. It did not move.

Chapter 18: Two Instruments

At 10:58, Lin entered Institut Llum with two instruments and paperwork for three.

The cases came from approved project storage in a university delivery vehicle. Both contained what the manifest claimed: telemetry buffering and power conditioning for the eclipse imaging run. The third position on the trolley was empty.

Marc Escudé held the annex door.

"Traffic?" he asked.

"Barcelona."

"You cut it close."

"The booking begins at eleven."

"And it is ten fifty-eight. Conscientious as ever."

He looked at the empty position without asking where the third case was.

Arnau and Júlia entered behind her on Júlia's project access. Arnau wore a visitor badge and carried no Lenticular equipment except his own radio kit. Marc greeted him with the careful sympathy reserved for colleagues under internal review.

"Salvador said you might assist," he said.

"Salvador says many things before I do them."

"He is usually right."

The guard at the inner desk did not wave them through. He compared Júlia's project letter with a list printed at 07:00, found Arnau absent and called the duty manager. Behind them, a trolley carrying eclipse glasses waited to enter. Behind that, two camera engineers argued that their live position mattered more than a visitor whose employer had suspended him.

Arnau stepped aside. Every minute of scrutiny cost them.

Júlia opened the signed amendment Reixac had approved before he suspended Arnau. It named her as technical lead and permitted one external observer for validation. The guard called the number on the document, not the number Júlia offered. A project administrator answered from home, swore at the hour and confirmed it.

"Observer," the guard said, returning Arnau's passport. "You touch nothing."

"That has been the theme of my week."

They lost nine minutes and entered on an old authorization Reixac had forgotten to cancel. At the equipment log, the guard turned Lin's orange Flipper over, found May's entry and wrote its serial number again.

Through distant glass, the chapel held its quantum machines in ordered light, and MareNostrum hummed in the hall beside it. Nobody approached the secure machine hall. Nobody needed to.

The annex itself had spent the morning as a corridor. Staff who had not gone south passed through with coffee and eclipse glasses. A student asked Marc whether the building would lose power when the Sun went dark. Marc said no with the patience of a man who had answered the same question since April.

Heat had already entered the outer rooms. The controlled space held cooler air that smelled of new cable and the solvent used on the floor after May. Lin's shirt stuck between her shoulders. She had slept two hours on Marta's sofa and driven into a city that believed its own traffic would part because the appointment was important.

Lin placed the two legitimate instruments into the cradles she had rehearsed in May. Coolant, power, telemetry. Each connection produced a checklist item and a record. Her hands remembered the dummy loads. The Flipper answered the first cradle in four seconds, the second in four. Repeatable. Boring. The third cradle waited with its couplings capped, the empty frame that had been inspected in May by a man who was now holding the door.

"Where is your heavy dummy?" Marc asked.

"Delayed."

"I can mark the instrument absent."

"At eleven thirty."

"That is generous."

"The project paid for the slot."

Marc opened the local schedule. "Guaita declared a contribution incident at ten forty-one. They may need this room for continuity validation."

"This is a research annex."

"Today every room is eclipse infrastructure."

He was too helpful in exactly the way he had been in May. He supplied the rule before anyone asked which authority would use it.

Arnau walked the annex perimeter once. He was not trained for this. He counted exits, then counted them again because the first count had included a door that only opened from the inside. Júlia stayed at the project console and did not look at Marc.

"If they bring it," she said quietly, "we treat it as evidence first and a computer second."

"If they do not bring it, we have two instruments and a cancelled allocation," Lin said.

"Then we have proved only that we arrived."

At 11:16, a dark van stopped outside.

The grey EBRO waited across the street beneath trees, legally parked. Deng remained behind the windscreen. He had followed the hardware, not Lin. A second figure sat in the passenger seat and did not turn towards the annex. Observation, not rescue.

Two Guaita contractors brought a black Yulan case through the public loading entrance. Their incident credential named a recovered contribution appliance and authorized temporary technical custody. Every field was complete. The shipper was Llevant Import.

The case seal matched the copied seal from May.

Mei answered Lin's video call from Llevant's shuttered showroom. Lin held the institute camera on the seal while Mei compared it with the photographs from the false shipment. She asked for the left hinge, the underside of the handle and the abrasion beside the number seven.

“Same case family,” Mei said. “Not the same case. The label stock is ours. The print alignment is not.”

“Can you prove that?” Arnau asked.

“I can prove our printer leaves a two-millimetre margin. This has four. Whether anyone cares depends on who writes the first report.”

Lin added Mei’s comparison to the project record before the case crossed the marked line. The act cost another minute. Marc watched the clock and said nothing.

“Your third instrument,” Marc said.

Lin did not touch it. “Where was it recovered?”

The taller contractor consulted his tablet. “Municipal shipment exception.”

“Which municipality?”

“The incident record is restricted.”

“Then it does not enter my cradle.”

Marc lowered his voice. “If you reject it, the allocation closes. Guaita will remove all three cases for inspection.”

Reixac had put Llevant’s name on both doors: accept the stolen module or lose access to it under perfect procedure.

Lin photographed the seal, the credential and the case on the institute camera. She added a note to the project record: **Instrument received under disputed third-party custody. Identity not verified.**

The Guaita contractor offered a signature box.

“No,” she said. “Your custody ends when you place it on the marked floor. My custody begins only after service validation.”

The man looked at Marc.

Marc nodded. “Acceptable.”

The contractors withdrew but did not leave the building. Their van remained.

Lin opened the case.

Ingot sat inside.

For a moment nobody moved. The machine was a black service module with handles where hands required them and blank metal where a logo would have advertised ownership. Every disputed manifest, false pallet and missing person had been arranged around something two people could lift.

Arnau had expected revelation to make the conspiracy larger. Instead it gave the conspiracy dimensions: sixty centimetres, a forty-three-kilogram module that weighed eleven more than the catalogue assembly it had replaced, three coolant ports and a scratch on the right rail. Case and fittings brought the shipment to sixty-two. Remove Ingot, restore the ordinary assembly, and the same box weighed fifty-one.

The module was smaller than the empty frame suggested, dense around its memory and package fabric, coolant connections protected by transport caps. A month in Guaita’s custody had added one inventory label and removed none of Yulan’s internal marks.

Lin connected the orange Flipper to the maintenance lead. Her service application read the module’s counters without waking the compute fabric.

Transport healthy. Package seal intact. Last powered state: 16 July. No full model run.

Guaita had stolen Ingot without using it because it could not use it alone.

“Six kilowatts available,” Júlia said from the cradle console. “Direct cooling stable. Research fabric reserved.”

“Conventional accelerators?”

“Attention and dense layers ready.”

Arnau watched the corridor camera rather than the module. “Guaita contractors are still inside the annex.”

“Deng?” Lin asked.

“Still in the EBRO.”

“He will not come in.”

“How reassuring.”

Lin and Marc lifted Ingot into the third cradle. His hands knew exactly where the weight would shift. Before Lin reached for the rail release, Marc pressed the recessed catch beneath it and turned the module two degrees to clear the coolant manifold.

The movement did not appear on the public service sheet. Lin had learned it from the loose cable in May.

“You opened the dummy case in May,” she said.

“I found a loose cable.”

“You copied the seal before you opened it.”

Marc kept his attention on the cradle guide. “You chose not to call security.”

“You offered to call Guaita.”

“I offered procedure. You supplied secrecy. Salvador did not need me to make that choice for you.”

The module seated.

Júlia enlarged the disputed incident credential on the project screen. The authorization chain ended at a Guaita account created before Lin’s van arrived, not at the institute duty desk. Marc had supplied the rule at 11:09. The rule had been waiting since 10:41.

Cooling pressure rose. Power became available but remained gated. The full Shanhai weights waited in approved project storage, too large for the four ordinary boxes in Badalona and useless without the hybrid fabric.

Lin closed the service panel. Arnau looked from the hidden catch to the credential chain and then to the contractors who had not left the corridor.

“How long?” he asked Marc.

Marc did not pretend to misunderstand. “Since the May test.”

Marc stepped away from the cradle. “Today Guaita is the continuity authority for this annex. At the first incident, they assume custody.”

“What counts as an incident?” Arnau asked.

“Whatever the dashboard cannot explain.”

Arnau moved between Marc and the corridor. “Did you know Oriol was in the mobile room?”

“I knew his validator remained active.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“It is what I can prove. You taught me to answer that way.”

“Why?”

Marc looked at the two approved instruments as if they might answer for him. “Eleven years of grant contracts. Every project ends in June and I am renewed in September if somebody remembers. Guaita offered me the continuity lead for this annex. Permanent. My daughter starts school in September.” He lifted one shoulder. “Reixac never asked me to hurt anyone. He asked me to follow procedure a little earlier than the institute would.”

Arnau had heard the same arithmetic from half the engineers he had ever hired. It had never before ended with a stolen machine in the next cradle.

Marc checked the third-cradle temperature, found it half a degree above forecast and adjusted the room set-point. Then he divided the wall display into three.

The fire panel showed clear roads with no vehicles. The traffic panel showed a queue with no smoke. The custody panel showed two approved instruments and an empty third position while Ingot cooled beneath it.

“Choose one,” he said.

Júlia photographed all three in the same frame.

Marc returned the wall to the cooling curve. “The room is stable.”

The corridor door opened. One of the Guaita contractors checked that the black case was no longer on the floor, then spoke into his cuff microphone.

At 11:43, Lin armed the third instrument.

Ingot drew its first full breath of cooled power.

Across the street, the grey EBRO’s lights came on.

Chapter 19: First Boot

Ingot's first useful hour ended with one truth, one lie and no way to distinguish them by confidence alone.

Arnau watched the model load. When Ingot's routing predictions held, tokens moved. When they missed, the machine paused long enough for everyone to hear the cooling.

"Five point nine kilowatts," Lin said. "Within limit."

"First-token latency is terrible," Arnau replied.

"It has no prompt history."

"A flaw shared by people."

Lin had commissioned the module before the load began, kneeling at the cradle with her engineer enrollment on a hardware token. Ingot was a prototype with one key slot. It would not run a session for anyone it had not been introduced to, and it encrypted everything the session wrote, model state and working index alike, under a key that existed only inside the module.

Marc had watched from the doorway. "If the incident requires transport?"

"Standby," Lin said. "Two minutes. It seals the session key so the work can resume on another fabric. Decommissioning destroys the key. That takes longer, and it is the one operation nobody should interrupt. A half-written key store on a single-slot prototype is a brick."

"Who can recommission it?"

"An enrolled engineer. Or the factory."

Marc had nodded as though the answer were routine and returned to the corridor.

Júlia read the verification harness line by line. Every claim needed an independent source before it could leave quarantine.

The first task asked a narrow question: explain the repeated correction traffic inside several eclipse contribution streams.

Before Júlia admitted the prompt, the allocation clock turned amber.

Guaita's incident order had reduced the annex slot to forty-five minutes. The model load had used seventeen. Lin could preserve the performance counters or complete the evidence pass, not both.

Arnau called Reixac through the recorded project line.

Reixac answered with the contribution floor behind him. Staff crossed the frame carrying cables and eclipse filters. He wore a headset Arnau had seen him use during ordinary failures.

"We need the original allocation restored," Arnau said.

"Institut Llum accepted the incident window."

"The cooling reservation and project letter run until twenty-one hundred. Your order shortened access after the instrument arrived."

“Is the third instrument operational?”

Lin watched Arnau from the cradle. Júlia kept her hand away from the prompt control. The correct answer was also the one that gave Reixac what he wanted.

“All three instruments are stable,” Arnau said. “The research team is ready to continue its approved evaluation.”

Reixac waited. He had spent eleven years teaching Arnau which sentence belonged in an incident call. Arnau had supplied it without accusation, history or the word Ingot.

“As Lenticular engineer of record,” Reixac said, “do you recommend restoration?”

Arnau looked at his visitor badge on the desk. Lenticular had suspended his access, removed his equipment and instructed colleagues not to answer him. The project letter still carried his signature.

“Yes, Salvador.”

Reixac extended the allocation to twenty-one hundred. His approval appeared on the project display while the call remained open.

“Thank you,” Arnau said.

“Finish the test.”

The line closed. Lin saved the authorization beside the disputed custody record. Arnau removed the headset and placed it carefully within the outline marked on the desk.

Before the answer, the model produced work.

It requested samples from feeds Júlia had excluded, proposed three incompatible schemas and tried to allocate more context than the research fabric allowed. Lin reduced the active expert set. Arnau rejected a camera archive whose licence did not permit this use. Júlia forced every generated parser into a container without network access. The first twenty-three minutes consisted mostly of saying no to a machine capable of asking faster than they could refuse.

The annex door clicked each time somebody passed in the corridor. A trolley squeaked beyond it. On Júlia’s display, six thousand evidence records became five thousand eight hundred and then five thousand four hundred. Frontier scale had entered the room as subtraction.

The first complete response took eleven minutes after the harness admitted the prompt. It blamed routine clock maintenance and cited a vendor bulletin from 2024. Arnau recognized the bulletin. It concerned studio intercoms, not contribution encoders.

“Same manufacturer,” he said. “Wrong product family.”

Júlia marked the citation invalid. The complete answer vanished from the audit screen. Lin did not preserve it as a near miss.

“Again,” she said.

The second run stalled and repeated the same phrase until Júlia killed it.

Shanhai proposed four possibilities. Clock maintenance. Error correction. Vendor telemetry. Covert index transfer.

It wrote a parser for the event records. Júlia ran generated tests against known samples. One failed because the model treated a length field as elapsed time. Arnau corrected the interpretation from the broadcast specification. The second parser passed.

They gave it one feed whose correction blocks Arnau had already counted by hand. The model found fourteen. His worksheet contained thirteen. For nine minutes they assumed he had missed one. Then Júlia found the model counting a retransmission as a new observation.

“It is the same block,” Arnau said.

“It arrived twice,” Lin replied.

“The network repeated it. The world did not.”

Júlia added a source-lineage test. The count fell to thirteen. Only then did she allow the other feeds back into the context.

The fourth possibility moved to the top.

Each correction block travelled beside an unregistered user-data field, the kind most players ignore. In unrelated camera feeds, that field carried fragments that repeated by Atlas node rather than by any clock or video fault. The fragments assembled into relationship updates: operator, gateway, probable room, confidence. Players skipped them. They were not needed to make the picture reach viewers.

“That is the export path,” Arnau said.

“A candidate path,” Júlia replied.

“Three independent feeds. Same structure.”

“Then call it verified structure. Destination remains inference.”

They traced the contribution route to a commercial relay reserved for post-eclipse international distribution. Narthex held a client certificate for the receiving service. It could not control the cameras. It could receive the completed map once Guaita placed it inside traffic everyone expected to be large.

The model had found an infrastructure boundary no person in the room had seen.

“Cheap hardware,” Arnau said.

“Cheaper memory and packaging,” Lin corrected. “Inside a room with expensive power, cooling, networking and conventional accelerators. Anyone who calls this a laptop supercomputer is selling something.”

“What are you selling?”

Lin studied the stable six-kilowatt line. “The right to say we built a different part of it.”

Lin photographed the performance counters. Proof of the architecture.

Arnau photographed the verified correction pattern. Proof of the sale.

Júlia signed neither.

“Second task,” she said.

Atlas contained an identity cluster attached to Llevant’s customer profile. The cluster linked the false southern shipment, the traffic receiver crate, a warehouse camera operator and the fifth Yulan case. Its subject name remained blank.

Shanhai filled it.

Chen Zhou. Confidence 0.94.

Arnau stared at Mei’s father’s name.

Nobody corrected the screen.

Cooling continued behind them. A cleaner pushed a cart past the annex window and paused to read the eclipse notice on the door. Marc answered a radio call in the corridor. The ordinary building supplied eleven seconds in which the accusation looked finished.

Below the name, Shanhai proposed actions: suspend the customer profile, preserve associated devices, notify participating operators. Each was reasonable if the name was true. Each could reach Llevant before Arnau reached Mei.

He pulled the network lead from the audit display.

The screen went grey. The isolated run continued; only the outward presentation stopped.

“That was not your control,” Júlia said.

“Then assign me one.”

“You are protecting a person you know by interrupting a process you agreed to observe.”

“Yes. Write that down too.”

The model cited five sources. Together they told a persuasive story: Chen had used his company to receive Ingot and move empty cases south.

“False,” Arnau said.

“You know him,” Lin replied. “The model does not.”

“He did not ship the pallet.”

“Prove it inside the evidence.”

Arnau opened the provenance graph. There was no paper trail behind them. The five sources collapsed into one origin: Llevant’s copied evaluation profile.

Júlia changed the independence rule.

Confidence fell from 0.94 to 0.38.

“Still too high,” Arnau said.

“For what action?” Júlia asked. “That is the missing field.”

“For any action against him.”

“Then the system needs an action threshold, not a nicer number.”

He wanted her to say Chen was innocent. Instead she had offered another column. Arnau pushed his chair back hard enough to strike the cable rail.

“What do you want me to enter?” he asked. “That he makes terrible tea? That he keeps screws from broken radios because a child may need one? I know where he was Sunday morning. Mei knows. Half the estate knows. Your machine has five copies of one lie and calls that evidence.”

Júlia let him finish.

“Then those people are evidence the dataset excluded,” she said. “They are not a correction I can invent because you are angry.”

Arnau looked again at the five branches collapsing into one copied form. Chen’s decency, Mei’s certainty and the meals in the warehouse office appeared nowhere on the screen.

He opened a blank observation record, then stopped.

“If I enter my testimony now, I am changing the evidence after seeing the answer.”

“Yes,” Júlia said.

“But excluding it leaves the answer wrong.”

“Also yes.”

Lin glanced at him. “Now you understand why Hsu kept paper outside our project.”

They did not add Arnau’s testimony. They marked the identity unresolved and listed what was missing: physical receipt, independent witness, original serial ledger.

Arnau called Mei at Llevant.

She answered over voices and warehouse alarms. The independent inspector had opened the dummy. Guaita’s observer was contesting the record.

“The model named your father,” Arnau said.

Silence.

“As what?”

“Operator behind the shipment and camera equipment. It is wrong.”

“Why?”

He explained the shared template and collapsed sources.

“Then show it the people,” Mei said. “Joel, my father, the driver, the neighbour who opened his yard.”

“They are not in the dataset.”

“That is why the dataset is wrong.”

Behind her, someone called Chen’s name.

“Do not publish anything,” Mei said.

“We won’t.”

“Not the false identity. Not the true route. Not until I know what publication does to this warehouse.”

Behind Arnau, Ingot’s cooling rose as the next task entered memory.

Mei heard it. “You are continuing.”

“The people index is quarantined. The infrastructure route can prove Guaita is exporting Atlas.”

“The last task named my father. What does the next one get to name before you call me?”

“Nothing leaves the room.”

“You answered a different question.”

At Llevant, somebody lowered a shutter by hand. The chain rattled through the call. Arnau pictured Mei standing in the loading lane with the independent inspector, Guaita’s observer and her father listening to a machine accuse him from another city.

“If we stop now,” he said, “we lose the path to Narthex. We may lose the path to Oriol.”

“And my father is at the beginning, where you can see him, so his danger feels less urgent.”

“I pulled the display lead.”

“After his name appeared.”

“What do you want me to do?”

“Stop asking the machine questions about people until the people in its answers can answer back.”

Júlia watched him from the verification desk. Lin did not. She kept her eyes on the performance counters, giving the marriage no privacy and no audience.

Arnau looked at the grey screen. Stopping the people task meant giving up answers before he knew whether one of them would be Oriol.

“If his name appears,” he said, “we could find him.”

“If his name appears, you will believe it because you need it.”

“I would verify it.”

“Like you verified my father by knowing him?”

He did not answer.

Mei continued. “Keep the machine. Keep the route. Freeze every identity result. If Oriol appears, it waits with all the others. You find him from evidence we can challenge.”

“That may cost time.”

“It already cost ten days because men who knew better decided our risks for us. I am deciding this one with you.”

Arnau turned to Júlia. “Can you move the whole identity layer into quarantine without stopping the infrastructure pass?”

“Yes. Marc will see the scope change.”

“Then let him.”

She built the quarantine as its own encrypted volume on Ingot’s local flash. The harness held its key and would release it only on two signatures. She excluded the volume from the annex snapshot schedule and from every replication job. Nothing in it would exist anywhere except inside the module.

Júlia made Arnau sign the change. His project authorization sat beneath hers, the same two names that appeared in Atlas’s old manifest. This time the signature removed access instead of granting it.

“Done,” he told Mei.

“Send me the signed scope.”

“You don’t trust me?”

“I trust you enough to require the record while we disagree.”

He sent it.

The warehouse chain stopped rattling. Mei read the scope while he waited.

“Now continue,” she said.

The line ended.

At the annex door, Marc watched the status display. “First result?”

“Quantization baseline,” Lin said.

“Successful?”

“Mixed.”

He looked disappointed, which meant he expected a more useful lie.

His gaze moved to the provenance graph before he left. Arnau saw the moment Marc understood that the duplicated-source weakness had been found. He sent a message without taking his phone from his pocket; his thumb moved twice against the fabric.

Within a minute, Guaita’s incident dashboard added a yellow warning beside the annex cooling circuit.

No sensor value had changed.

Júlia verified that the entire people index remained in quarantine. She left the verified infrastructure relationships available for audit.

On the model screen, Chen Zhou’s name disappeared.

The correction stream remained. Marc’s yellow warning remained as well.

Chapter 20: Grass Parking

The first southern viewing site closed at 15:07.

Lin learned from a Guaita dashboard before the public announcement reached the radio. A green capacity bar turned red. Traffic advice changed from **USE OFFICIAL ROUTE** to **FOLLOW LOCAL DIRECTIONS**. Beneath it, a list of unofficial overflow areas appeared without fire-service approval.

“Who added those?” Arnau asked.

Marc read the screen. “Event coordination.”

“Which coordinator?”

“Guaita aggregates the local status.”

“That was not my question.”

Marc left to answer an incident call.

Inside the annex, Ingot continued loading Atlas observations as eclipse feeds came online. Outside, Barcelona moved through an afternoon that looked ordinary except for people stopping on pavements to test glasses against the full Sun. Totality lay far south and west. The city would receive deep partial darkness, not the complete event promised by careless headlines.

Lin’s phone carried the part of the country the annex could not see.

Marta called from a service road above the southern broadcast site. Cars filled both sides despite no-parking signs. A police vehicle tried to turn a camper back and discovered five more behind it.

“Guaita navigation is sending them to fields,” Marta said. “Not official car parks. Field entrances.”

“Can you reach Oriol’s mobile room?”

“We can see it below the broadcast mast. The road between us has stopped.”

Lin asked her to turn the camera.

The picture moved from Marta’s face to the road. Vehicles occupied every useful surface: compact cars nosed into olive terraces, rental vans with wheels on the white line, a motorhome angled across a gate because its driver had discovered too late that the opening was narrower than the vehicle. Families carried folding chairs uphill between them. A handwritten sign offered parking for ten euros in a field the official map marked as uncultivated scrub.

“That gate was chained when we passed at noon,” Marta said.

“Who opened it?”

“Somebody with bolt cutters or a key. The owner is in Reus.”

The Guaita dashboard described the same place as **COMMUNITY OVERFLOW B**. Capacity eighty. Current occupancy sixty-three. Fire access status unknown.

An unknown field had acquired a confident name and a useful number. Drivers saw the number, not the chain on the ground. The number did not stay on the dashboard. Guaita published the event's official closure and parking feed, the one navigation apps took in every few minutes as road truth. Once a field carried a name and a capacity, every phone on the southern roads could route a driver to its gate.

Leïla sent a photograph. The white Tramuntana body stood among production vehicles, its false equipment-room wall presumably installed again. A dark van waited beside it. One person in a yellow incident vest guarded the door.

No face. No proof Oriol remained inside.

At 16:20, a second official site reached capacity. Navigation applications redirected vehicles towards secondary roads. Drivers followed one another through open gates because the car ahead made uncertainty look authorized.

The annex received hundreds of traffic observations each second but almost no meaning. A receiver reported twelve vehicles. A camera counted nineteen objects. A navigation partner reported slow movement. Nobody's feed contained the sentence that mattered: the last safe turning place had been blocked by a family unloading a refrigerator-sized telescope.

Shanhai inferred the obstruction from three sources and suggested a route around it. Júlia checked the alternative against the fire-service layer. The road ended at a dry ravine.

"Reject," she said.

The model proposed the same road two minutes later with a lower confidence score.

"It does not remember that the ravine is a reason," Arnau said.

"Then we encode the reason."

Shanhai had saved them hours on the correction stream and could still turn a mapped line into a road because the syntax allowed it. Its usefulness increased the cost of trusting it casually.

Marta and Leïla left their vehicle on gravel and continued on foot carrying water, fire blankets and the Room Zero module. They could move faster than traffic but not fast enough to cover kilometres casually.

The hillside smelled of dust, crushed thyme and hot engines. People sat on folding chairs facing west as if the view were a cinema that had not yet started. A child asked in French when the darkness would come. His father said soon and checked a phone whose battery had already swollen in the heat.

Leïla watched hands, shoes, who belonged. A man in a yellow vest stood too still beside the mobile room. Another walked the same ten metres repeatedly without looking at the sky. The crowd was cover and a problem. Any sudden movement would be visible. Any correct movement would take too long.

"If we go down now we become another blocked car," Marta said.

"If we wait, the fire does the blocking for us."

Marta looked at the cured grass along the unofficial track. Pale, brittle, already marked by tyre prints. She had spent Tuesday watching a similar margin burn.

"Then we wait where we can still move."

At 17:36, the first car parked on cured grass began to smoke.

A spectator recorded the beginning. The video reached the contribution centre and then the annex because every programme wanted eclipse traffic pictures. A family unloaded chairs from

a hatchback. Behind them, a thin line of smoke appeared under the engine side of another car. Somebody pointed. The driver opened a door, saw flame beneath the dry stems and tried to move.

The tyres carried burning grass forward.

Lin saw the driver climb back into the burning car after two people shouted at him not to. The rear wheels spun on the slope. Burning stems wrapped around the axle. When the car gained traction, it crossed six metres of field and stopped beside a row of vehicles whose owners were watching the sky from the ridge.

The camera operator backed away. The image swung across bare legs, sandals and a child carrying eclipse glasses in both hands. Somebody dragged the child out of frame. A woman tried to beat the flame with a picnic blanket made of synthetic fabric. It shrank from the heat and stuck to itself.

"Tell contribution control to keep the original rolling," Arnau said.

"Broadcast wants thirty seconds," Marc replied from the doorway.

"Fire command needs the road geometry."

"That is not what this feed was contracted for."

Lin copied the request into the project log. "Ask the operator for an emergency share. Do not take the stream."

Marc looked at her as if consent were an inefficient protocol. He made the call.

The operator agreed. A second view appeared in the fire-service workspace, delayed by the same contribution path Atlas was using for the index. The camera had become useful twice: once to sell a spectacle, once to show responders which entrance the spectators had blocked.

People shouted contradictory instructions. One man used an extinguisher on the vehicle while fire travelled behind him. Others moved their cars at once, blocking the narrow track firefighters needed.

The clip ended before the outcome.

"Vehicle heat can ignite grass," Lin said. "It does not happen every time."

"It only needs to happen once in each field," Júlia replied.

It happened more than once.

One fire began beneath a parked vehicle. Another started near a cooking flame somebody believed was shielded from wind. A third cause remained unknown. Dry vegetation, heat and delayed response joined them. Guaita had not struck a match. Its routing system had placed more ignition sources on unsuitable ground and made every evacuation route carry arriving traffic.

The first field's owners reached their cars together. Doors opened into the narrow space between rows. Engines started. Navigation screens told drivers to leave by the entrance through which the fire engine was trying to arrive.

Berta abandoned the programme script and repeated the local instruction: leave keys with the vehicle, move on foot only when directed, keep the access lane open. The studio put a map behind her. It showed the official car parks in blue and omitted Community Overflow B because no authority could confirm it existed.

Guaita's public layer still showed the field in green.

"They know it is burning," Arnau said.

"Their fire layer knows," Júlia replied. "Their parking layer has not accepted the update."

"One operational view."

Marc had returned to the corridor. He heard the phrase and did not answer.

By 18:05, smoke crossed the western horizon at the largest southern site. The Sun remained high enough to shine above it for now. Spectators refused requests to leave.

They had driven from France, Germany, the Netherlands, Madrid, Barcelona. They had booked rooms a year in advance and slept in cars. Totality would last little more than a minute and might not return to their lives. A warning about possible smoke competed with the certainty that leaving meant missing it.

"They are not irrational," Júlia said. "They are valuing a rare event above a risk described as possible."

"That is irrational," Arnau replied.

"It is human. Which is why a routing system must include it."

Ingot's cooling load rose. Expert misses increased as the model moved beyond its earlier domain prompts into live feeds. Lin reduced the processing queue rather than the safety margin.

At 18:29, Leïla called.

"We heard Oriol," she said. "The mobile room opened for ventilation. A man inside argued about a clock correction."

"Saw him?" Arnau asked.

"No. Voice only."

"Can you reach the door?"

"Not while Guaita has three people and the crowd has nowhere to move."

She sent a wider image. Between Leïla and the mobile-room door, spectators had established a small village: chairs, coolers, camera tripods, two dogs tied to the same fence and a table selling warm bottles of water. Guaita's three incident workers looked ordinary within it. Reaching Oriol by force would require Leïla to start a panic beside a road already needed for fire.

"If he is inside, he has waited this long," she said. "I will not make the crowd our weapon."

Arnau wanted to tell her to reach the door anyway. The wish lasted long enough to frighten him.

"Open the fire lane first," he said.

Marta came onto the line. "A fire lane south of us is blocked by arriving cars. If we open it, we can reach the mobile room and emergency crews can reach the field."

"The temporary priority corridor," Arnau said.

Lin looked at the Flipper beside Ingot's service port. Its custom application now held the one verified event-receiver request extracted from the authorized rehearsal. Sending it could create a short green route for a registered emergency vehicle. It could also stop traffic they could not see.

"Not yet," she said. "Confirm the corridor and vehicle."

At 19:35, the Moon touched the Sun over Catalonia.

Nothing electrical failed. People in Barcelona cheered and looked through approved glasses. In the south, smoke lowered across one horizon.

Lin did not touch the Flipper.

Chapter 21: The Green Wave

Arnau opened the corridor at 19:46 and lost sight of what it closed.

Marta had confirmed the route three times. A local fire-service vehicle waited at the eastern end with its temporary eclipse priority identity active. The blocked lane led past the field below the mobile room. If the selected junctions granted one short sequence, emergency crews could enter and Leïla could move behind them.

The command had been captured during the authorized traffic rehearsal eight days earlier and verified against the temporary event system's documentation. The receivers were event equipment bought for one summer. They had never been built to refuse a request they had already heard. Arnau did not forge or alter the command. He would resend it unchanged. He did not guess a credential or teach Shanhai to attack a signal.

Lin connected the orange Flipper by serial lead to an approved maintenance bridge in the annex. The small device displayed the request and its registered emergency identity. The bridge would send it through the event network to a field gateway in the south. That gateway, already authorized, would broadcast locally to the temporary receivers.

The Flipper was a console, not a radio reaching across Catalonia.

"One request," Lin said.

"One corridor," Arnau replied.

"No status outside the selected receivers."

"I know."

"Say the cost."

He looked at the traffic map. "Vehicles on crossing approaches will stop. We do not know whether one is an ambulance, whether a driver enters late or where the queue ends."

"Now decide."

Marta's call remained open. Behind her voice came horns, a siren and people shouting directions in more than one language.

Arnau called Mei.

Lin's finger moved away from the Flipper. The request waited beneath the centre button.

Mei answered on the third ring. In the warehouse behind her, the emergency alarm gave one short tone every five seconds.

"I can open a temporary corridor in the south," he said. "Fire service is at the entrance. Leïla can follow towards Oriol's room."

"Can or must?"

"I am asking."

"You are telling me with the button ready."

He looked at Lin's hand, the registered identity and the green line that did not yet exist.

"Cross traffic stops for up to a minute," he said. "We cannot see the full queue. If another emergency vehicle approaches, the system may not compare them."

"Can the fire crew enter without it?"

Marta answered through the other call. "Not before the field closes. Cars are across both lanes."

Mei heard her. "And Oriol?"

"The mobile room is beyond the field."

"If he were not there, would you open the corridor for the fire engine?"

Arnau watched the southern map. Smoke had removed one camera. Spectators occupied the road the diagram still drew as two clean lines.

"Yes."

"Then do not make Oriol the reason. He is the reason you want it faster."

"Does that change the choice?"

"It changes whose life you pretend to be counting."

The alarm sounded again behind her.

"What is happening there?" he asked.

"Power has dropped twice. The inspector wants the cage open before the battery fails. Guaita wants the evidence server left online. I can keep one."

"Keep the evidence."

"You answered quickly."

"People can leave the building."

"Good. Answer your own question the same way. Open the road for the fire crew. Let Oriol be what comes after."

Arnau looked at Lin. "One sequence."

"One," she said.

"Send," Arnau said.

Lin made him press the centre button.

The maintenance bridge accepted the request. For four seconds nothing changed. Then the first southern receiver acknowledged, followed by the second. On the traffic diagram, a short line turned green.

Marta heard the result before Arnau saw it.

"Fire vehicle moving," she said.

The third receiver delayed because a junction was occupied. The corridor held. A crossing approach turned red and its queue length disappeared beyond the map's edge.

"What is stopped there?" Arnau asked.

"No camera in the test view," Lin said.

"Atlas has cameras."

"And we are not using a people index to justify the command."

Júlia found a public traffic feed pointed near the crossing approach. It refreshed once every fifteen seconds and showed only the back of the queue. A delivery van, three cars, a coach. On the next image, the coach had moved sideways to let a white vehicle pass. Only its blue roof light was visible between trees.

"Ambulance," Arnau said.

“Maybe.”

The temporary receiver had obeyed the authorized fire identity and stopped another emergency vehicle to do it. The system had no shared priority picture. Neither did Arnau.

“Cancel?” Lin asked.

He watched the acknowledgements. Cancelling would release the crossing but stop the fire engine before the field entrance. Continuing might hold the unseen vehicle for another minute.

“Complete the sequence,” he said. “Then report the conflict.”

The decision entered the audit under his name. No model softened it into an optimization.

The third receiver acknowledged after forty-two seconds. The green line reached the field entrance.

The public feed refreshed. The coach had mounted one wheel onto a verge. The white vehicle moved past it and disappeared. Siren sound arrived through Marta’s phone a few seconds later, travelling on a different road.

Arnau could not tell whether his choice had delayed care or merely looked as if it had. His name remained beside the forty-two-second hold in the audit.

The annex telephone rang on the emergency line.

Júlia answered and held the receiver away from her ear. A dispatcher wanted the operator responsible for the temporary corridor. Lin pointed at Arnau.

He gave his name.

“Did you hold junction E-three?” the dispatcher asked.

“For forty-two seconds. Registered fire identity moving west.”

“We had a medical unit on the crossing approach.”

Arnau looked at the public image frozen on Júlia’s screen. Blue light between two trees. No vehicle number.

“Was it delayed?”

“It left the queue. I am asking whether your sequence forced it onto the verge.”

“I can’t see the front of the queue.”

“Who can?”

Atlas could. The quarantined index had three probable cameras near the junction and one operator relationship above threshold. Arnau could ask the machine which view had watched the ambulance. The answer would also tell Atlas that this operator mattered.

Júlia turned the people display away from him.

“The public camera refreshes every fifteen seconds,” Arnau said. “It shows the coach making space. I can send those frames and our exact hold time.”

“Send them. Do not send me an interpretation.”

He exported three images, the receiver acknowledgement and the audit line carrying his name. The dispatcher stayed silent while they arrived.

“The medical unit reports no collision,” she said. “Delay unknown. Keep the crossing released.”

“It is released.”

“Keep it that way.”

The line ended.

On the wall, the white vehicle did not return. The next public frame showed only the coach lowering its wheel from the verge and a driver standing outside his car, pointing after the vanished light.

Marta's utility vehicle followed the fire crew. Leïla walked beside it until the road opened enough to climb in. Spectators moved barriers when they saw the engine, then closed around the route behind it.

"We can reach the mobile room," Leïla said. "Guaita can see us now."

The Flipper showed the request completed. Arnau disconnected it. Repeating the sequence would be a new action without authorization or visibility. There would be no second green wave.

He exported the request log before closing the service application. Lin signed the device state. Júlia added the public traffic images and the possible ambulance conflict. If an investigation later asked whether the corridor had helped, the answer would not be a triumphant green line. It would contain the vehicle they could not identify and the queue they could not measure.

On the annex wall, the 3Cat eclipse programme carried Berta live from the contribution centre. The partial Sun appeared beside her as a bright white curve through the approved filter. Behind the camera, producers spoke through her earpiece.

Her expression changed.

For months, Berta had been asked to turn the eclipse into appetite. She had stood beside school telescopes, interviewed astronomers about the chromosphere, corrected presenters who called a close grouping of planets a gravitational alignment, and answered viewers who wanted to know whether their pets required protective glasses. The repetition had made her voice familiar enough to enter kitchens without invitation.

Now that familiarity became emergency infrastructure no contractor had designed.

"Guaita has sent an update," she said on air. "It asks participating cameras to remain pointed at the sky and says traffic images may cause unnecessary concern."

Arnau heard Marc swear quietly.

Berta looked away from the teleprompter.

"We are not going to follow that instruction. Emergency services in the southern viewing zone are asking people to keep access roads clear and to leave unofficial parking areas when directed. If your car is on dry vegetation, do not move it if there is fire beneath or around it. Follow crews on site. Do not stop on the road to photograph smoke."

She did not accuse Guaita. She did not reveal Atlas. She supplied information viewers could use and refused the sentence intended to keep every camera on the sky.

The programme cut to a traffic view. Cars stood across a field entrance while a fire engine used the corridor Arnau had opened.

In Berta's earpiece the duty editor wanted the smoke footage checked before it ran again. She continued.

"Barcelona is not in the path of totality," she said. "Do not drive south now. The eclipse is already under way. Watch safely from where you are."

Some people would listen because they had heard her discuss glasses, planets, clouds and the same eclipse for months. Others would believe their own route was the exception. Berta could not clear a road from a studio. She could decline to make it worse.

The producer cut her microphone during an aerial sequence while the duty lawyer checked

the footage. Arnau saw her turn in profile and argue with someone beyond the camera. The programme filled twenty seconds with the shrinking Sun, then returned to her.

"My editors worry that showing smoke may encourage people to move at the wrong time," she said. "It is a fair worry. Emergency services decide when you move, not this programme and not a private coordination company. We will continue to carry their instructions."

Marc left the annex without explanation.

Arnau watched him cross the corridor to the two Guaita contractors. One used a phone. The other turned towards the instrument room.

"Incident custody," Lin said.

Ingot's cooling remained stable. The full model continued processing the falling light curve. Antumbra's relationship index moved towards completion. The verified audit trail grew beside the quarantined people table.

Júlia checked the southern feeds. "The green request created a timing marker. Atlas has correlated three traffic receivers with two camera operators."

"We helped it," Arnau said.

"And opened the rescue road. Both are true."

His phone showed a message from Mei.

Power unstable at Llevant. Inspector left. Guaita observer stayed.

Then Leïla called.

"We reached the mobile room," she said. "It is moving."

On the traffic feed, the dark van pulled away behind the fire engine and entered the corridor before the final receiver returned to normal.

The van's driver had waited on the shoulder until the fire identity opened the first junction, then joined close enough that the receiver treated both vehicles as one moving interruption. No hacked signal. No second command. Guaita used the gap created by a legitimate rescue decision.

Leïla ran beside Marta's utility vehicle as the van moved ahead of them.

"We gave them the road," she said.

"We gave the fire crew the road," Arnau replied.

"They took the rest."

He could hear her breathing and the crowd closing behind the vehicles. "Do not chase through people. Keep visual contact if you can. Oriol needs the road to stay open more than we need the van stopped."

Leïla swore once, then let the distance widen.

Behind the van, the fire crew parked an engine across the lane mouth and set marshals and cones along it. The junctions went back to their normal cycle.

Guaita rode Arnau's last green light out of the field.

Chapter 22: Smoke on the Horizon

Power failed at Llevant at 20:03.

The eclipse did not cause it. A transformer serving part of the estate had spent the afternoon under heat and unusual demand. Refrigeration, air conditioning, warehouse chargers, temporary event equipment. When it opened its protection, the showroom lights died, fans slowed and thirty people made the same surprised sound.

Mei heard the battery system start beneath the office stairs.

“Nobody moves,” she called.

Emergency lights came on. The warehouse changed from a workplace into aisles of shadow. Outside, neighbouring shutters opened as people checked whether the outage belonged to them or everyone.

The independent inspector had left after recording the weighted dummy. Guaita’s observer remained in unit two, a woman named Sílvia Prat who had shown valid insurance credentials and touched nothing without asking. Her restraint made Mei trust her less.

“The Yulan units require controlled shutdown,” Sílvia said.

“Four do. One is steel plates.”

“The evidence case still carries an active controller.”

“On an isolated supply.”

Mei opened the emergency panel. The battery could carry the evidence server, alarm, office network and one systems-room circuit for forty minutes. Not the four Yulan catalogue appliances, not the showroom, not the warehouse ventilation.

She shut down Shanhai.

The four ordinary boxes fell quiet one by one. Product reconciliation stopped. Open catalogue work disappeared from staff screens but remained saved. The local model had been useful all week. It was not entitled to power because a more important machine shared its name.

Mei killed every circuit except evidence, alarm and the office network.

The silence exposed how much of Llevant usually went unheard. Without ventilation, the roof clicked as it released the day’s heat. Battery alarms chirped in separate units along the estate. Somewhere in the dark, a toy activated inside its carton and began repeating a cheerful Mandarin instruction until an employee found it and pulled the batteries.

Mei assigned two people to each loading door, not as guards but as witnesses. She gave the office camera to her father and asked him to record the breaker positions, the battery display and the untouched evidence seal in one continuous shot.

“You trust paper more,” Chen said.

“Today I trust disagreement. You write the readings while the camera records.”

He found the carbon-copy delivery pad and began. Digital and paper would be forced to contradict each other honestly if either changed later.

“You are letting the warehouse die,” her father said.

“Temporarily.”

“That is how machines describe dying.”

He distributed torches from the returns shelf.

On a battery television in the office, southern footage showed smoke covering part of the western horizon. The Sun had narrowed under the Moon and lowered towards the fire haze. Crowds remained on hillsides. Emergency vehicles advanced through people who had carried chairs into their path.

Arnau called from Pedralbes.

“We are approaching the final calibration,” he said. “Guaita invoked incident custody.”

“Power failed here. Evidence store is alive. Everything else is down.”

“Your father?”

Mei looked at Chen, who was helping an employee find the manual release for a loading door.

“Still falsely identified. Still giving instructions.”

A pallet jack moved in the dark behind her.

Joel was pulling the fifth Yulan case from the cage.

“Stop,” Mei said.

He did not.

She ended the call and crossed the warehouse.

“The case stays under evidence seal.”

“Cooling is off.”

“It contains steel.”

“The controller is live. Corporate security said the hot case must leave if power or cooling fails.”

Sílvia appeared at the aisle end. “Which corporate security?”

Joel looked at her and understood too late that he had supplied a sentence nobody else possessed.

Mei put one foot in front of the pallet jack wheel.

“Name,” she said.

“He called himself Rui.”

“How long?”

“Since June. After the delivery. He knew Lin Qiao, the evaluation contract, the serial error. He showed Yulan identification.”

“What did you tell him?”

“Temperatures. Movements. Who asked about the cases. Nothing about customers.”

“You told him when we opened the dummy.”

Joel lowered his hands from the jack. “Yes.”

Mei wanted to strike him. The desire arrived cleanly and left her ashamed of its simplicity. Joel had collected her from school when her parents worked late. He had taught her which wholesalers paid on time and which customers returned a broken item only after replacing its useful parts. He had also given a stranger the movements of every person who entered their warehouse.

“Did Rui ask about me?”

“About everyone. He asked who understood the customs system, who kept local copies, who spoke to Lin. He made it sound like a compliance questionnaire.”

“And Arnau?”

Joel looked at the floor. “I said he notices the wrong things until they become the right thing.”

Even the description was affectionate. That made it worse.

“Walden?”

“No. I did not know you went home.”

“Figueres?”

“I found the modular supplier for you. I told him someone asked.”

The grey EBRO had followed Guaita north because Joel’s helpful queries travelled through both networks.

“You were protecting the product,” Mei said.

“I thought I was protecting us. If Yulan equipment disappeared, who would they blame?”

The same fear had put Mei in the warehouse before breakfast on Sunday. Joel had made her first decision with less information and a convincing badge.

“Move the jack away,” she said.

He did.

Sílvia held out her hand. “Guaita can take the case into powered custody.”

Mei laughed once. “Your company brought the empty cases south and the real machine to Pedralbes. This one stays where police labelled it.”

“That is an allegation.”

“It is also on three recordings.”

Around them, warehouse workers had raised their phones. Not secretly. Sílvia could see every lens.

She lowered her hand.

“Those recordings show a power incident and an employee trying to protect active equipment,” Sílvia said. “They do not show Guaita moving Ingot.”

“No. They show you knew which false case to ask for before Joel named it.”

Sílvia’s attention moved to the phones. Four employees had captured the sentence. Four recordings had begun at different moments. Sílvia could not face all four lenses at once.

“You should preserve the originals,” Sílvia said.

“Thank you. We sell storage.”

Chen laughed from behind the camera. The sound broke the fear enough for two employees to breathe normally again.

The battery estimate fell to twenty-six minutes.

Mei moved the evidence server onto its smallest supply and shut down even the office network. One disk, one alarm, one record of the open dummy. The rest of Llevant went dark.

The battery estimate rose from twenty-six to thirty-eight minutes. She wrote the number on Chen’s delivery pad and signed beneath it. Joel asked whether he should sign as witness.

“Yes,” she said.

He looked surprised.

“You do not repair a false record by disappearing from the true one.”

He signed.

Then Mei held out her hand for his warehouse keys.

Joel looked at them on his belt. The ring carried the front personnel door, both shutters, the returns cage and three neighbouring units whose owners trusted him to receive early deliveries.

“Until when?”

“Until I can tell everyone whose stock movements you reported and let them decide which keys return.”

“You need me tonight.”

“I need your testimony. That is different from access.”

Around them, the warehouse workers continued recording. Mei could have taken the keys into the office and called the matter family. Doing it in front of the people whose movements Joel had exposed made the cost public without making punishment the same as exile.

He unclipped the ring and placed it in her hand.

“Can I stay?” he asked.

Mei wanted him gone because his presence made anger compete with the power alarm, Guaita and the false case. Sending him away would also remove the witness who knew most about the weeks before the theft.

“You stay where somebody can see you,” she said. “Tomorrow you tell the neighbours yourself.”

“There is more,” Joel said. “About July. I am not ready.”

“Then be ready by the time I ask.”

Joel sat again beside the weighted dummy. He no longer guarded it. He waited with it under other people’s observation.

On the television, smoke swallowed the lower edge of the Sun.

Mei called Arnau again.

“Joel was the leak,” she said. “Yulan recovery. Deng Rui.”

“Is he safe?”

She looked at her cousin beside the pallet jack.

“He is here. The case is here.”

At the annex, someone spoke behind Arnau. An incident order. A transport seal.

“Mei,” he said, “they are taking Ingot.”

“Show me the seal.”

Chapter 23: Totality Engine

At 20:24, the false incident responders entered the annex and the model began its final pass.

They wore Guaita credentials over fire-service yellow. The credentials were valid. Their order declared an infrastructure cooling risk during a regional emergency and transferred all three research instruments into protected custody.

Marc Escudé opened the door for them.

Arnau counted three responders, not two. The third carried no tools, only a hard case for documents and an institute body camera clipped over the borrowed yellow. He positioned himself where his recording would show Lin obstructing authorized custody and exclude Marc at the access panel.

Júlia moved one step sideways. Her own project camera now included both men.

The responder adjusted his position.

So did she.

Evidence was already fighting over the shape of the room.

“Six minutes,” Lin said.

The lead responder looked at Ingot’s power display. “Immediate shutdown.”

“An uncontrolled shutdown risks coolant pressure and storage corruption. Six minutes gives you safe state and a clean storage pass.”

He consulted his tablet. The order covered removal. Lin’s warning made him owner of the shutdown.

“Four minutes,” he said.

Lin began the shutdown checklist on one display while leaving the audit job active on another. The actions were compatible only if the model completed before coolant isolation. She did not conceal that fact. The service camera recorded her hands, the counters and every warning.

“You are continuing computation during an incident,” the lead responder said.

“I am completing a storage consistency pass required by your transfer order.”

“The model task is not storage maintenance.”

“Then your technical author knows more about Ingot than the custody claim says.”

He stopped speaking.

The service camera caught him lowering the tablet.

Outside the annex, Barcelona’s Sun had become a thin bright crescent low in the west. The city was not inside totality. Streetlights woke under deep partial darkness. People cheered from roofs and courtyards, then quieted when the light acquired a colour no photograph on a phone could hold.

On the southern feeds, the Moon approached complete cover.

Some cameras showed a clean western horizon. Others showed smoke. One official site had travelled for years towards this minute and could see only an orange stain behind ash.

Shanhai processed the falling-light curves. Antumbra aligned exposure response, compression behaviour, network delay and corrected clocks. Atlas relationships that had remained probable turned confident. The clocks told Atlas which picture came from which box. Guaita's continuity records supplied the rest: the maintenance account inventory, address leases and asset sheets it kept for every partner it ran. Operators joined gateways. Gateways joined maintenance accounts. Unlisted rooms acquired addresses.

The people index filled beside them.

Names appeared faster than Arnau could read. Some came with source chains. Others came from copied records disguised as independent evidence. Chen Zhou returned at 0.92 until Júlia's harness collapsed the duplicated sources and pushed him back below quarantine threshold.

Thousands of other names had nobody in the room to defend them.

"Audit trail complete," Júlia said. "Infrastructure index at ninety-eight per cent. People layer still processing."

"Stop people," Arnau said.

The annex display changed before Júlia could act. Reixac appeared through the remote incident channel, seated somewhere quieter than the room he controlled. Júlia's hand stopped above the control. Arnau's command remained queued beneath Reixac's face.

"Do not interrupt the index," he said. "The person layer is the accountability layer. Without it, you are publishing a map of institutions and protecting every individual who abused them."

"And assigning thousands who did not," Júlia replied.

"Then publish confidence. Let courts decide."

"Courts receive names as facts long before they receive uncertainty as context."

Reixac looked at Arnau. "You spent your career demanding observability. Now that the system can show responsibility, you want a blind spot."

"Where are you?" Arnau asked.

"Does it alter the argument?"

"It alters whether you share the consequences."

Reixac's background contained a blank wall, a glass of water and no window. Even his room had been reduced to claims the camera could support.

"I am where continuity requires me," he said.

"You mean outside every system you are asking us to join."

"No. I mean outside the theatre. You are all mistaking proximity for virtue."

"A blind spot shared by everyone is different from a complete view sold by one company," Arnau said.

"Only until the next company rebuilds it," Reixac said. "And the next test will have a government signature. Delete this one and the capability survives. Only the signature changes."

"Then they should have to make the choice in public too."

Leïla answered through the open call from the south. "Query seven is in that layer. Karim's cluster, resolved."

Behind her voice came sirens and the engine of Marta's vehicle.

"If we delete it, your proof goes," Arnau said. "Júlia. Preserve it for a court."

“Where?” Júlia did not look up. “The store lives on Ingot’s flash. Ingot leaves in four minutes under incident custody. Preserving it means handing it to Guaita and asking a judge to request it back.”

“Export it.”

“Since the incident declaration our outbound link runs through Guaita’s continuity gateway. The checkpoint is hundreds of gigabytes. We have four minutes, and their gateway logs every byte it carries.”

“Only Karim’s record, then.”

“His record is a pointer into the graph. Alone it proves nothing. To prove it I would have to export the graph behind it. And to find it I have to query the people layer for his name.” She glanced at the open call. “Every people-layer query is written to the Atlas log. That is how we have Narthex’s query seven. Mine would land beside it.”

“I know,” Leïla said.

“I need you to say it,” Arnau said.

For two seconds Leïla did not answer.

On her open line, somebody called for a hose coupling. A child cried because the darkness had begun too early. Leïla had spent years searching for one person among systems that refused to name him. Now she was being asked to destroy the first searchable answer those systems had produced.

“Delete the people index,” she said.

Her voice did not break. The breath after it did.

Júlia selected the quarantine store. The system required two project approvals because her harness had treated destructive actions more carefully than inference. She signed first.

Arnau signed second.

The deletion would not touch the model weights. It would not destroy the verified infrastructure audit or the evidence showing Guaita had built Atlas and Narthex had contracted for it. It would remove the completed table that converted probabilistic relationships into names a buyer could search.

Raw camera observations remained with their original operators. Guaita retained fragments and old tests. Room Zero’s replica, sealed in Leïla’s custody, held a graph without names. What would disappear was the unique completed checkpoint created from the eclipse curve, joined across institutions and ready for commercial query. Deletion prevented immediate ownership. It did not make the capability impossible.

The lead responder stepped closer. “Time.”

Lin opened the transport menu. “Not yet safe.”

“Your four minutes ended.”

At the southern site, the last arc of Sun vanished.

Totality arrived low over the horizon.

The land on the feeds darkened while a narrow orange band remained beneath the shadow. Venus appeared first, brilliant and well up in the south-west. No planet followed it. Mercury and Jupiter lay somewhere inside the orange band beneath the Sun, too low for any camera on the feeds. People who had spent the afternoon shouting stopped. Even one fire crew looked up for a second before returning to the line.

Arnau watched despite the room.

The cooling fans changed pitch as outside temperature dropped by a degree the building controls had not expected. On the roof, birds crossed towards trees as if evening had been compressed into seconds. From the streets beyond the university came a sound larger than cheering and quieter than panic, an entire neighbourhood reacting to a Sun that Barcelona could almost, but not completely, lose.

The southern camera nearest Marta showed the corona through a gap in smoke. The next showed nothing but an orange-black horizon. Two groups separated by twelve kilometres had travelled towards the same promised event and received different skies.

Shanhai completed the audit.

Júlia executed the deletion.

The harness destroyed the quarantine volume's key. The people table remained on Ingot's flash as ciphertext with nothing in the world able to read it. The harness produced a deletion receipt listing what had been made unreadable and what had been retained. No hidden soul escaped. No model objected.

Júlia did not trust the receipt alone. She asked the question every restore test had taught her: where else? The quarantine volume had never been in the annex snapshot schedule, and its replication log showed no copy leaving the module. Guaita's continuity mirror of the annex had last synchronized at 17:40, before the eclipse curve existed. She attached both logs to the receipt.

That was why Reixac had sent responders and a trolley, not a download. He had never needed a copy. He needed the module.

Arnau released the verified package.

Nothing large had to cross Guaita's gateway. The signed file had sat encrypted with each recipient since the afternoon, and only the release key went out, a few hundred bytes from Júlia's project phone.

It contained Guaita's contract path, Atlas provenance, Júlia's failure appendix, the correction-stream export route and the evidence sources behind each claim. No camera credentials. No live access. No searchable identities.

Berta received it. The investigating officer received it. Three independent research archives received the same signed package. Reixac could call it stolen, but not make every copy disagree.

"Published," Arnau said.

Reixac's image remained on the incident display.

"You have released stolen operational data during an emergency," he said.

"With provenance and limitations."

"Nobody reads limitations."

"That was your business model."

Reixac looked away. An alert had reached him somewhere outside the frame. The audit was no longer an object inside the annex. It was becoming questions in other rooms.

At that moment, Lin's service screen turned green.

"Safe," she said.

Transport standby. The session key sealed inside the module, not destroyed. On a fabric Guaita controlled, the infrastructure checkpoint and the model state could resume where they had stopped. The storage pass had held the fabric until the fourth minute, and the responder would tol-

erate one short operation after that, not two. Decommissioning would have destroyed the key, but it needed longer than anyone in the room would wait, and Marc stood at the access panel watching for exactly that menu. Interrupted, it bricked the module and took the service record with it, and Hsu's proof lived in that record. A sealed key could still be killed later, on a day with fewer hands in the room. Lin had chosen the operation she could finish.

The responders disconnected Ingot.

Arnau stood in the trolley's path. He did not touch it.

"Move," the lead responder said.

"Give me the destination address."

"Protected incident storage."

"That is a classification."

"Move."

Behind Arnau, the third responder's body camera recorded obstruction. Júlia's camera recorded the refusal to name a destination. Lin said his name once.

Arnau stepped aside.

He could delay the trolley for perhaps twenty seconds and give Guaita a clean image of him interfering with equipment during a regional emergency. Or he could let the case move and preserve the unanswered question. Resistance was not measured by how long he could make three men push him.

They worked correctly. Coolant isolated, power gated, transport caps fitted, module lifted into its black case. Marc checked each step. The digital custody record showed a Guaita incident recovery from disputed Llevant equipment and a transfer to secure storage.

Perfect custody for a theft.

Arnau held his phone towards the case. Mei watched from Llevant.

"Closer to the seal," she said.

He moved closer until the lead responder blocked him.

"No recording of protected transport."

The image had already reached Mei.

"It is ours," she said.

"The case?"

"The identity. Old logo, English first, B-seven serial. Same cloned customer profile. They are removing Ingot under a Llevant seal."

The responders closed the case.

In the south, totality ended. A point of Sun returned and crowds shouted with relief or grief depending on whether smoke had allowed them to see it.

In Pedralbes, no totality had occurred. The crescent widened slowly above the city.

Guaita rolled Ingot towards the door while Arnau's verified audit propagated beyond the company.

The trolley wheels crossed the annex threshold. On Arnau's screen, the deletion receipt remained beside the empty instrument position.

Chapter 24: Eleven Seconds Again

At 20:36, Mei watched Ingot leave Pedralbes on Arnau's phone while Leïla listened for Oriol, held somewhere inside a moving room.

The warehouse remained on emergency power. Employees stood in the loading lane where the air moved more freely than inside. Sílvia Prat had withdrawn to her car and was making calls beneath the Guaita logo. Joel sat on the floor beside the weighted dummy, guarding the evidence he had tried to move.

Arnau's image shook as the responders rolled the real module away.

"Keep the seal in frame," Mei told him.

"They are blocking me."

"Then record their shoes. Custody has feet."

Another call entered. Leïla.

Mei joined it.

"We lost the mobile room forty minutes ago," Leïla said. "We have just heard him."

Marta's engine and a siren filled the line. The green sequence had lasted barely a minute. Since then the fire crews had held an access lane open with engines, cones and marshals while ordinary signals returned and traffic crawled on either side. Marta had stayed behind the fire vehicle at walking pace. The Guaita van had used the same minute of green and the same held lane, then left it at a junction nobody saw through the smoke.

"You heard him," Mei said.

"Voice only, on the room's validation channel. Then the contribution feed changed."

Leïla sent eleven seconds of audio and timing data from the moving room's live validation channel. Mei forwarded it to Arnau without opening anything on Llevant's evidence system.

Arnau answered at once. "One point seven seconds. Twice."

The original fault.

Oriol had divided his staged clip into three islands of time. Now the mobile gateway lost the same interval between validation reports. Not random drift. A signature repeated by somebody who expected Arnau to see it.

"Can it locate him?" Mei asked.

"Not by itself."

Arnau replayed the audio through the annex monitor. Beneath Oriol's voice, three background tones sounded. The first belonged to the broadcast network. The second was a cooling alarm. The third might have been a reversing vehicle or a warning from the mobile power unit.

Ingot had left on the trolley. Nothing in the annex could classify sound now, and nobody missed it. Arnau had spent twenty years listening to outside-broadcast rooms. Lin heard the cooling alarm

before he named it. Júlia had stood beside enough mobile generators on the southern sites that spring to call the third tone a power transfer warning, not a vehicle. Three people disagreed for ten seconds and then agreed. The ambiguous tone stopped mattering. The missing interval did not.

Júlia came onto Arnau's call. "The delay appears only when the room hands its contribution link from one field relay to the next. The relays belong to the event network, not the traffic receivers, and the corridor work mirrors their logs to us."

The annex held the relay map from the corridor work: every temporary field relay on the southern sites, its position and its handover log, which the room's link had to pass through like any other contribution feed. The mobile room's 1.7-second gaps fell exactly on three handovers. Three possible roads became one.

The first road crossed the fire lane and had already closed. The second passed a relay the room's log never touched. Only the vineyard service road produced the three observed handovers in sequence.

"Confidence?" Mei asked.

"Route, high. Vehicle position, four-minute window. Whether Oriol is still inside, voice only."

Leïla answered before Mei could. "Voice is enough to follow. Not enough to enter."

No password. No camera takeover. One known clock fault intersecting a relay log the annex was entitled to read.

Arnau gave Leïla the next junction.

Marta knew the service track beside it. She left the held lane before Guaita expected anyone to follow. The utility vehicle crossed a vineyard margin, stayed on bare earth and rejoined the road ahead of the mobile room.

"We cannot stop them," Leïla said.

"The fire crew can," Marta replied.

She called the crew through the local emergency contact printed on the site plan and reported a vehicle using the cleared lane without authorization. Then Leïla gave Oriol's police incident number and registration.

The fire engine stopped across the narrow junction.

The dark van braked behind it. The mobile body it carried rocked once on its frame.

Marta stopped thirty metres back, leaving room for an engine to reverse. Leïla walked forward with both hands visible and the police incident number open on her phone. One Guaita worker climbed down from the passenger side and ordered the fire crew to clear the lane.

The crew leader pointed towards smoke above the field. "This lane exists for that."

"We are carrying contribution infrastructure."

"Then contribute from here."

The worker displayed his credential. The crew leader photographed it and asked for the missing man's registration again. Leïla gave the number, the spelling of Oriol's name and the time of the last voice capture. She did not say hostage. She said a person might be restrained inside and let the statement remain exactly as strong as the evidence.

Guaita's driver presented an incident credential. The crew leader read it and asked why an incident vehicle carried a missing man's live production identity. Procedure met a better question.

Police already moving with the fire response arrived four minutes later. It was past nine. The Sun had set behind the smoke, still partly eclipsed, and the light over the vineyards had gone the colour of old metal.

The Guaita driver tried to reverse. Marta's utility vehicle did not block him, but the stopped traffic behind her did. Spectators had filled the road as soon as the priority sequence ended. The crowd that had prevented Leïla from approaching the mobile room now prevented it from leaving.

She did not thank the coincidence. A blocked emergency road remained a blocked emergency road.

Leïla did not open the mobile room. An officer did.

Oriol sat inside before the false white wall, one wrist secured to the equipment desk with a plastic restraint. He was dehydrated, unshaven and furious that the first person he saw was not Arnau.

The room smelled of hot electronics, stale air and the chemical toilet Guaita had not let him use often enough. Empty water bottles rolled against one wall. A clock generator occupied the desk beside his restrained hand. He had reached its front panel with two fingers and changed a delay value nobody thought worth locking.

An officer photographed the restraint before anyone touched it. Another read Oriol his options as witness, victim and possible participant in the original staged clip. Rescue did not erase his own actions.

Leïla handed the Room Zero module to the second officer with its four signatures intact. He logged it against the query-log hash Júlia had read into the call that morning, for the court and not for anyone's company.

"You took your time," he told Leïla.

She held the phone so Mei and Arnau could hear.

"The one point seven seconds," Arnau said. "You planted it."

"Of course. You complained about that clock correction for six months during the Tour tests. I knew you would recognize it."

"You staged the first clip."

"I staged the room. I left the badge. Riera took it before I expected."

Arnau moved away from the annex doorway. Guaita's transport was gone. People crossed the corridor behind him carrying eclipse glasses and cables as though the building had not spent the evening losing a machine and finding his oldest friend in opposite directions.

"I thought you were dead," he said.

Oriol's answer began as a joke. Arnau heard it forming in the breath before the words. Oriol stopped it.

"I thought I could leave you a fault only you would follow," he said.

"You left me your badge, my wife's company and a room nobody could find."

"The badge was supposed to stay on the desk."

"Someone returned my father's watch to our bedroom."

Oriol looked towards Leïla's phone as if the distance to Barcelona had become visible inside it. "I did not know."

"Sunday, a little after one. Did you answer your phone?"

Oriol's head lifted. "They moved the room on Saturday, before your police reached the yard. Another shed, the same kind of shutter, the room backed up against it. The phone rang on a charging shelf. They were outside. I could reach the answer control through the cable gap, and the shutter chain with my foot."

"You struck the chain."

"Until someone came back. I thought you might hear the room."

"I heard you. I did not record it."

"Good."

"Why is that good?"

"Because for six seconds you answered as my friend."

"That sentence is doing a great deal of work tonight."

An officer offered Oriol water. He drank too quickly, coughed and tried again. Arnau waited through it. For ten days he had imagined this conversation as proof that Oriol was alive. Now that it existed, relief did not remove the choices that had made it necessary.

"Why me?" Arnau asked.

"Because you never accept a missing interval."

"That is why the clue worked. It is not why you chose me without asking."

Oriol held the bottle against his forehead. "No. It is not."

Mei let the silence remain long enough for both men to hear the difference.

Then, through the phone: "And the collection order?"

Oriol stopped looking for Arnau.

"Guaita asked me to validate an equipment-recovery rehearsal using Llevant's customer template," he said. "I knew the order was false. I put the Tour docket between its pages before I approved the print copy."

"You approved people coming to my warehouse."

"I expected you to reject the serial. I expected Arnau to see my name and follow the paper. Guaita prints its collection orders and hands them to the driver. They never pass back through the company systems once signed. You read every docket at your own counter. I have watched you do it."

"You expected correctly. They took our ledger through the rear while I argued with the driver you sent."

Oriol lowered his eyes. "I did not know about the second team."

"Neither did I. That is what happens when somebody else decides which risk belongs to you."

The officer beside him wrote the exchange into her notes. Oriol had hidden a clue inside Guaita's procedure and made Llevant the surface on which both sides tested their intelligence. Rescue did not transform that decision into courage.

"Why not tell me?"

Oriol looked towards the open door, where smoke and the last afterglow smeared the horizon.

"I tried once," he said. "In June I emailed three lines to a newspaper editor I trusted, from my company laptop. A question about who owned the eclipse calibration job. Reixac quoted the second line back to me within the hour, word for word, in a corridor."

Arnau knew the mechanism. His own prompt had travelled through Ephemeris the same way: a company account logs what its users send, mail or prompt, and whoever administers the account

reads it.

"After that, my badge, my phone and my laptop were his," Oriol said. "If I met you, the account tokens would put us in one café. If I called you, my phone became a witness against you. Paper was the one channel his systems never touched. And Reixac owns every rehearsal. He wanted me to validate the eclipse feed after the cameras disagreed. I spent years teaching systems to call a planned result successful. I was not going to run that rehearsal again."

He had disappeared voluntarily to make the evidence independent of his own company account. Guaita took him when he returned for the mobile room. Since then, he had been forced to validate contribution paths and used the only fault he knew Arnau would separate from noise.

"They did not need me for the model," Oriol said. "They needed a familiar name on the validation report. Every failed camera could be corrected under my profile. Every correction made Atlas stronger."

"Why keep sending the clock fault?" Júlia asked over the call. "It risked the validation."

"It passed rehearsal with the fault for six months. A known defect is invisible once enough people plan around it."

Arnau closed his eyes. He had complained about the 1.7 seconds, documented it and then accepted the workaround because the Tour and eclipse schedules could not wait for a replacement. Oriol had turned Arnau's compromise into a distress signal.

The officer cut the restraint.

At 21:07, Oriol stepped out of the mobile room.

His knees failed on the second step.

Leïla caught one arm. The officer caught the other and lowered him onto the gravel instead of pretending the movement had been controlled. Oriol sat with his back against the false room and the bottle between both hands.

"Hospital," the officer said.

"After my statement."

"During."

The fire crew brought a folding chair. Oriol refused it until standing became the only alternative, then accepted without thanking anyone.

"Are you coming?" he asked Arnau through the phone.

Arnau looked towards the annex door. A police officer inside had begun recording the disputed custody transfer. Júlia was preserving the shutdown screens. Lin was arguing that the transport destination was a classification, not an address.

"The roads are closed," he said.

"That is not why," Mei said. "He did not ask whether you could provide transport."

"If I leave before my statement, Guaita's body camera becomes the first record."

"You put the marriage into the rescue," Mei said. "You can hear what it cost."

Oriol was quiet for a moment. "Stay, Arnau. If they call me an unauthorized operator, your statement is the difference between my clue and their rehearsal. Come when it is signed. Not when it is perfect."

The ambulance crew arrived. Leïla lowered the phone while they examined Oriol, but did not end the call. Arnau heard clipped questions, the tear of packaging and Oriol objecting to a blood-pressure cuff as if it were poor engineering.

Arnau forwarded the custody record Guaita had generated half an hour earlier. The transport carrying Ingot had left the Pedralbes annex at 20:36 under a perfect Llevant custody record.

Mei stood between four ordinary Yulan boxes and one weighted dummy while power returned to the industrial estate in sections. Lights came on in neighbouring units. Llevant remained dark because she had not yet closed the emergency bypass.

“Oriol is alive,” Arnau said.

“Ingot is gone,” Lin said behind him.

Mei closed the emergency bypass. The four ordinary Yulan boxes restarted one by one beyond the wall. Beside Joel, the weighted dummy remained silent.

Somewhere east, the real module continued moving.

Part Four: The Beasts of Fire

The festival was already in the streets before the sky went dark.

Chapter 25: Perseids

By 22:11, the custody record said Ingot had reached secure storage.

Lin knew it had not.

The Guaita transport left Institut Llum at 20:36. Its digital route showed a direct journey to a protected incident depot west of Barcelona, arrival at 21:08, seal verified, power state safe. Every checkpoint carried a credential, timestamp and signature.

The grey EBRO had followed the physical van east.

Deng sent one photograph from a road above the city. Guaita's vehicle entered the coastal traffic towards Badalona while its official identity continued west.

Perfect records had separated from the box.

Lin sat on the annex steps with the orange Flipper in her hand. Nobody had listed it on the instrument manifest. Guaita had taken the module, case and coolant caps. They had left the small console because it looked like a toy and because Lin put it in her pocket before completing transport standby.

At close range, through Ingot's service port, the device could still run the decommission routine Yulan's menu called safe mode.

Arnau and Júlia remained inside giving statements. Marc had disappeared during the transfer; his badge and the entrance camera disagreed about who carried it.

When Arnau came outside for air, he saw the Flipper in Lin's hand.

"Guaita will say you withheld part of the instrument," he said.

"It was never on their manifest."

"Neither was Ingot until they wrote Llevant onto it."

Lin closed her fingers around the device. "Do you want me to give it to police?"

"I want you to document that you have it," he said.

"That is not the same as surrender."

"I am learning."

They photographed the device with the institute clock and sent its serial to the investigating officer. The officer declined to take custody of it. Lin folded the printed note of his refusal around her copy.

Deng called.

"Orders changed," he said.

"Recover from Guaita?"

"Recover from whoever holds it."

"That includes me."

"If you reach it first."

“Where are they going?”

“Badalona. The cloned seal is not only blame. It is access to an equipment pool already staged under Llevant’s identity.”

“Why would they keep it near the company they framed?” Lin asked.

“Because investigators look outward after finding a source.”

“And because Badalona gives you a reason to be there,” Lin said.

“Guaita chose your ambiguity,” Deng said.

“They chose yours first.”

The EBRO continued after the van. Deng did not invite Lin to join him.

“Tomorrow,” he said, “do not stand between the module and recovery.”

“Tomorrow began when you used Joel.”

He ended the call.

Lin contacted Hsu Yu-chen through the channel they had retained since the first package work. In Hsinchu it was already morning.

“The run succeeded,” Lin said.

“Whose definition?”

“Ingot served the full model. Independent counters recorded it. Atlas completed. We deleted the people index and released the audit. Guaita took the hardware.”

Hsu absorbed the sequence. “And Yulan?”

“Recovery is following.”

“Then two companies are pursuing a module built from work one of them says I did not do.”

“I have the performance record.”

“You have their record. I have mine.”

“Not yet,” Lin said.

“You still believe timing belongs to you.”

“If you publish before we recover it, Guaita will destroy the module.”

“If I wait until you recover it, Yulan will ask me to wait again.”

Hsu did not promise silence. Lin had forfeited the right to request it.

“What will you publish?” Lin asked.

“A checksum of the floorplan file, the date and the page we both signed. Enough to show where the design was in 2019 and whose names stood beside it. Not enough to reproduce it.”

“Yulan will say the file was created later.”

“The university archive signed its deposit in 2019. Your company asked them to hide the author, not alter the clock.”

“And Taiwan?”

“Do not use an island as shorthand for my decision. I will publish from Hsinchu because that is where the record is, under my name because the work is mine. Do not turn authorship into a flag.”

After 23:30, Arnau and Júlia emerged from the annex. City light erased most of the Perseids.

They saw one meteor.

It crossed briefly beyond the chapel roof and vanished before Arnau could point.

“Did you see?” he asked.

“Yes,” Júlia said.

Neither tried to record it.

Júlia found Guaita's public festival movement notice while waiting for another police question. Beginning Saturday at nineteen hundred, its Badalona contractors could move temporary lighting and continuity cases inside roads closed to ordinary traffic. The notice named no warehouse and no module. It supplied a deadline.

Lin put the Flipper into its black pouch.

She showed Arnau the notice. On the photograph he wrote **SATURDAY, 19:00** and placed it beside the false Llevant seal.

Chapter 26: False Custody

Digital custody sent Ingot west. A late supper sent it east.

On Thursday morning Mei stood in Llevant's loading lane with three photographs of the Guaita transport and a list of places that still served food after nine on Wednesday. The official record showed the case reaching a protected depot beyond Barcelona. The physical van had crossed towards Badalona after nine.

Arnau wanted to begin with road cameras. Mei made him begin with receipts.

"A camera gives you one vehicle at one time," she said. "Supper gives you the driver, whether he was in a hurry and which direction he thought he was going."

"If he paid by card."

"If he spoke to a person."

They took Chen's old delivery van because every dent already belonged to them. Lin sat in the back beside a crate of returned fans. Júlia stayed at Llevant with the evidence server and the four ordinary Yulan boxes. Oriol was still under medical observation. Leïla had gone to meet Sami.

One café remembered two men in yellow incident vests because one ordered a hot sandwich and left before it arrived. The sandwich still existed.

The owner took it from the cold display beneath the counter: bread rubbed with tomato, a folded omelette, one bite missing from the end. She had wrapped it after the taller man ran outside when a driver they had not expected moved the van. He returned, put coins beside an untouched coffee and told his companion that *they had changed the bay*.

"Who changed it?" Arnau asked.

"If he had supplied names, I would have remembered those instead of his sandwich."

She placed the parcel between them as though the driver might still come back to claim it. Condensation had softened the paper. Mei asked where the men sat, then sat in the taller man's chair herself. From there she could see the loading lane but not the main road. A convex security mirror above the bread shelves reflected the opposite kerb.

"He watched the mirror," Mei said.

The owner nodded. "Every time a grey car passed."

Lin remained in Chen's van. The grey EBRO had not followed them from Llevant, but Deng no longer needed to be present to alter a room. Mei photographed the chair, mirror and view, with the owner's permission. Arnau wrote down *changed the bay* and underlined *they* once. A pronoun was not a faction. It was more than the custody record had given them.

Arnau asked whether they could see the payment terminal log. Mei stepped on his shoe beneath the counter.

The owner had offered memory, not access to every customer's account. She drew the shape

of the Guaita logo on a paper napkin and remembered that the taller man kept watching a vehicle through the window. She could not remember its number plate.

"Blue strip on the left?" Arnau asked.

"Every European plate has that."

Mei thanked her before his questions converted help into an interview.

"They asked for the industrial estate," she said. "Not an address."

"Which part?"

"They said festival storage. I sent them towards the municipal depot."

Arnau found a municipal traffic image before they reached the van.

The Guaita vehicle appeared at the edge of the frame, westbound, twelve minutes after leaving the café. Its plate was hidden by glare. The dent above the right lamp matched.

"West depot," he said.

Mei kept driving east.

"One vehicle at one junction," she said.

"A public record with no reason to lie. Turn at the roundabout."

A driver behind them sounded his horn. Mei entered the roundabout and took the west exit.

"Your choice," she said. "You own the forty minutes."

The west depot occupied a fenced municipal yard beneath the motorway. Its guards and the investigating officer checked both entrances and the storage rows. No Guaita van, Llevant entry or cooled case had arrived.

Arnau looked again at the photograph. The traffic lane beside the van curved west, but a painted arrow on the road pointed towards a slip lane hidden beyond the frame. The van could have crossed the image westbound and turned east beneath the camera ten seconds later.

The frame had been accurate. Arnau had completed the movement outside it.

"Forty-three minutes," Mei said.

He locked his phone. "Mine."

She waited for the defence. None came.

"What now?" he asked.

"We call Joel."

"After what happened last time?"

"Yes. We do not avoid a useful person because trusting him once went badly. We change what we ask and who hears the answer."

"If he calls Rui again?"

"Then Rui learns that somebody borrowed a forklift somewhere east. No module, no bay, no route. Joel gives the answer through the recorded police line."

"You still trust him."

"Not with the same thing."

Arnau looked back at the depot gate. "That sounds convenient after my camera just cost us forty-three minutes."

"Your camera did not cost us anything. You did."

"Thank you."

"Do you want me to distrust every image now?"

"No."

“Then do not ask me to distrust every person. Joel made a choice. We change the conditions under which he can make it again.”

“And if he does?”

“It becomes evidence about him. Not proof that every answer he ever gave was false.”

Arnau watched traffic pass beneath the motorway.

“Does Joel know that is what you are doing?”

“He will hear the officer recording the call.”

“Answer the question.”

Mei looked at him.

“I will tell him,” she said.

She called from the officer’s recorded line, told Joel only that a case had moved east, and asked for forklift work after nine. No product name. No destination. No private promise.

Before asking the question, she told him why the line was recorded and what she had withheld.

“So you think I will report it,” Joel said.

“I think you need to know what I am trusting you with.”

“Almost nothing.”

“Today, almost nothing is enough.”

A gate camera finally showed the Guaita van passing east eleven minutes after its digital record placed it west. No depot had received the black case.

Joel found the next movement through a forklift driver who worked nights for three units. Shortly after ten, a Guaita case had been transferred from the van to a plain truck beside a rented warehouse. The men borrowed his forklift because their tail lift failed.

“Which forks?” Mei asked.

“Short pair. Bent right tip.”

Guaita’s own departure photograph in the custody record showed the underside of the case clean when it left the annex. Whatever marked it had happened after the van drove away.

The forklift driver described the transfer but refused his name until Mei named the officer handling the cloned shipment. He called the police station himself, waited through two transfers and confirmed the number. Only then did he agree to show them the damaged forks.

He was called Pau. He made them wait while he finished unloading six pallets of bottled water. Arnau watched a plain truck leave the neighbouring lane before realizing it matched nothing Pau had described.

“You are looking for every truck now,” Mei said.

“Yes.”

“Good. Know that you are doing it.”

When the water lorry left, Pau rolled out the short forks. The right tip bent upward by less than a finger width. Fresh black paint marked the inside edge.

“I took a picture,” he said. “Of their case. Just after ten, when the fork caught it. If somebody claims damage later, the driver pays. I make sure the driver can show what he touched.”

His phone showed 22:14, a black case on a pallet, two parallel marks beneath it and one shallow curved scrape. The customer label was visible above the scrape: Llevant, old logo, English first. A man in a yellow vest stood at the edge of the frame.

Lin set it beside the clean Pedralbes photograph and asked whether she could take a swab from the fork. Pau refused.

"Police can take one," he said. "You can take a picture of me refusing."

She did.

Pau demonstrated with an empty lighting trunk. The bent tip scratched where his own photograph showed the scrape.

"The man in grey was angry," Pau said. "The one in yellow told him the paint did not matter because the case would receive another label."

"Grey vest or grey shirt?" Mei asked.

Pau looked back towards the loading lane. "Vest, I think. Perhaps the yellow looked grey in shade. Put that I am not sure."

Arnau did. Certainty would not improve the scrape.

Lin measured the trunk against the photograph without touching the fork. The marks matched within a centimetre. Pau sent the picture to the officer's number before he sent it to anyone else.

On Arnau's page, a sandwich, bent fork and unpaid favour now formed an eastbound line.

The rented warehouse belonged to no conspiracy. Its tenant hired storage by the week for festival barriers, portable lighting and sound equipment. Guaita had sublet one rear bay through an event contractor. On Friday the contractors would stage their equipment around the estate. On Saturday it would move into Badalona's Festa Major closures.

The tenant opened the rear bay only after the investigating officer confirmed by telephone that viewing it would not contaminate a later search. The space was empty. Four clean rectangles remained in the dust. Three matched standard road cases. The fourth was wider and ended in two fresh arcs where trolley wheels had turned towards the inner door.

Arnau crouched without crossing the threshold. Cold air touched his face from a portable duct fitted through the wall. Somebody had paid to cool an empty storage bay during the hottest week of the year.

The tenant checked the sublease. Electricity was billed to the festival contractor. The supplementary cooling order had been added that morning under a Guaita incident number.

They had found the place after the machine left it.

"Why move Ingot into a festival?" Arnau asked.

"Because every road closure creates legitimate equipment movement," Mei said. "And because our label already belongs here."

Clara Reixac arrived at eleven carrying the same thin folder from Girona and a new page.

The new page cited the eclipse incident record. Llevant was now officially the shipper of the recovered instrument. Clara offered to remove the name through an amended contractor statement if Mei supplied the dummy, service logs and silence.

"Your offer grows each time your brother uses us," Mei said.

"So does your exposure."

"Put in writing that Guaita transported Ingot under a cloned Llevant seal."

"I cannot use a product name my client does not recognize."

"Your client founded the company."

"My client is Guaita. Corporate persons also have boundaries."

Mei almost admired the sentence.

Clara looked through the open shutter at workers preparing flower frames and painted festival pieces in a neighbouring unit. “By Saturday this district will be on television for the festa. It can be flowers and fire beasts, or warehouses and an unregistered Chinese accelerator. You can influence which picture arrives first.”

“Chinese accelerator,” Mei repeated. “When you need our name on a label, we are a local customer. When you need fear in a headline, we become China.”

“The module entered through a Chinese manufacturer.”

“The architecture has an author in Hsinchu, a custodian from Shenzhen, a European test booking and your brother’s buyer. Which country do you put in the headline?”

Clara did not answer immediately. Mei watched her search the folder for a safer country.

Mei closed the folder without signing.

“Both pictures are true,” she said. “Your brother depends on people believing only one can be.”

Clara left the folder. “Truth does not choose the headline.”

“Neither do contracts. They choose who may complain afterwards.”

After she left, Lin called. Deng’s orders now required recovery from either party. The EBRO had lost the plain truck near the festival storage lanes.

“He may take it from us if we find it,” Lin said.

“Then do not tell him first.”

“He still has Joel’s reports.”

Mei thought of her cousin. Joel no longer carried a phone he had not purchased himself. He had spent the morning making calls under the eyes of everyone he had misled.

“He has old reports,” she said.

By evening they knew Ingot had entered one of six rear bays used by festival contractors. They did not know which bay, which truck or which crew would move it on Saturday.

They needed a route strong enough to survive being reported.

On Mei’s passenger seat, the napkin bearing the Guaita logo carried a coffee ring. The owner had wrapped the unfinished sandwich before they left. Nobody had returned to collect it.

Chapter 27: Festa Major

Badalona searched for Ingot while preparing lunch for hundreds of people.

The two activities shared tables.

On Friday, flower frames occupied one warehouse, painted panels another, folding chairs a third. People carried food lists, procession hardware, extension leads and questions between units. Bells and rehearsal drums reached the industrial streets from the centre. Every movement had a purpose unrelated to Mei's case, which made unusual movement easier to see.

She told the neighbours enough truth.

A stolen computer had been moved under Llevant's name. It was dangerous because several companies wanted it, not because it would explode. Guaita might conceal it among event equipment during Saturday's road closures. Nobody should enter a locked bay, confront a driver or interfere with festival safety.

Then Joel told them the part that belonged to him.

He stood beside Llevant's open shutter without keys. Twelve people stayed. Others continued carrying frames and food because his confession did not cancel their work.

"A man called Rui said he represented Yulan product security," Joel began. "I gave him case temperatures, movement times and the names of people asking questions. I believed I was protecting equipment we had accepted. I did not verify him through Mei or the supplier contract."

The owner of unit four put down a bundle of cable. "You told him about my rear yard?"

"I told him the dark van crossed it on Sunday."

"You had no right."

"No."

"My nephew works nights. Did you give his name?"

Joel looked at the list he had made with Mei. "I said your nephew had seen the van. I did not give his telephone number. Rui found one anyway."

The owner called his nephew in front of everyone. He asked whether Rui or anyone from Yulan had contacted him. The nephew said a man had called Monday claiming to verify an alarm report. He had answered two questions and ended the call when asked which doors connected the units.

The strip of red paper Joel had pocketed on Sant Joan now covered a split in the beast's painted jaw.

"Why should we tell you anything now?" the woman repairing the panel asked.

"You should not tell me," Joel said. "Tell Mei, tell the police number on the wall, or keep it until they ask. I can identify which questions Rui used. I cannot make myself the person who collects the answers again."

An older driver asked whether Joel had been paid.

“No.”

“Then you were cheap. Not innocent.”

Joel accepted that too.

One neighbour left. Another asked whether Joel would still drive Llevant vehicles. Mei said not while the keys remained disputed.

“Then what do you want?” asked the owner of unit four.

“Memory. Which shutter opened, who borrowed a pallet jack, where people ate, which truck arrived clean and left dusty.”

An older wholesaler asked whether the stolen computer came from China. Mei said some of its manufacturing did and some of its disputed design did not.

“Then this is Chinese business,” he said.

“It became our business when they put our label on it.”

Mei asked each person about their own door and their own memory.

The search spread through ordinary relationships. A woman painting a fire beast’s damaged panel remembered a plain truck because it blocked her paint delivery. A volunteer assembling flower supports had seen two men replace its magnetic company sign. A restaurant worker recalled six late meals delivered to a rear bay whose tenant normally closed at eight.

No camera held the complete route. No person did either.

By Friday evening, three bays were eliminated: sound equipment, barriers and one empty room whose new lock had an ordinary explanation.

Three remained.

At the fourth bay, a contractor refused entry and threatened to call Guaita. Mei asked him to do it. He dialled, listened, and then claimed the call had failed. That bay moved higher on their list, but they still did not cross its shutter.

At the fifth, volunteers opened lighting cases in the lane and complained that the search delayed their safety test. Lin checked none of the electronics. The case dimensions were wrong. They helped close the lids and carried two stands back inside.

Through Friday evening the first day of the festa moved through streets beyond the estate. People returned carrying programmes, gossip and revised instructions. A procession route had changed around road works. One contractor would move lighting equipment closer to the seafront on Saturday evening.

At midnight, preparations continued under work lights. Mei’s mother portioned food for volunteers without allowing the investigation to reduce anyone’s share. Her father repaired a loose wheel on a flower cart and refused to discuss the false model identity while holding a spanner.

“Tomorrow,” he said. “Today this wheel is guilty.”

At 00:43, Joel stood beside unit two and looked towards the rear lane.

“I know which shutter,” he said.

Mei waited.

“The night they replaced case five, I was here. Sixteenth of July. Rui told me to expect a technician for the hot unit. The man showed me a card and I assumed Yulan. I opened unit two with my code and watched him take the real frame out through the rear loading door. Only later did I learn the card was Guaita’s, not Yulan’s. I heard a shutter across the lane after midnight. Not ours. Number seventeen.”

“Why did you never say?”

“I thought Rui had sent him. Guaita used the visit he arranged.”

Joel pressed both palms against the warm shutter. “If I had told you in July, would you have believed me?”

Mei considered the question instead of rewarding it with comfort. In July, Yulan was a difficult supplier, Rui a verified representative and an after-midnight inspection an inconvenience somebody else had accepted.

“I would have asked why you let them in,” she said.

“That is not belief.”

“No. But it might have been enough.”

Bay seventeen was one of the three remaining. Its current tenant supplied temporary lighting through a chain of subcontractors ending at Guaita. The plain truck had entered it Wednesday night. On Saturday, the tenant was scheduled to deliver two lighting cases and one unlisted equipment case to the seafront route.

The unlisted case matched Ingot’s dimensions.

She called the investigating officer who had received Arnau’s verified audit. She gave the physical chain: café, forklift marks, borrowed machine, meal delivery, night shutter, event manifest. He began the process for a search.

“How long?” she asked.

“Not before evening. Nobody signs fast on festa Saturday.”

The case was scheduled to move at nineteen.

Saturday began with matinades and bells. The estate heard them before it saw anyone. By ten, families and ceremonial groups moved towards the centre in clothes that made no concession to warehouse work. Flower carpets changed which streets could carry wheels. A volunteer argued with a driver about a corner that had been a road at breakfast and was now a pattern of petals nobody would step on willingly.

At half past two, the communal lunch filled the Rambla. Long tables, paper cloths, dishes arriving from more kitchens than any one family owned. Mei’s mother sent two trays and did not go. Chen went, ate standing, came back with oil on his shirt and the news that a lighting contractor had asked a waiter whether the industrial estate still had a rear lane open after six.

“What did the waiter say?” Mei asked.

“That he served lunch, not traffic.”

Later, sardanes claimed another street Guaita had treated as a line on a map.

At 18:41, bay seventeen opened.

The message reached Mei at the edge of the sardana gathering.

“Photograph the shutter and nothing inside,” she told the neighbour watching the rear lane. “Then leave.”

“The case is visible.”

“You are not evidence-proof. Leave.”

He left. The photograph showed the opening time, part of the black case and no person close enough to be accused of trespass.

A Guaita van entered. The grey EBRO stopped two streets away.

Lin waited with the Flipper in a delivery car that did not belong to either side.

The unlisted black case rolled towards the van.
Around them, streets were already closing for the fire procession that would end at the sea.

Chapter 28: The Fire Route

At 19:06, Guaita discovered that a festival route was not a traffic route.

The van left bay seventeen with Ingot listed as temporary lighting control. It travelled six blocks before a flower carpet closed one street and metal barriers closed the next. Navigation continued to recommend a turn occupied by musicians, families and volunteers carrying tables from the communal lunch.

The driver stopped beside the seafront approach.

Deng's grey EBRO stopped behind it.

The Guaita driver sounded the horn once. Nobody moved. A volunteer carrying a bundle of metal barrier feet pointed at the sign prohibiting vehicles after eighteen hundred. The driver displayed an incident credential through the glass. The volunteer fetched a marshal, who fetched the route coordinator, who called the number printed on the credential instead of accepting the urgency implied by its colours.

The number answered at Guaita.

The coordinator asked for the municipal incident reference. The driver had a regional continuity reference. Each man repeated his number twice. Neither number gave a vehicle permission to cross a fire route full of people.

Behind them, a rubbish truck turned into the street and completed the trap.

Neither vehicle could reverse. The street had filled with people moving towards the Bany de Bèsties. Fire crews, marshals and performers controlled the protected route. Their safety plan outranked every private incident credential Guaita presented.

Lin watched from the public side of the barriers.

She wore ordinary clothes and carried the Flipper in its black pouch. Mei's neighbours knew her face and her task. They did not know how Ingot worked. They knew she needed five minutes beside the case and that nobody was to enter the pyrotechnic safety space for her.

Guaita unloaded the black case onto a wheeled event trolley. Moving it by hand through the public lane offered their only route around the closure.

The trolley had small hard wheels designed for a level loading floor. The first paving seam stopped it. The driver lifted the front while the second contractor pushed. The case tilted far enough for its transport monitor to chirp.

Lin heard the warning through the crowd.

She did not need the Flipper to invent an opportunity. Guaita's own hurry supplied one.

Marc Escudé walked beside it.

He saw Lin before she reached them.

"The instrument is in incident custody," he said.

“The transport monitor shows unsafe state.”

“You cannot see its monitor.”

Lin held up the Flipper. “Exactly.”

The case had remained in standby since Pedralbes. Without a service check, Guaita could not know whether heat inside the van had affected coolant pressure or memory state. Marc understood the risk. He had stood in the annex doorway when Lin explained it. He also understood that a damaged Ingot had no buyer.

“Two minutes,” he said.

“Five. Standby took two. This takes longer.”

“Three.”

“Open the flap before you agree to time you do not control.”

Marc looked towards the route coordinator. The credential call had reached a second Guaita desk and produced no municipal reference. The trolley could not remain in the narrowing public lane.

He opened the service flap while the other contractor argued with a marshal about crossing the route. Lin connected her spare maintenance lead. Over the lead, the Flipper read Ingot’s service port and showed transport temperature above preference but below damage.

She selected the routine Yulan’s service menu called safe mode. It was not the transport standby she had set in Pedralbes. Standby sealed the session key so the work could resume on another fabric. This decommissioned the module: it stopped expert prefetch and destroyed the session key itself.

Without that key, the infrastructure checkpoint and the model state Guaita had carried across Catalonia became unreadable. The command did not erase the public model weights or damage the module. Whoever next used Ingot would need it recommissioned by an enrolled engineer, which meant Lin, or by Yulan’s factory, which meant Yulan admitting the device existed.

Progress reached sixty per cent.

The screen offered no dramatic countdown, only storage groups changing from amber to green. Lin checked transport pressure with her free hand and kept the lead loose enough to disconnect without damaging the port. Around her, people asked one another what the black case controlled. Nobody answered. A boy on his father’s shoulders decided it contained fireworks and announced this as fact.

“Lin,” Deng said behind her.

He had left the EBRO and reached the public side of the barrier. His recovery order could be fulfilled by taking three steps, removing Marc’s hand and claiming the module. Instead he watched her screen.

“If you interrupt this, Yulan may receive damaged hardware,” she said.

“If I do not, Yulan receives hardware it cannot demonstrate.”

“That is the point.”

Deng looked at the crowd, the phones and the route marshals. “No. The point is that you make me choose in public.”

He did not step forward.

Marc looked at the screen. “That is not a transport check.”

“It is now.”

He reached for the lead and stopped with his fingers a hand’s width from it.

A half-written key store on a single-slot prototype. He had heard the sentence in Pedralbes. Pull the cable at sixty per cent and Guaita delivered a brick to a buyer who had paid for an instrument. Leave it and Guaita delivered a module that needed its authors.

Lin turned her body between him and the pouch. No strike, no theatrical struggle. Around them, hundreds of phones waited to record whatever he chose.

Progress reached one hundred.

Ingot entered safe mode.

Lin disconnected the Flipper.

Marc closed the flap. His thumb passed once over the connector pins before anger could make him careless.

The route coordinator ended his call with the second Guaita desk and returned with a municipal police officer. Under the festival safety plan, he said, nothing with wheels crossed the fire route until it reopened after the bany. Not the van, not the EBRO, not the trolley. The officer wrote both registrations in her notebook, asked Marc for the incident reference and wrote down the regional number he gave her as well. Then she put the case itself on hold in place under the plan, in writing, and told Marc plainly that only the Mossos could seize it. She could only stop it moving.

At 19:40 a Guaita flatbed tried the closure two streets north. A volunteer and a patrol car turned it back at the barrier. At 20:20 Marc tried the beach service ramp with the trolley and both contractors. A pyrotechnic marshal stopped them at the edge of the safety zone, where the night's powder was already staged, and the municipal officer walked them back. Marc did not argue with her. He had read enough safety plans to know which one outranked his.

Mei's call reached the investigating officer again at half past eight. The search authorization for bay seventeen was signed before nine and extended to the case in the street. The officers who would execute it had to reach the seafront through the same closures as everyone else. The plan holding Guaita held them too, and they did not ask for an exception through a crowd walking towards live fire.

The light went. Lin sat with two of Mei's neighbours at a café table on the public side, where she could see the trolley and nobody had to stand guard over it.

At half past nine, drums began beyond the barriers.

The first fire performers moved into their regulated space wearing protective clothing. Marshals pushed spectators back. Sparks rose only inside the cleared route. Lin stayed outside it, moving with families as the public lane narrowed.

Each drum rhythm carried an instruction: movement, hold, emergency. Marshals watched clothing, wind and distance. Parents lifted scarves over children's hair. People who wanted the closest view still yielded when the rope advanced.

Lin moved with the families towards the side street. Marc tried to cross on the movement rhythm. A marshal stopped him on the next beat, and he turned back to find another way round.

"Stop her," he told a Guaita contractor.

The contractor reached the rope. A marshal sent him back without caring which company issued his badge.

Smoke drifted over the spectators after the first group passed. Drums made speech local. People danced in place, covered children's ears, adjusted scarves and goggles. Mei's neighbours did not form a wall. One handed Lin a bottle of water. Another told her which public side street

remained open. A third moved away because helping had never been compulsory.

Lin followed the permitted crowd flow.

Behind her, the Guaita van and Deng's EBRO remained trapped nose to tail. Ingot sat on its trolley between them, useless for Atlas and visible to anyone who knew which cloned seal to photograph.

Marc reached the side street after Lin. He had lost his badge somewhere in the crowd or removed it himself.

"You have made the module unsaleable," he said.

"No. I made it require its authors."

"Yulan will restore it."

"Then Yulan must admit what it is."

"And if the police take it?"

"Then you will have to explain why your custody route ends inside a festival."

Marc came close enough that Lin could see soot caught in the moisture along his hairline. "You think a public record makes people safe. It makes them available to whoever tells the first convincing story."

"That is why we left more than one record."

He looked past her. Mei's neighbours held no coordinated line and wore no shared symbol. One spoke to a marshal. One photographed the cloned seal. One had already left for dinner.

Another burst of regulated sparks lit the smoke behind him. Marc looked back.

A marshal lifted the public rope to release one section of spectators towards the sea. Lin passed beneath it with them. When the rope came down, Marc was still on the other side.

Chapter 29: Bany de Bèsties

At 22:00, drums reached the sea before the beasts did.

The first rhythm travelled along the maritime promenade from Platja dels Pescadors, felt through the paving before it separated from the crowd. Smoke carried the dry mineral smell of spent powder and the sweeter trace of singed costume cloth. Then sparks cleared the heads nearest the safety line and the first fire beast emerged behind them, moving towards Pont d'en Botifarreta.

Mei stood outside the safety line with Arnau, Júlia and Oriol.

Oriol wore a hospital wristband he had refused to remove and carried no equipment. He should have been resting. He said rest was an activity for people whose employer had not tried to sell a country.

He had apologized to Mei for putting the collection order into Guaita's hands. She had told him an apology was not a warehouse repair and asked him to remain available for every police question. Forgiveness had not been scheduled.

The black Ingot case remained on its trolley beside the trapped Guaita van. Marc had returned to it. Two contractors tried to negotiate a path through closures that would not reopen until after the beasts reached the water.

Deng sat in the grey EBRO behind them.

Police were coming with the search authorization signed that evening. The safety plan that had held Guaita in place since seven held the patrol at the same closures. Their arrival would be slower than the investigation and more legitimate than everyone already present.

Salvador Reixac reached the case first on foot.

He wore no incident vest. Heat had darkened his shirt at the collar, the first visible disorder Mei had seen in him.

"Senyora Zhou," he said. "This can still end without further harm to Llevant."

"You have used our name on three false shipments."

"A contractor used a customer profile beyond scope. Clara's agreement corrects that."

"Your correction requires silence."

Reixac took Clara's agreement from a clear sleeve. The page already carried Llevant's address, the three disputed shipment numbers and an empty line for Mei.

Oriol leaned far enough to read it. "You prepared the ending before finding the box."

Reixac looked at his former producer. "You falsified a capture and disappeared under a live-event credential."

"Put it in my performance review."

The first beasts passed behind them. Fire outlined metal and painted forms. The crowd moved with the marshals, not with the argument.

A drum group passed close enough to erase speech. Reixac waited instead of raising his voice. Mei watched him count the interval between groups and resume exactly when conversation became possible. Even here he searched for the operating rhythm and placed himself inside it.

"The public audit has already named Guaita," Mei said. "Why move the module?"

Reixac slid the agreement back into its sleeve. "Because deletion did not make the capability impossible."

"It made your choice public," Arnau said.

Reixac did not glance at the police lights approaching along the promenade. He was still waiting for Mei to recognize his logic as inevitable.

Reixac signalled Marc to take the trolley.

Deng drove the EBRO forward half a metre.

Its bumper blocked the narrow gap between the Guaita van and a barrier. He stopped without touching either. Guaita could not move Ingot forward or return it to the van.

Deng got out.

He left the driver's door open. The dashboard continued showing the route on which he had followed Guaita across Catalonia. Yulan could later call the movement an approved recovery. The open door showed the simpler truth: one employee, one car, one decision not yet made.

"The module is Yulan property," he said.

"Your company denies the product exists," Reixac replied.

"Not my company. My instruction."

He looked at Lin, who had rejoined the public crowd farther along the route. Recovery orders required Deng to take Ingot from whoever held it. He could wheel the case to the EBRO now and replace one private custody claim with another.

Instead, he removed the EBRO key and placed it on the roof.

"Nobody moves it until police arrive," he said.

"Your instruction is to recover it," Lin said from beyond the barrier.

"My instruction assumes recovery ends uncertainty."

"It ends your employment if you refuse."

"Employment is already uncertain."

Reixac studied him. "You followed them, threatened witnesses and used a supplier's employee as an informant. This is where you discover ethics?"

"No," Deng said. "This is where witnesses discover me."

He turned so the nearest phones could see his face.

Phones recorded the vehicles, the case and Reixac. More important, the people who had seen pieces of the week began, one by one, to be heard.

The café owner described the unfinished sandwich. The forklift driver described his bent right fork. The restaurant worker named the six meals delivered after midnight. The woman with the paint order identified the truck's changed magnetic sign. Joel described Rui's calls and his own reports without asking to be forgiven first.

Their accounts reached the investigating officer by phone, through the statements Mei's neighbours had taken down during the evening and, from the two who lived on the seafront, face to face.

No central camera index owned the chain. Each witness held one part and remained available to disagree with the others.

They did disagree. The café owner remembered two yellow vests; the forklift driver thought one might have been grey and had asked for his doubt to be written down. The meal order contained six portions, but the restaurant worker saw only four people. Joel placed Rui's first call on a Tuesday until Mei showed him the warehouse rota and he corrected it to Wednesday.

The officer wrote each uncertainty on a separate line.

Mei's phone vibrated.

A university archive in Hsinchu had published a short checksum of a package floorplan file from its own deposit, stamped December 2019, together with the contributor page Hsu and Lin had signed that day. Two reviewers the archive named, neither employed by Yulan nor by Guaita, had compared it with the reference digest Ingot's service record cites for its own floorplan, which Lin released. They matched. The publication revealed no design, memory schedule or manufacturing path.

It did not prove who had invented what. It proved that the design file Ingot's service record cites had existed in December 2019 under a signed record naming more than one author.

Yulan could no longer present a purely internal invention without explaining that record. Guaita could not claim its incident recovery had acquired an ownerless prototype. Any supervised custody would have to include Hsu's evidence and Lin's witnessed performance record.

Lin read the publication and closed her eyes.

"You asked her to wait?" Mei said.

"Yes."

"She did not."

"No."

Lin sounded relieved.

Police reached the blocked vehicles at 22:31. They checked the cloned Llevant seal against Mei's evidence photographs, recorded the case in place and separated the custody claims before moving anything. Guaita objected. Deng identified himself and requested counsel. Nobody vanished into the festival.

The officers did not open Ingot beside the crowd. They photographed every face of the case, checked the wheels and service flap for fresh damage, and placed their own numbered seals across both latches. One officer read each number aloud while another recorded it. Mei compared the cloned customer label with her originals and dictated the differences in Catalan; Lin repeated the technical terms in English for the foreign ownership submissions. Neither translation replaced the other.

When the evidence vehicle arrived, it could not reach the trolley. Four officers carried the case through the same public gap Guaita had failed to use. The weight forced them to stop once. The senior officer marked the stop in the movement log and initialled it before the case moved again.

Then the officer asked Mei why she had waited before reporting bay seventeen.

"I did report it," she said. "To the officer assigned to the cloned shipment."

"You also organized private observation."

"We asked people to remember their own streets. Nobody entered the bay. Nobody touched the case."

“And the service device?”

Lin presented the Flipper in its pouch, with Guaita’s signed departure photograph from Pedralbes and Pau’s photograph from the forklift. She did not explain the application beside a public crowd. The officer sealed the pouch separately and recorded Lin’s claim that it contained a safety control, not a key to the model.

Reixac watched each item acquire official custody. He began to tell Arnau what the police record would fail to see.

The officer held up one hand. “You can put it in your statement. Not beside my trolley.”

Reixac stopped. Arnau did too. For once, neither man received the last word.

The beasts reached the water.

After the fire procession, participants carried their forms into the Mediterranean surrounded by controlled flame. The sea accepted sparks and reflected them without becoming cool. Crowds shouted from the promenade. Children who had hidden from the noise earlier pushed forward to see.

The figures entered slowly, handlers testing each step against sand and water while fire continued around them. Salt water darkened costumes at the knees. Sparks died where they landed and survived where the wind carried them back towards the route. Crews watched both directions.

Mei had seen versions of the bany before, first as a child held above the crowd, later as a teenager pretending she attended only because friends did, then after years away as something she had not realized she missed. She watched an older handler place a younger pair of hands on the correct bar before allowing the beast into deeper water.

Reixac stood beside the police cordon, visible in dozens of ordinary recordings. Ingot remained closed in safe mode.

The final beast entered the sea.

Epilogue: After the Fire

Llevant was cleared at 09:12 on Sunday morning by a statement that named it seven times.

The first paragraph said the company had no role in the unauthorized movement of eclipse equipment. The second described its location in Badalona Sud, its Chinese-Catalan ownership and the categories of goods it imported. The third praised its cooperation.

Mei read the statement in the warehouse office while her father burnt toast on a hot plate below. The toaster had failed during the outage, and Chen refused to discard it before proving every setting was bad.

"Cleared," he said when she came down.

"Yes."

"Then why do I know less than yesterday?"

The four ordinary Yulan boxes ran again in the systems room. Small Shanhai-Coder processed product descriptions and flagged uncertain translations. It had returned to kettles, lamps and warranty claims without resentment. Mei kept the evidence harness Júlia built. Every answer still had to show its source.

At 09:26, Pilar Forn arrived carrying an empty radio carton and the council order Guaita had held since the eclipse week.

"They released it at eight fifty-five," she said. "My temporary staff began at nine. One has spent the first hour explaining eclipse channels to me because I refused to admit I had forgotten them."

The unconditional correction from Clara Reixac was clipped to the order. It said the copied Llevant profile had entered Guaita's contractor system without Llevant's knowledge. The same sentence could have left the Girona table before Mei signed anything. It had waited until witnesses made silence worthless.

Pilar looked at the official statement on Mei's screen. "They cleared you by describing you."

"Seven times."

"Good advertising. Expensive method."

She took the radios and left two coffees behind in exchange, a transaction neither company needed to classify.

On the battery television, now connected to the wall again, Berta presented the morning eclipse retrospective without Oriol. He was asleep in hospital after a four-hour statement. She showed totality, smoke, emergency crews and the crowds who never saw the Sun. She did not show the false identity Shanhai had assigned to Chen.

A news line beneath her supplied the institutional consequences too early to call outcomes. Ingot had entered supervised research custody under the investigating court. Yulan, Lin and Hsu had submitted competing authorship records. Guaita's incident claim established possession dur-

ing the theft, not ownership. Safe mode held while an independent panel was assembled.

Reixac had not been arrested. Lenticular suspended him and claimed its governance had worked because company systems produced part of the audit. Institut Llum suspended Marc's access after his statement described valid incident authority but failed to explain how he knew Ingot's computation when the custody order did not name the architecture. The two contractors who had held Oriol were charged over his detention. The documented instruction chain stopped at their supervisor, two levels below Reixac.

Mei's phone displayed one message from Leïla.

Sami agreed to meet. His sister and lawyer will be present. I am bringing a written account and no device.

The deleted people index had taken Leïla's best route to Karim. She still had the Narthex contract, the Room Zero query log and the canary record showing that Vasseur's people queried the false locker after denying any commercial delivery. It was a weaker case. It required people to testify about their own decisions.

Mei wrote back only: **Tell him the risk before asking for anything.**

Arnau sat at Llevant's packing table with coffee and the expression of a man whose employment status had become a meeting scheduled for Monday.

The ambulance they had never identified remained in his traffic record. No inquiry had established whether it reached the crossing late, or whether the corridor had changed anything. The uncertainty would attend Monday's meeting with him.

"Atlas is gone," he said.

Júlia looked up from the public eclipse archive. "The complete index is gone."

The archive contained millions of public images, contribution records, weather observations and timing measurements. Schools, observatories, broadcasters, municipalities and viewers had released them for legitimate study. Arnau's verified audit explained enough of Antumbra's method for researchers to detect similar abuse. It also explained enough for a patient graduate student to build a crude cousin.

Not next week. Not with Atlas's access. But the method no longer lived in one room or one module. It lived in the archive with the weather observations and school camera feeds.

"Should we have withheld the method?" Arnau asked.

"Then only Guaita would know it," Júlia replied.

"Now everyone can."

"Not everyone will. That is not the same comfort."

Mei carried the recovered red ledger from the office. Police had found it in bay seventeen beneath old Guaita transport forms. Its handwritten corrections had helped prove the physical serial and cloned profile. Investigators requested the entire book for the final case file.

She had copied the relevant Yulan page.

She did not surrender the rest.

The ledger also contained damaged cartons accepted for neighbours, late returns, temporary storage favours and corrections whose meaning belonged to people who had trusted Llevant with context. None proved Atlas. All could place the estate on new maps.

Mei sealed the single copied page in an evidence envelope and put the red book back on its shelf.

“That is incomplete observability,” Arnau said.

“Yes.”

He waited for her to defend it.

She did not need to. He nodded.

Before lunch they returned to Walden 7.

Police had released the flat after photographing the watch, the locks and the cleaner residue. Nothing prevented them from sleeping there except knowledge. The building’s courtyards rose around them in blue and green, bridges carrying Sunday movement from one side to another. Laundry, plants, a child’s scooter, two people disagreeing about where a folding table belonged after the festa.

Carme met them outside her door with Arnau’s equipment case.

“You left this at my house,” she said.

“I did not.”

“Then a polite man did. He said police had cleared it. I told him police know my telephone number. He left.”

Arnau did not touch the case.

Mei photographed it and called the investigating officer. Carme waited until the call ended.

“Can I have my balcony back now?” she asked.

“Yes,” Mei said.

“Good. Escapes are hard on the geraniums.”

Their flat looked smaller after strangers had measured it with intention. Arnau’s dive watch remained on the bedside table. The investigation had found no tracker, transmitter or chemical marker. Whoever returned it had relied on suspicion to do the continuing work.

Arnau picked it up.

“You are sure?” Mei asked.

“No.”

He put it on anyway.

They opened the windows. Hot air crossed the flat but did not cool it. Voices from several courtyards entered at once, impossible to assign to one apartment. The building kept some ownership ambiguous by design.

In Badalona, volunteers cleaned festival materials and swept the remains of flower work from transport frames. The deliberate fire had ended at the sea. The drought fires in the south were under control but not yet extinguished. Smoke still softened the horizon.

Joel helped a neighbour repair a shutter. People spoke to him differently now. They still spoke.

One woman crossed the service lane carrying folded tables. Halfway across, she looked up at a camera above a warehouse door.

The camera had been there for years. She had passed beneath it every working day.

Now she noticed where it pointed.

She moved one step out of its view before continuing.

Behind the Technology and Places

The eclipse, its late-evening geometry over Spain, and the intense public interest surrounding it are real. The novel's central surveillance index is not.

Real camera systems are fragmented. Ownership, access, image quality, clocks, retention, and legal authority differ. The story imagines software that uses a predictable natural change in light to correlate those fragments at a scale and speed that do not exist as a single real Catalan system.

The radio and traffic-control scenes describe fictional, event-specific systems. They omit frequencies, identifiers, message formats, tool settings and repeatable attack steps. No real traffic network is claimed to work as depicted.

The two AI assistants are fictional. Their contrast reflects a real deployment difference: a hosted service can apply centralized safeguards and log requests, while downloadable model weights can run locally under controls chosen by the operator. Neither arrangement guarantees correctness, authorization, or safety. In the story, AI proposes interpretations and code; humans verify the evidence and remain responsible for every decision.

Public service metadata can disclose that a system exists, when it answered and what identity it presented without exposing its pictures or controls. Reused web certificates can suggest shared administration, but do not prove that two records describe the same device or location. The novel turns those weak associations into clues only after people test them against shipping practice, custody records and physical equipment.

The eclipse-clock method is fictional at the scale depicted. In principle, a widely observed change in light can provide a common event against which imperfect camera clocks are compared. The resulting corrections would remain estimates, not a perfect national timeline. Likewise, a model's confidence figure is not proof: Shanhai's plausible but false location comes from treating a customer-account code as geography.

Ingot and Yulan Microdevices are entirely fictional. Real sparse mixture-of-experts models can contain hundreds of billions or trillions of stored parameters while activating only part of the model for each token. This creates opportunities for quantization, expert placement, and memory optimization. It does not currently make a frontier model fit cheaply into one visiting research module as depicted here.

The Ingot connection to MareNostrum, the experimental fabric, visiting programme, access procedures, staff, and workloads are invented. Nothing in the story describes the real machine's security or configuration.

Real organizations and landmarks appear as setting. The conspirators, hidden rooms, compromised systems, and institutional conduct are invented.

Architecture and Place

The buildings in this novel are not backgrounds. Each proposes a different answer to the same question as Atlas: what happens when many private lives are joined by one structure?

Walden 7. Mei and Arnau's home is a real residential complex in Sant Just Desvern, completed in 1975 by Ricardo Bofill Taller de Arquitectura. Its apartments were conceived as combinations of cells rather than isolated conventional flats. Courtyards, bridges, stairs, balconies, and vertical routes turn a large building into a small city. That geometry gives the novel both refuge and uncertainty: a person may be visible from many directions without any observer possessing the whole view. The apartment and residents in the story are fictional, and no route through the building is described in a way that could be followed. Walden 7 is a home, not a public thriller location, and visitors should respect its privacy.

Torre Girona and MareNostrum. For almost two decades Barcelona Supercomputing Center housed its MareNostrum supercomputers, from the first to MareNostrum 4, inside the deconsecrated Torre Girona chapel. MareNostrum 5 now runs in the centre's adjacent building, and since 2025 the chapel has hosted BSC's quantum computers, connected to MareNostrum 5. Glass allows the old stone volume and the machines to remain visible together. The contrast is dramatic, but it is not a hidden contradiction: both architectures organize a community around questions larger than one room. Institut Llum, its annex, its staff, and every access or security procedure in the novel are invented.

The Dalí Theatre-Museum. In Figueres, the museum's dome and Mae West Room make viewpoint part of the work. Separate objects in the Mae West installation assemble into a face only from the intended position. The novel borrows that principle, not the museum's operations: Oriol's false room becomes convincing because one camera occupies the place from which its surfaces agree. Quel, the night visit, the chase, and the hidden card are fictional.

Gaudí's Barcelona. La Pedrera appears briefly as a reminder that curves are not the absence of rules. Structure, ventilation, light, and load make apparent fantasy habitable. The observation belongs to Júlia, but the larger idea runs through the book: systems look magical when their constraints are hidden.

Badalona and the Festa Major. Llevant Import and its warehouse are invented. The city, its seafront and its working districts are real; the August festa as staged here is a composite (see the factual anchors below). The Bany de Bèsties places regulated fire, drums, marshals, performers, spectators, and the sea inside one shared route. In the novel, that public safety rhythm outlasts Guaita's private credentials. The equipment pursuit and police action are fictional.

Vineyards, dry ground, and the western horizon. The Penedès vineyards and the southern Catalan landscape are not interchangeable scenery. Rows, access tracks, water points, cleared mar-

gins, wind, and cured grass decide how people and fire move. Marta's property and the principal southern viewing site are invented composites. The risk created when hot vehicles enter dry vegetation is not.

The broadcast city. 3Cat's studios in Sant Joan Despí are real. Lenticular, Guaita, their contribution centre, and the internal rooms and systems described in the novel are fictional. So is their ownership. Guaita is not a Lenticular subcontractor but a separate company held privately by the man who runs both. All presenters, producers, editorial decisions, instructions, and on-air incidents involving 3Cat in the novel are fictional. Broadcast infrastructure is shown as a chain of human agreements, not as one master control room, because that fragmentation is central to both the plot and the truth it distorts.

Factual Anchors

The eclipse. On 12 August 2026 a total solar eclipse crossed Spain near sunset. In Catalonia, full totality was available only in the south and west of the territory. Barcelona lay just outside the path of totality: it saw an extremely deep partial eclipse, with the Sun almost, but never completely, covered. The cover art brings a total eclipse above the Barcelona skyline as an artistic interpretation, not a literal view of the event from the city. The low Sun made an unobstructed western horizon essential.

The other sky. A total eclipse near sunset removes the usual bright-planet display. Mercury and Jupiter lay west of the eclipsed Sun and therefore very low below it, out of practical reach from Catalonia. Venus, approaching its greatest eastern elongation on 14 August, stood brilliant and well up in the south-west, and was the one reliable planet of the totality. Arcturus, Spica and the Summer Triangle were available to anyone who looked away from the corona. The Perseids' best observing window followed in the early hours of 13 August, under a new Moon, with the shower already active late on eclipse night.

The Clásico and the Tour. FC Barcelona hosted Real Madrid at Spotify Camp Nou on 10 May 2026 and won 2-0. The nearby technical rehearsal is fictional. The Tour de France began in Barcelona on 4 July; its third stage left Granollers for Les Angles on 6 July. Oriol's Figueres return docket and all Guaita involvement are invented.

Bany de Bèsties. The August festa in this novel is a fictional composite, using real Badalona waterfront places and fire-beast traditions associated with Catalan festival culture. The route from Platja dels Pescadors towards Pont d'en Botifarreta, the equipment chase and the police action are invented. Readers should not treat the procession, date or timetable as an official 2026 programme.

MareNostrum. Barcelona Supercomputing Center housed MareNostrum 1 to 4 inside the deconsecrated Torre Girona chapel. MareNostrum 5 operates in the adjacent BSC building, and the chapel now hosts the centre's quantum computers. The fictional Institut Llum, projects, staff, and events in this novel are invented.

Semiconductor controls. Extreme-ultraviolet lithography became central to leading-edge chip-making during the late 2010s. From October 2022 onwards, the United States repeatedly changed controls and licensing policy for specified advanced-computing chips, semiconductor equipment, supercomputer uses, and related activities involving the PRC. Separately, and under its own authority, the Netherlands introduced national authorization requirements for specified advanced semiconductor-manufacturing equipment in September 2023 and expanded them in September 2024 and April 2025. These regimes continued to evolve after the fictional 2019 events depicted in the interlude. Ingot is an invented architectural response, not a claim about an undisclosed real chip.

Heat and sea. Catalan summers can combine severe inland heat, hot nights, wildfire danger, and unusually warm Mediterranean water. Exact temperatures in the story are fictional observations for its characters, not historical claims.

Fictional boundaries. No hidden facility, compromised system, conspiracy, or wrongdoing is attributed to the owners, residents, employees, or staff of any real place or organization named in this book.

About the Author

Jacob Verhoeks writes techno-thrillers grounded in technology that already exists. He has three decades of experience in IT, from on-premises infrastructure to cloud platforms, working around the world. His interests include open source, programming, ethical hacking, cloud systems and artificial intelligence. His fiction draws on public research, documented incidents and the texture of engineering: the compromises, assumptions and small human decisions inside complex systems.

His novels are works of fiction. Characters, companies, systems, incidents and conspiracies are invented or fictional composites. Real places, public technologies and documented events may provide setting or context.